On Another's Sorrow

Contents

Reckoning Time . . . 3
The "Storm" Downpours . . . 8
Temporary Dispatch . . . 8
Homecoming Day . . . 9
Getting Worse . . . 13
Escape Plan . . . 14
Homecoming Day . . . 18
Perfect Exchange . . . 19
The Cube Researchers . . . 19
Quantifying Pain . . . 23
Stone Doves . . . 24
Burned Feathers . . . 28
Low on Supplies . . . 33
The Alumni . . . 33
Bumpy Roads . . . 38
Temporary Product . . . 42
Rules Are Rules . . . 42
The Everlasting Chaos . . . 47
Emergency Measures . . . 48
"New Faces, Old Friends" . . . 53
A Hard Choice . . . 54
Whisper of Flowers . . . 60
Secret Communication . . . 60
The Shapeshifter . . . 60
Thorny Thicket . . . 66
An Unexpected Conversation . . . 72
Disagreement . . . 72
Vacuum of Arcanum . . . 73
Rational Passion . . . 78
Behind the Door . . . 78
Snow Blindness · 1/2 . . . 82
Competitive Business . . . 84

Snow Blindness · 2/2 . . . 85
The Hope in Her Heart . . . 85
Song of the Black Sheep . . . 89
The Killing Board . . . 92
Protection Amulet . . . 93
A Peek into Fate . . . 95
The White Tower . . . 100
Assembly . . . 105
Blame Game . . . 105
Wishing for Peace . . . 105
Pure White Folder . . . 109
Peace and Loss . . . 109
Her Reward . . . 115
Memorial Service . . . 118
Ambush Strategy . . . 118
The Legendary Hermitage . . . 119
Riposte . . . 125
A Loss of Civilization . . . 125

Reckoning Time

13TH-01

On Another's Sorrow

Reckoning Time

Countdown to the "Storm"

Courtroom

Special Tribunal Officer: Order, order.

The gavel strikes with perfect momentum, not overly dramatic, but enough to serve as a warning.

Creius: ...

Creius: The commotion from the jury box yields to a penetrating silence.

Special Tribunal Officer: Once again, Mr. Creius, this proceeding is not an "interrogation." But you are obligated to respond to the questions put forth to you by this tribunal.

Special Tribunal Officer: Now, please give a full account of your unsanctioned actions proceeding from October 1st, 1920 onward, following the tenth "Storm."

Special Tribunal Officer: You are reminded that your testimony must be complete, truthful, and without omission. Our time is limited.

Creius: Understood, Your Honor.

Foundation officers and staff watch as he looks down at his prepared statement and begins to read.

Creius: On October 1st, 1920, I issued an unsanctioned order to Sergeant Yermolai, a member of my squad, directing him to carry out a mission on the Western Front in Europe.

Creius: In addition, during my tenure as head of security in the safe zone, I instituted a "frontline contingency plan" without prior authorization from the Joint Committee.

Creius: Following that, I took advantage of the policy approved by the Committee in December—the *Resolution on the Expansion of Admitted Persons*—and issued admission licenses far exceeding my allowance under the regulations.

The tribunal officer stares right past Creius, looking instead at the representative of the Hawks.

Irinei: ...

Irinei maintains a stern expression.

Special Tribunal Officer: Then you admit to acting beyond the regulations of this policy in order to distribute these licenses, most of which were issued to military-related individuals. Would you care to explain why?

Creius: I believed the Foundation would need them.

Special Tribunal Officer: Elucidate, please.

Creius: All this time, the Foundation has been sheltering only a small number of core personnel from each era. We've had to rebuild our ranks from the top down after every "Storm."

Creius: I don't doubt we had our reasons. We sheltered only the best of the best. After all, a farmer sets aside their most productive seeds to survive a coming flood.

Creius: But we're fighting a war out there. I hardly think there's any need to "elucidate" how this policy has kept us on the back foot. We're scrambling.

Special Tribunal Officer: Irrespective of our shortages, you can't possibly claim these people you've taken in are fitting candidates. They aren't qualified specialists; they're soldiers. The only reason they're fighting for us is to protect themselves from Manus Vindictae.

Special Tribunal Officer: How do you intend to ensure their continued cooperation after the "Storm" takes us to a different era?

Creius: We tell them what they're fighting for.

Creius: Every man and woman that fought in those trenches has already come to terms with the idea that they may never see their home again, all for the sake of a senseless war without any hope of an end. What better qualifications could we ask for?

Special Tribunal Officer: Would you state that as a matter of fact, or as your opinion?

Creius: I speak from my own experience, Your Honor.

Creius: Every one of us here has been snatched from our eras. We've all lost homes and loved ones to the "Storm."

Special Tribunal Officer: ...

Creius: But the Foundation saved us and gave us a reason to fight, not for vengeance but for the future itself.

Creius: We are the lucky few who benefited from the Foundation's old policy. I only aim to give that chance to more people. Expanding our numbers will not change our goals. We can save more people, and I believe we must.

Creius: Besides that, the truth of the "Storm" will help persuade them—to say nothing of Manus Vindictae. Just think about how many they've already driven to our side.

The tribunal officer organizes her files—an excuse for a brief pause.

Special Tribunal Officer: You've made your point. Now let's turn to the matter of your use of tracking serum on a member of your squad.

Special Tribunal Officer: First, please provide a factual account of the events.

Yermolai: I'll be keeping tabs on her from now on, Marsha. Even got a tracking serum—Creius's order.

Marsha: "Tracking serum"?

Merel: I-I won't run again. Trust me, I swear!

???: Mandrake extract taking effect. Subject calmed.

???: Don't sweat it. Her vitals are fine.

???: Give us the room, will you? We don't need any help with the injection.

Merel: ...!

The elevator's doors open, freeing Merel from its cold, silvery walls.

Vertin: Is there something wrong, Merel?

Merel: I ... I'm fine. Let's go, Ms. Timekeeper.

Vertin: Please, call me Vertin.

Merel: Yes, Ms. Vertin.

Vertin: Just Vertin is fine.

Merel: Oh, er, right. Vertin.

Her voice drifts downward as she stows away her ID card and copy of *Visitor Guidance*—already on its umpteenth edition. When the elevator comes to a stop, she seems only too eager to hop forward and out.

Hallway, Rehab Center

Merel: Ward 1119. Ah, this way.

She leads them through the Rehabilitation Center's halls. Before long, they arrive outside Ward 1119's door.

Merel: Marsha, are you in there? It's me, Merel, and M—Vertin's with me too.

Marsha: Merel? Please, come on in.

Ward, Rehab Center

Striking scarlet hair stands out against the soft, white pillow beneath Marsha's head. She looks out from her sickbed through the nearby window.

Vertin: It's good to see you again, Marsha.

Merel: Oh, you're looking much better!

Marsha: Hah. The doctor says I only look so rosy-cheeked because my hair is red.

Marsha: I'm not even allowed to stand up. And I was given strict instructions not to use my arcane skills.

Marsha: I wish I could at least get out of this bed, but I understand that would probably just make me a pain in the neck for the doctor.

Merel: Uh, best just to stay where you are, then. How are you really feeling, though? Inside, I mean.

Marsha: I believe I've fully recovered. The last of the fear I accumulated during Charon's surgery was released three days ago.

Marsha: But Ms. Mesmer is afraid that it might have a long-term effect on my mental state, so she has asked me to stay awhile longer for observation.

The visitors approach their injured comrade.

Merel: We brought you some snacks, but security seized them at the door. Apparently, visitors aren't allowed to bring food.

Merel's face turns from downcast to bright and sunny.

Merel: But they did let me keep this.

A plump bird appears in Merel's palm.

Marsha: A bird? How cute. What species is it? I don't think I've seen such a bird before.

Merel: I saw it in *The Arcane Creature Keeper's Travelogue*. It didn't mention the species, though.

Merel: Actually, I think it said that even the author hadn't seen it. The picture was just a rough reconstruction. So I improvised a few bits.

Marsha: A reconstruction? Are they extinct?

Merel: Apparently. No one's seen one for over 40 years, so it seems like they're gone for good.

Merel: *sigh* What a shame! I hope there are some left out there. I bet the real version's even cuter.

Merel: I made it from some old bits and bobs I left at headquarters. One of them was a "blueprint" I drew during a maths lesson.

Merel: It was supposed to be a flying model powered by arcane skills, but, er, that was a bit beyond my ability at the time.

Merel: But, since my arcane skills have improved, I decided to give it another shot. I retooled the design, added a few new ideas ...

Merel: And, ta-da! Go on. See what it can do!

"Bird": *chirp*

The handmade bird flaps its little wings and leaps from Merel's hand to the bed.

Vertin: It's amazingly lifelike. The arcane skill you cast on it must be sophisticated.

Marsha: Thank you, Merel. I'll treasure it as if it were a sacred relic.

She stretches an arm out from the blankets and places the bird beside her pillow.

Marsha: Somehow, the way it moves reminds me of you.

Merel: I gave it all the healing incantations I could think of. Not sure if any of them actually work, though. Anyway, I thought it might keep you company while we're away.

Merel: Vertin and I have been assigned a mission at the SPDM. We'll need to go in a minute.

Marsha: Huh? They're sending both Team Timekeeper and the "XII" Squad to the SPDM?

A brief flash of surprise crosses her face. It's hard to imagine someone like Yermolai playing chaperone at the SPDM.

Merel: Uh, no, heheh, not the "XII" Squad. I've been seconded to Team Timekeeper for the mission.

Vertin: The SPDM has taken in a large number of "Storm" orphans in the last few months, and they're preparing for next term's opening ceremony.

Vertin: With our shortages in manpower, they've been recalling any available alumni to assist, including Merel and me.

Marsha: I see. I'm sure you'll do well this time.

Merel: O-Of course! I'll try my best.

Marsha: How is Commander Creius? Paravyan mentioned that the Committee has brought him to court.

Vertin: I'm sure it isn't anything too serious. I believe the Committee only wants to collect as much intelligence as possible before the next "Storm."

Merel: Yeah. That's why the squad members have all been reassigned.

Merel: I asked Paravyan and Yermolai to come visit you with us, but they were tied up. Looks like we'll have to wait till the "Storm" ends before we reunite.

Marsha: The "Storm" ... Then the end of this era is coming.

Vertin: Yes, but don't worry. The Foundation has already begun recalling its staff, and you'll be safe here.

Marsha: The doctor said that as long as I stay in the rehab center, I won't feel a thing when it happens. But it's my first time braving the "Storm."

Marsha: Commander Creius walked me through what to expect. He told me I would get "used to it."

Marsha: You've each been through it many times now, right? Have you gotten used to it?

Merel: ...

Only once she's outside the ward does Merel allow the worry on her face to show.

Merel: No one ever really gets used to it, do they, Vertin?

Vertin: I still haven't.

Merel: *sigh* It's almost time. Shall we set off early?

Vertin: Sorry, I can't. I just received a message. There's something I need to handle back at headquarters before I go.

Merel: Should I wait for you, then?

Vertin: No need. Just go and find Matilda at the ceremony hall. She'll tell you what to do before I arrive.

Merel: Matilda? You mean Matilda Bouanich, our old monitor assistant?

Vertin: Yes. She's an investigator now—a "star" investigator, she'll insist. She'll also be helping out.

Merel: Got it. I hope the school shuttle's still running. I haven't been back since I graduated.

Vertin: Take it as a good chance to revisit, then. Sonetto and I will join you soon.

The "Storm" Downpours

小径

Pre-Storm Field Observation Reports

According to field reports submitted by Marcus, Semmelweis, and other operatives across European branches, locations marked as "critical points of time" are now scattered across Europe in the current historical period. Both their number and distribution far exceed anything previously on record.

This is a turbulent era. The territorial and political disputes left by the war have Europe redrawing its map in blood and paperwork, while many nations are still rebuilding. Famine, unemployment, the lingering effects of influenza, and other post-war wounds pervade everyday life. Rebellious movements like Dadaism take root in the spiritual confusion of the age. The invention of wireless radio and small home appliances sparks the first stirrings of a technological revolution ...

Despite repeated reinforcements, new "critical points of time" continue to surface in cities and corners across multiple countries, and we are still unable to pinpoint where Manus Vindictae are most active. With a severe manpower shortage at the headquarters checkpoint, we can no longer spare operatives for continued observation.

In summary, based on reports from all teams, we are unable to confirm Manus Vindictae's operational direction, mount a targeted counteroffensive, or slow the deterioration and expansion of these "critical points of time." Headquarters has decided to execute the evacuation plan immediately in order to preserve as many of our forces as possible. All field team leaders are to order and urge their operatives to return to headquarters without delay or proceed to the nearest shelter to take refuge from the "Storm."

Temporary Dispatch

小径

Complaints From a Part-Time Guard

"Honestly, if someone had told me that joining the Foundation would one day have me posted as a door guard, I never would have let that Creius leave the Vigiles Bureau. But it's too late now. You, I, and all these fine Foundation employees will soon be standing at the door, plastering on smiles and shouting 'Welcome!'"

"At the end of the day, this all comes down to Creius and those 'Hawks' aggressively pushing through the Shelter Expansion Act. Ever since the Timekeeper announced the 'Storm' countdown, refugees from all over the world have flooded to the Foundation's doorstep, surrounding headquarters with no end in sight. Those lines stretch so far they could probably wrap around the entire earth."

"Who knows how loose the Foundation's screening criteria are this time. If you ask me, if even a handful of those veterans turn out to be spies, the Foundation could be blown apart from the inside in no time. Creius knows better than anyone what those soldiers are capable of, yet he's not the least bit worried about keeping them in line—just like he always has his ways of dealing with me and 'Blackbird.' And of course, you—his loyal little dog who doesn't need dealing with at all."

"Fine, this is why he dumped us here. On top of standing guard and welcoming guests, we're also on riot control, reconnaissance, and counter-espionage duty—and at the critical moment, we might just end up digging a trench outside the building. Let's go, heads up. Time to rotate from patrol to the front door ... Stop it. I didn't mean for you to actually smile like that."

Homecoming Day

13TH-02

Homecoming Day

Hallway, St. Pavlov Foundation

Captain Osborn: Paravyan, Yermolai, front and center, please.

The two "new recruits" stand at attention before their captain.

Paravyan & Yermolai: Hello, sir.
Good morning.

Captain Osborn: You two are from the "XII" Squad. Got nowhere else to go, huh? Sorry about your boss.

Captain Osborn: Anyway, welcome to the First Squad of the Pre-Storm Quick Reaction Force. I'm Captain Osborn. I'll be your supervisor until the "Storm" is over.

Captain Osborn: I don't believe you two are acquainted with our Storm Reaction Protocols, are you?

Paravyan: No. This is our first mission here. What are our responsibilities, sir?

Captain Osborn: Our primary duty is to provide security for the Foundation's personnel admission process.

Captain Osborn: We'll receive our orders directly from the Pre-Storm Dispatch Center, which takes over the Foundation's security forces in the last 24 hours prior to every "Storm."

Captain Osborn: Usually, we handle the admission process without additional support, but things are understandably more complicated this time. That's why you've been assigned here.

Yermolai: Well, I wasn't expecting a vacation.

Captain Osborn: Good to hear. Now, follow me. I'll fill you in along the way.

The grand north-facing gate, unweathered by time's passing, casts a heavy shadow beneath the sun's slanted rays.

Registration Desk, St. Pavlov Foundation

On the eve of each prior "Storm," it has served as the only entrance to the Foundation open to visitors and refugees.

Beyond the gate, people form an uneasy line along the exterior wall, their slow and trudging progress like some fattened caterpillar inching toward safety.

Captain Osborn: See these lines? Thanks to the *Resolution on the Expansion of Admitted Persons*, we're taking in ten times as many people as before.

Captain Osborn: Soldiers, psychiatrists, theoretical physicists, and more than a few questionable individuals ... Someone's really opened the floodgates this time around.

Captain Osborn: Most of them don't even know about the "Storm" yet. The Foundation's given out the usual excuses for our sudden invitation.

Captain Osborn: But with all of these new faces, this is a prime opportunity for the Manus to infiltrate us. With so many looking for an escape from this war, it wouldn't be difficult to coax them into doing their dirty work.

Captain Osborn: We've set up a security checkpoint here. Your job is to guard it and stop any unauthorized access to headquarters.

Paravyan: And what if we find an "unauthorized person"? What's the protocol? Should we haul them off to a cell?

Captain Osborn: Of course not. That's just what they'd want—an opportunity to cross the "Storm" safely.

Captain Osborn: Send them away, and make sure they don't come back.

Paravyan: But anyone we send away will die in the "Storm." Can't we just ...

Captain Osborn: Those are your orders. We can only admit those who are already authorized, and there's no time to run background checks.

Captain Osborn: Showing any mercy, no matter what the sob story, could put everyone in danger. You let one man in, and a second will follow, and then a third, and a fourth, and before you know it, it's utter chaos.

Captain Osborn: We don't have the manpower nor the space to deal with that.

Paravyan opens his mouth only to feel a tug on his shoulder. Yermolai's grim expression conveys the point wordlessly.

Yermolai: Understood, sir. Paravyan and I won't have any trouble following protocol.

Yermolai: We'll do everything as ordered: "Express gratitude, salute, and see them off. Never disturb the lives of the registrants," right?

Paravyan: ...

Captain Osborn: Good to know at least one of you understands. The Foundation is like an ark sailing the flood. The only way we'll reach land again is through strict order.

???: Let me in!

The crowd at the entrance erupts into a flurry of shouting and shoving.

Captain Osborn's face remains stalwart and professional as he scans for the source of the commotion.

Captain Osborn: Expect to see plenty more where that came from. We already stopped three of them before you got here.

Intruder: You can't just leave us out here to die!

Intruder: What are you all looking at, huh? The Foundation's only letting you in because they think you're useful! Your families are still going to die! Just like the rest of us!

Captain Osborn: Gentlemen, please get rid of him before this escalates.

Yermolai: ...

Paravyan: As Yermolai moves to carry out his orders, he spots his comrade's hesitation.

Yermolai: Oh, brother. Before I get started, can I ask how long you've been at this, Captain?

Captain Osborn: Five "Storms" as captain of the First Squad and three years as a squad member.

Captain Osborn: It wasn't until I saw the "Storm" with my own eyes that I fully realized I'd never get to see my wife and children again.

Paravyan: ...

Captain Osborn: But if you want to know my take on this, I'd say I swore to devote my life to the Foundation.

Captain Osborn: It takes sacrifice to push time forward, gentlemen.

Yermolai nods, then turns to give Paravyan an affectionate pat.

Yermolai: C'mon, Beagle. Let's take care of this lad.

Hound has cornered his prey. The intruder has nowhere left to run.

Intruder: Go to hell, Foundation lapdogs!

Yermolai: Tsk.

Intruder: Urgh!

A kick from behind sends the intruder stumbling to the ground.

Intruder: Please don't kick me out.

Captain Osborn: Leave him to me. Now, back to your positions.

Yermolai: Understood.

The wails and commotion give way back to quiet order. Yermolai approaches Paravyan, blocking his view of the scene at the gate.

Yermolai: Let's get to it. You know what to do.

Oh life of peace, and joy within, we yearn.

Our hearts, they stay on guard to strive and fight.

For darkness lingers steadily within.

Light flies toward thee like a dove.

...

Opening Ceremony, SPDM

The children make an awkward attempt at bows and curtsies, then exit the stage following their teacher's instruction.

The applause continues as the principal takes the stage. He taps the microphone, drawing out a screech of feedback before he begins.

Principal: Thank you for that wonderful performance. Distinguished teachers, dear students, ladies and gentlemen, welcome to this year's opening ceremony.

Principal: We are especially honored today to be joined by the Foundation's Inspection Team, who will be spending this memorable day by our side.

Principal: For many of you, this will be your first time leaving home. And for all of you, this opportunity to study at a unique institution with students from all over the world may seem daunting at first.

Principal: There will be challenges, even conflicts, along the way. But here, you will study the skills and values needed to overcome them. Every young arcanist will have the opportunity to realize their potential and to contribute to the cause of world peace—

Principal: A mission this institution has pursued for centuries. Our philosophy ...

The loudspeakers carry the principal's speech across the campus, same as ever.

Matilda leans against the guardrail, finding her eyes drifting over and over to the time.

Matilda: Vertin said she and Sonetto would be a tad tardy, I know, but where is that assistant she said would be here?

Matilda: Ugh, that same old speech again? I bet that old fogey wrote it before I was even born.

Merel: Matilda?

A flash of purple squeezes out from the sea of white uniforms.

Matilda: Merel! You're the assistant Vertin sent?!

Matilda: Heck! What took you so long? I've already been waiting for 34 minutes!

Merel: Sorry! You wouldn't believe how crowded the student entrance is. Took me ages to get in.

Matilda: The student entrance? You're not a student anymore, Merel.

Matilda: You were meant to go to the staff entrance. They would have let you in right away.

Merel: Oh. Uh, haha, ha ...

Merel: You're right. I should've known.

Matilda: ...

Matilda: You graduated two years ago, Merel.

Merel: I-I know. It's just ... I chickened out when I made eye contact with the instructor at the gate.

Matilda: *sigh* Never mind. It's not too late to start our mission.

Merel: Right. About that, what is our mission exactly?

Matilda: To maintain order on the campus and deal with any and all threats during the opening ceremony.

Merel: Isn't that the guards' job?

Matilda: Well, yes, but, hmm, we need some privacy. Follow me.

Classroom

Matilda inspects the classroom. Only once she's confirmed it to be empty does she speak, albeit cautiously.

Matilda: *sigh* We can't let the students know about the "Storm." I am certain you remember.

Matilda: I suppose you know this better than I do, but many children have lost their parents to the war in this era.

Matilda: Therefore, the SPDM has taken in a great deal more arcanist orphans than ever before. The intake this year is so large that the staff can hardly handle it.

Merel: I see. No wonder everywhere feels so crowded.

Matilda: So, then, you've seen for yourself how order is barely being maintained, even with all the guards on hand.

Matilda: That is why the SPDM has requested some alumni from headquarters to assist.

Matilda: Still, we have a more important mission than just maintaining order, that is, to inspect the Shelter Doves around the campus.

She looks out the window, which offers a clear view of a nearby watchtower at the corner of the school's walls.

Merel follows her gaze. It's a familiar sight, the same watchtower that stared down at her when she was a student here.

Merel: You mean those things installed on top of the watchtowers? Are you sure we're allowed to touch them?

Matilda: Oh, you know about them already? Good. Then we can skip the introduction.

Merel: I think so. My commander from the "XII" Squad told me about them. He said headquarters only has a limited immunity range against the "Storm."

Merel: Nearby facilities, like the SPDM, fall outside that range.

Merel: And that's where these Shelter Doves come in. They reshape the immunity area to cover those facilities.

The alumni look away.

Merel: There is one thing I've been wondering, though. Where did these Doves come from?

Matilda: It's Pax House technology. Not even the Laplace researchers know how it works.

Merel: But if we don't know how they work, how are we supposed to inspect them?

Matilda: Ordinarily, the Pax House sends an inspector to check on their status. But this time, they sent over the testing equipment so that we can do the job ourselves.

Matilda: You just need to plug it into the maintenance panel on the pedestal and wait. It will sound a warning if the Doves need repair.

Matilda glances downward as she pulls a piece of paper from her pocket. She's done her homework, condensing the entire 150-page manual onto a single sheet of crucial information.

Matilda: And of course, its power doesn't come from nowhere. You can check the battery status on the panel.

Merel: And if it does sound a warning? I doubt we'd be able to fix it on our own.

Matilda: In that case, replace it with a backup Dove and report the malfunction to headquarters. Someone will take care of it.

Matilda: There are backup Doves stored in the air-raid shelters beneath the watchtowers, except the central one. That shelter is closed for maintenance, so its Doves are stored near the top.

Matilda: According to the maintenance logs, we shouldn't have any problems. But we still need to inspect each one of them.

Merel: Uh, so, it's just a routine check, then?

Matilda: Yes. I know it sounds a little dull, but the safety of the entire campus depends on us.

Matilda: Now you understand why they turned to Matilda—their most reliable investigator and former monitor assistant—to bear such a great responsibility.

Matilda: Hello?

Lavender: Ms. Matilda, have you met the other member of the Security Assistance Team?

Matilda: Yes. She's here with me now.

Matilda: Any luck finding the missing student Ms. Fogel talked about?

Lavender: Well, about that, I followed the instructions of your divination to the classroom building and dorm, but there was no sign of him at all.

Lavender: And I received a new message from Ms. Fogel. She said there was another student missing during the attendance call at the opening ceremony.

Getting Worse

小径

Legends of the School Watchtowers

> [The last page torn from a book, treated with a visibility potion—the invisible ink now exposed.]
>
> This afternoon I overheard the instructor slip up—she said something like "back when the school didn't have the watchtowers ..." What does that tell us? Those five towers are no ordinary structures; they were built for a reason! Our earlier suspicions just might be right!
>
> Which one do you mean? The one about the towers being used to subdue ghosts? Or the one about locking up students who've gone mad?

Both! Just think—why would the school suddenly put up towers that serve no purpose and ban every student from setting foot inside?

Oh please. Maybe the name says it all—they're just there to watch us. The higher-ups have teachers on duty up there around the clock, holding a long-range lightning gun, just waiting for the moment you try to slip out ... and bang, you're down.

Even if there really are teachers on duty, I don't believe they can stay awake 24 hours a day. One of these nights we'll find our chance, sneak in, and figure out their secrets for ourselves!

Have you lost your mind? What if there are machines inside that can spy on students? We'd get caught in no time.

You're just a coward! We'll cover our faces. If something goes wrong, you run first, and I'll cover the rear. Just tell me—are you in or not?

Fine ... for the sake of our friendship, I'll go.

[A report lies beneath this "secret message," with a few sharp lines on the page.]

After comparing handwriting, we have confirmed that the two students responsible are fifth-years Andrea and Oliver. I will personally reprimand them and impose a one-week detention as punishment. Given the recent rumors circulating among students regarding the watchtowers, I propose increasing patrol frequency around the watchtower perimeter and strengthening oversight of the weather-stabilizing pigeons housed within to avoid any lapses during inspections from the Pax House.
Regarding my mistake, I can confirm that I did not mention the "Storm" or that reverse incident during the first "Storm." I will submit a three-thousand-word written apology and reflect seriously on my failures in student management.

Escape Plan

13TH-03

Escape Plan

George the Oak

The passage of time has done little to change the face of the old oak. Years pass by as fleeting moments, but it remains as it ever was.

And just as ever, a flock of little white doves gathers beneath its ancient boughs.

Emilia: Are you sure this is going to work, Lucas?

A short boy crawls across the ground. He seems to be searching for something.

Lucas: You CAN leave if you don't trust me.

Emilia: Hmph!

Emilia: The school anthem's over. Mikey said he would sneak out when the choir was leaving the stage.

Emilia: Then, it's time for the principal to give that same old speech that goes on and on. So, let's say 15 minutes, but we might need more time than that. Do you think we can make it?

Lucas stands up and brushes the dirt from his palms.

Lucas: C'mon Emilia, don't sweat it! You know the old man'll keep blabbing on for at least half an hour.

Lucas: We've still got plenty of time. Just think about it: once the summoning array's done, the three of us will be free.

Lucas: I mean out-of-the-school free.

Emilia: ...

The little girl tenses visibly.

Emilia: Out of the school, really?

Emilia: Do you know what it's like out there? The instructor said there's a war going on. It could be dangerous.

Lucas: Are you kidding? They just said that to scare us.

Emilia: But why are we doing it today of all days?

Lucas: Because it's our last good chance for the whole semester. Everyone's at the ceremony, and the guards are busy either handling the crowds or showing the Inspection Team around. I heard there are some Committee members coming this time.

Lucas: So, will you calm down already? This was your plan, remember? Everything's gonna go just fine.

Emilia—the planner between them—says nothing. She turns her head to look up at George the Oak.

The grandfatherly tree has nothing to offer but stern and noble silence.

Year after year, new cohorts gather beneath his bright, green leaves as they wither and dry, until they're plucked from his head by the wind and become the soft mulch on which the new class treads.

Emilia: ...?

Emilia: Someone's coming.

Lucas: Could be Mikey. I'll go get him.

Emilia: Wait. Let me double-check. My arcane skill isn't totally reliable.

Emilia: Let me see. They sound like a girl's footsteps, a bit shorter than Mikey.

Emilia: Wait. Now I hear two of them coming this way. Is there something wrong with my arcane skill?

Matilda: Got you!

The star investigator herself pops out from the bushes.

Lucas: Shoot! It's a monitor assistant.

Matilda: Merel, are you in position?

Merel: I'm ready.

Emilia: Ah, run!

No match for the alumni, the two young students are soon caught and detained beneath the oak tree.

Emilia & Lucas: ...

Matilda: Another two overconfident truants. This happens every year.

Matilda: Fortunately, your little accomplice in the choir was exposed; otherwise, you would be running free outside the school right now.

Lucas: Urgh, you're a big jerk!

Matilda: Wh-What? Don't you realize you could have wound up in danger if the kindhearted and brilliant Matilda hadn't stopped you?

Merel rises to her feet to examine their array, and a peculiar expression crosses her face.

Hapless, yet knowing, like a chef realizing too late what their recipe needed.

Merel: You know, this array wouldn't have worked anyway.

Lucas: What? Liar! I found it in a book. It said it could summon a gryphon.

Merel: Uhhh, *Avian Critter Behaviors and Feeding Methods*?

Lucas: What? How did you know?

Merel: You found this array on the blank page between chapter three and four, right? Drawn in invisible ink.

Merel: "Whosoever unlocks the secret hidden in invisible ink will discover an array which summons the legendary gryphon."

The young boy's eyes go wide as he realizes just how far out of his depth he is.

Emilia: You've read that book too, haven't you? And you found this array?

Merel: That's right.

Emilia: You mean you went to this school?

Merel: Of course. What are you trying to say, exactly?

Emilia: Then, you mean we really do get to go back into the world?

Merel: We couldn't stay here even if we wanted to.

Emilia: The instructors are hiding something. But if we'll find out one day anyway, why don't they just tell us now?

Emilia: Miss, why can't you just tell us what's happening out there? I swear we'll keep our mouths shut.

Lucas: Don't bother, Emilia. They're not gonna tell you anything.

Lucas: They know. But even if they used to be students like us, they're just like them now.

Lucas: They'll ignore us, just like the instructors do.

Merel: I ...

Her face flushes. Terrible secrets threaten to burst from her lips.

Merel: War ... There's a war raging out there. Honestly, I wish I could stay here at the school where it's safe. And that's not even the worst part.

Matilda: ...

Instructor: That must be them. This way. Hurry up!

An instructor arrives flanked by school security guards, disrupting their increasingly dangerous conversation.

Instructor: Lucas, Emilia! What do you think you're doing out here? Unbelievable!

Instructor: You're both spending the rest of the day sitting in the guardhouse! Take them away!

Emilia: No, no! There's worms in the walls of that place.

Instructor: Exactly! Those Shamirs are there to give you troublemakers a lesson.

School Security: Move it, you little terrors. No more tricks. I'm watching you.

Lucas: Let me go!

The flustered instructor regains her composure and offers the Security Assistance Team a polite smile.

Instructor: Thank you for your assistance, investigators. Rest assured, I'll be giving these two a much overdue lesson on following rules and procedures.

Matilda: You are most welcome, Instructor. Of course, we could escort them to the guardhouse if you'd like.

Instructor: No need for that. I'm aware you have more important tasks to do while "the skies are clear."

She seizes the little doves by their wings and escorts them back to the safety of their cage.

Matilda and Merel stay in place, exchanging a look of resigned acceptance, powerless to change things as they are now.

Matilda: These students are too young to handle the truth. They don't even know they're from different eras. Could you imagine what would happen if we told them about the "Storm"?

Merel: I do understand. I mean, I know the school's only trying to protect them, but their punishment still seems a bit much.

Matilda: Mhm. Which is why I, the Great Matilda Bouanich, will be changing things as soon as I gain power in the Foundation!

Matilda: But for now, let's keep our eyes on the mission, alright? There's no time to wait for Sonetto and Vertin.

Matilda: The nearest watchtower is the one in the northwest. Let's start from there.

Top Floor, Northwestern Watchtower

Matilda: So, this is the Shelter Dove.

Merel stands beside the blast door, looking frozen stiff from head to toe.

Matilda: What are you doing standing back there? Come on, I'll show you how to use the tester.

Merel: What? I thought you said you never used it before.

Matilda: Perhaps not, but you underestimate Matilda the Magnificent! I already figured out how to use it well in advance.

Merel: Oh, okay.

Her stiff posture finally breaks as she walks over to accept the tester from Matilda.

Matilda: Plug the tester in at the panel on the pedestal, turn the safety knob, and press the button on the side.

Merel: The safety knob ... Am I turning it the right way?

A slight buzz emerges from the device.

Matilda: Okay. Now the lights on the panel will tell us whether the Dove is working.

Matilda: Verifying ID, green. Power status, green. Immunity area, also green. Good. Stellar. Superb!

She withdraws the tester with satisfaction.

Matilda: That's all there is to it. Now we head to the next watchtower.

Matilda: By the way, I'm quite curious: how did you know the gryphon array wouldn't work?

Merel: Because I was the one who drew it, back in eighth grade.

Matilda: Ah, uh, what? But, but, but that's, that's vandalism!

Hallway, St. Pavlov Foundation

Sonetto: ...

The long corridor is like a riddle whose end connects to its beginning. It loops around the Committee Building, linking various floors and rooms with meticulously designed stairways.

Somewhere within that winding riddle, Sonetto comes to a halt.

Vertin: Is there something wrong, Sonetto?

The soft words sound louder and sharper in the empty hallway. The bustle of the Foundation's Pre-Storm activity hasn't yet reached this corridor.

Sonetto: That courtroom we just passed—Mr. Creius is in there answering the Committee's questions.

Sonetto: It was his information that led us to the Amber Room and to Bereggrad. I'm just concerned ...

Vertin: The Foundation hasn't quizzed me on anything since I submitted my report on the Don Operation.

Vertin: I would be in there right next to Creius if they wanted to investigate us as well.

Sonetto: I see.

Sonetto suppresses her concerns. Footsteps echo over the marble again.

Vertin: Here it is. Let's go.

Foundation Office

The office behind the opening door is barren of any identity, a symptom both of the occupant's recent arrival and her curious nature.

The woman in question lifts her head from the neat stacks of files on her desk.

Ms. Stranger: Long time no see, Timekeeper, Sonetto.

Homecoming Day

小径

Such a lovely day, isn't it?

These noisy children are soon going to be locked behind the school gate, and I will say goodbye to you.

This war will be over as long as I close my eyes. It has lasted far too long.

sigh Finally ...

What are you doing standing around? Aren't you heading to school? Go on then. Children your age are SUPPOSED to be learning and playing.

Choices

1. I graduated long ago

2. I'll miss you

Branch 1

College then. Get yourself a medical degree or a doctorate at least.

Haven't you realized how precious peace is after coming back from the battlefield? Make your life count.

I'm going to take a nap. Now, go and find something to keep yourself busy.

Branch 2

Oh, please.

Take a look at that tree. I think it must feed on the escape plans of students like you; how else could it grow two inches taller every year?

I imagine it might even serve as something of a secret hideout for them.

But I wonder if anyone ever bothers to visit it again after they leave; likely not. A once beloved place all too quickly forgotten.

Do you know why?

Because they are too afraid to face the difficult truth.

That they wasted the most carefree days of their lives trying to escape from paradise into hell, and now there's no power in heaven or earth that can send them back.

You'll end up just as pathetic as them, unless you can go back there and prove your courage.

You won't have anything like the fanfare your French classmate received—she was proud as a peacock when she walked through that gate. But you'll not chicken out, will you?

Shared continuation

Homecoming Day

Perfect Exchange

小径

Improved Invisible Ink Formula

[A note in childish handwriting.]

Find a way to replace the ingredients with things that are easy to get from within the school.

Ritual Offering—This sacrificial food is mostly made of flour. Maybe a handful of dry pasta will do the trick?

Roaring Root—Fortunately, this main ingredient can be found right here at school. Spotted a few growing near the tree roots by the lake last week. The spell calls for Milled Magnesia—some salt from the canteen should work.

Trembling Tooth—Theoretically these should be molars from small to mid-sized omnivorous arcane animals, but judging by size and pneuma content, the baby teeth collected by Ms. Tooth Fairy at the clinic might be the best option. I could take cold showers for a couple of days, then if I get sick, I'd have an excuse to visit … but should I ask her directly or just quietly steal one …

The Cube Researchers

13TH-04

The Cube Researchers

Countdown to the "Storm"

Vertin: You still look pale, Ms. Stranger.

Ms. Stranger: Well enough to get back to work. Thank you for your concern.

Ms. Stranger: Though, before we exchange any more pleasantries, shall we allow this researcher to finish her job first?

She glances over to the other woman standing in the corner.

Technician: Hello, Timekeeper. You're as punctual as ever, right down to the tick.

Vertin: In fact, you're early, miss. But I must confess, I was never all that timely before becoming the Timekeeper.

Technician: Oh, wow, and a sense of humor too! You've really got it all, Ms. Vertin.

Technician: I'll be the one conducting research into your Suitcase's technology this time. Well, it's not just me, of course; it'll go to the team. One researcher alone couldn't possibly understand a device of the Suitcase's magnitude, could they?

Technician: So, has everyone moved out already?

Vertin: Yes. They're all in the Foundation's guest rooms. I've checked every nook and cranny to ensure no one was left behind.

This year's Suitcase inspection just so happens to fall during the "Storm." Perhaps Team Timekeeper will be able to take a vacation.

Following protocol, the technician takes the emptied Suitcase.

Technician: Thank you for your cooperation. I'm sure this will help us learn more about that mysterious Spinning Wheel.

She holds the Suitcase delicately, almost reverently. She stares down at it and then glances up again, as if weighing unspoken words on her tongue.

Vertin: Hm? Anything else I can help you with?

Technician: Um, Timekeeper, there's something I'd like to ask you about, kind of a private matter.

Technician: About the Amber Room. I heard you went through some kind of time distortion in there. Is that true?

Vertin: Yes. It was exactly as I wrote in my report.

Technician: Time distortion ... If only I were assigned to research that! What could be more fun than studying time itself!

Her visible excitement is contained—if just barely—by concern for the marvelous device she is holding.

Technician: Not to knock working on the Suitcase—I suppose involves the study of space ... Space or time, ah, I wonder which is deeper.

Technician: You know, you're a real gatherer of mysteries, Timekeeper. Actually, you're kind of a mystery yourself. *sigh* I don't know what I'm saying.

Technician: Sorry for the blabbering. I should really go.

Technician: We'll get the Suitcase back to you in a few days. A week at most. Please plan your schedule accordingly. Goodbye, Timekeeper.

She nods, causing the light to reflect off her sleek mask, then makes her exit.

Sonetto: ...

Ms. Stranger approaches gently.

Ms. Stranger: I wonder if she even saw me or Ms. Sonetto. Laplace really does excel in finding "unique" talents.

Vertin: I'm used to it.

Vertin: Has the Foundation assigned you a new job already? I thought you'd want to rest for a while longer.

Ms. Stranger: I wish I could, but it's not my decision to make.

Ms. Stranger: The Foundation received your report on the Don Operation while I was still stuck in bed. It mentioned that Igor gave you a "boon."

Ms. Stranger: Part of my work involves studying the Manus's arcane skills, so I was sent to Laplace to help.

Ms. Stranger: The project leader said they've made some progress already, but they'll need your help to continue.

Ms. Stranger: Which is why I invited you here.

Vertin: Is the research team here at the Foundation?

Ms. Stranger: Yes. The project leader and her assistant were notified in advance and brought their equipment here.

Ms. Stranger: Follow me. They asked for an open space, so we agreed to meet in the garden.

Southern Garden, St. Pavlov Foundation

Cold white auxiliary buildings form an uneven enclosure around the pleasant green commons of the Foundation's southern annex.

The patterns of shrubbery and lace-like walkways resemble, in a deliberate way, the intricate gardens that surround the Palace of Versailles—albeit tightly compacted.

Ms. Stranger: I don't understand how one can relax while walking through a maze like this.

Vertin: The view was much more enjoyable before the hedges grew into walls like this.

At the center of the commons stands a peculiar instrument.

Sonetto: That should be them over there. Is that Eagle?

Eagle: Hi, Ms. Timekeeper, Ms. Sonetto, Ms. Stranger.

The girl nods dutifully but bounds back with a bright smile.

Eagle: It's great to see you again.

Vertin: It's been a while, Eagle. I understand you've joined Laplace.

Vertin: Will you be working on this project too?

Eagle: Not exactly. The project leader is my tutor. I'm just here to help with a few things. She is ...

???: Hello, Timekeeper. It's truly an honor.

A woman steps out from behind the device. At a glance, she could be mistaken for any other Laplace researcher, save for the sharp and cunning look in her eyes.

Marguerite: I hope you've found the time to read Ms. Recoleta's novel.

Marguerite: Oh, you can call me Marguerite.

Vertin: It's a pleasure, Marguerite.

Marguerite: Your timing's perfect. Eagle and I have just finished setting up the Omni-Vector Virtual Monitoring Device. We're ready to start the experiment at any time.

She presents the device to them with a look that reveals both anticipation and calculation in a single dangerous smile.

Marguerite: Please, take a seat, Timekeeper. You're about to experience quite the adventure.

Sonetto: Wait, Ms. Marguerite. Would you mind explaining what this "Omni-Vector Virtual Monitoring Device" is before you start?

Marguerite: It's a "Chaos-System Omni-Vector Quantitative Analysis and Spatial-Metric Virtual Sensory Monitoring Device," to be precise.

Marguerite: Based on what we know about this cube, it'll go through unpredictable changes in the near future. So, to keep it under control, we must—

Marguerite: Ah. Judging by your faces, I think I haven't been clear enough.

Ms. Stranger: Allow me to make things easier for everyone.

Ms. Stranger: Using the data I provided, the research team has decoded the arcane skill Manus Vindictae used to stabilize the shell of the "boon," allowing us to access what was held inside.

Marguerite: It was trivial, really. All we needed to do was listen.

Vertin: So you're saying I can use this device to "hear" what's inside the cube.

Marguerite: Exactly. I know it isn't quite correct to call it a "monitoring device," but language itself is an exercise in uncertainty, wouldn't you say?

Ms. Stranger: Given that the cube was created by Arcana, a less direct but safer method of exploration is probably for the best.

Marguerite: As it happens, I already attempted to listen to the device while setting up the system. As soon as the first blast of sound reached my ears, I was hit with a wave of dizziness and briefly fell unconscious.

Marguerite: Symptoms that closely resemble what I experienced when you secretly "invited" me to the lake in your Suitcase.

Marguerite: It's likely, Vertin, that you are the only one able to remain conscious while listening to the device. And don't worry. Eagle has already booked a VIP room for you at the rehab center, just in case.

Vertin: I see. Well, I suppose there's only one way to find out.

The hat is removed, allowing the head to fit more easily inside the dome.

Marguerite: Virtual environmental model constructed. You may begin at any time.

Marguerite: Ms. Stranger, place the Pandora's box on the tray, if you would.

Marguerite: ... Just as ... the cube ... superposition ... ever-changing matter ...

Marguerite: It seems feasible ... the system ... aligns well with our simulated ... Wait—

Ms. Stranger: ... Timekeeper ... seems ...

Vertin: ...?!

The ringing in the ears fades, only to be replaced by the wailing of the device's alarm.

Sonetto: The machine is smoking. Did something go wrong?

Sonetto: Timekeeper! Are you alright?

Vertin: I'm fine. My ears are ringing, but that's all.

The hat is put back on, concealing still-spinning eyes beneath its brim.

Marguerite: So you were able to withstand whatever's inside the cube, as expected, but it looks like our monitoring device wasn't.

Marguerite: The overload of chaos data caused it to break down, though it should've been fine under the protection of the Apeiron scroll.

Eagle diligently jots down notes as she provides a full assessment of the damage.

Eagle: Did you hear anything during the experiment?

Vertin: I did. But I don't quite know how to describe it. It was almost like the sound of sinking quicksand?

Vertin: I think I've made contact with similar powers before. I'm not sure what it is, but I know it could be very dangerous.

Eagle: Then Ms. Stranger was right. It could be risky to break the shell before we find out what's inside.

Marguerite: It's still an option worth considering, since we've gotten nothing from the monitoring device.

She lets the undertone of excitement bleed into her voice intentionally as she focuses her attention on the artifact.

Marguerite: Well, Timekeeper? Shall we open it?

Vertin: No. The risk is too high.

Marguerite: Shame. Anyway, if you change your mind ...

She produces a capsule-shaped item.

Marguerite: Use this. Our virtual neighbor came up with this capsule while we were working on the monitoring device.

Marguerite: It activates with a simple incantation. It'll take about seven seconds to dissolve the shell. After that, who knows what might happen.

Marguerite: I'll teach you the incantation later. It's easy, as long as you passed the SPDM's ninth-grade arcane skills class.

Choices

1. Accept

2. Talk about ninth grade

Branch 1

Vertin: Thank you. I'll treat it with the utmost care.

Marguerite: Good. I look forward to hearing its secrets. If you decide to open it, that is.

Branch 2

Vertin: As it happens, I wasn't in class for most of ninth grade.

Marguerite: Really? Either way, I'm sure being the Timekeeper has given you more than enough experience to handle it.

Shared continuation

Marguerite hands over the capsule with a practiced smile.

Quantifying Pain

小径

The Foundation's Medical Record Archive

Classification: High
Patient Codename: Moth
Medical Record:
Examination reveals that the patient, having returned from the Antarctic Operation, performed repeated identity overwrites throughout their long-term undercover assignment, exceeding the safe iteration threshold. The patient's Phototaxis now shows multiple unstable segments, which may affect overwrite efficacy and increase the risk of personality collapse. Brainwave activity shows an increase in fast waves, indicating compensatory neuronal overload. Neurotransmitter concentrations are imbalanced: dopamine levels have dropped to 60% of the normal range, and serotonin synthesis efficiency has decreased by 28%. Physical damage is present in the medial prefrontal cortex, with mild edema in the limbic system ...
...
The patient also overextended her use of arcane skills during the Antarctic Operation, resulting in prolonged pneuma depletion. Recovery prospects are not encouraging. Strict limits must be placed on her arcane skill usage in the near term to prevent irreversible damage. During psychological evaluation, the patient exhibited mild self-perception disorder ...
...
Diagnosis:
The patient's brain damage is largely within controllable limits. Although a deep personality overwrite should be performed upon completion of the undercover assignment, given the critical enemy intelligence and knowledge obtained during this infiltration of Manus Vindictae, an unconventional approach has been approved: the Phototaxis overwrite will be suspended for the time being. The patient will instead receive regular injections of neural repair peptides to maintain brain function. During this period, the patient's psychological state must be closely monitored to confirm the results of cognitive anchoring.

Stone Doves

13TH-05

Stone Doves

Top Floor, Central Watchtower

Merel: Whoa!

The large Shelter Dove casts a soft glow over its perch.

Merel: Is it just me, or is this Dove bigger than the others?

Matilda: It is much bigger than the other four.

Matilda: And that is for a very good reason. This is the primary Dove.

Matilda: It covers the largest area of the campus, while the other four cover the corners.

Merel: To think that the SPDM's been kept safe all this time by these things.

Merel takes a step forward and, just as before, inserts the tester.

The tester whirs to life, and then just as quickly, the sound fades, replaced by a triumphant hue.

Merel: All green. Shelter Dove's functional.

Merel: That's it. We've checked all of them.

Merel: So, snack break, then?

Matilda: Certainly not! We need to keep patrolling the grounds until the "Storm" is over and everyone is safe.

Merel: Oh. So, what, we just keep circling around the school, going up and down the watchtowers?

Matilda: I know it is far from the sort of glorious mission that the Great Matilda Bouanich is capable of.

Matilda: But just think, we are protecting all the staff and students of the school!

Matilda: Someone must have done the same for us when we were students.

Merel: Yeah. I get it.

She chuckles to herself.

Merel: *sigh* I shouldn't complain. I'd much rather do this than fight on the battlefield. And the snacks here are better than the MREs, that's for sure.

She pulls two chocolate-flavored energy bars from her pocket and offers one to Matilda.

Merel: Plus, we don't have to hide them from the instructors anymore.

Matilda: Oh, th-thank you. Um, I suppose it is inefficient to work on empty bellies.

After a moment of hesitation, she reaches out to take the bar.

Merel: They're butter berry flavor, only produced in the 90s. I guess that makes them a little old, but they should taste fine.

Merel: Ignore the packaging. I swapped it out to avoid leaking time period info.

Matilda: Quite thoughtful of you.

Matilda: Let's go. Remember to lock the blast door in case any students end up wandering around near these restricted areas.

Matilda: Yes, Lavender?

Lavender: Ms. Matilda, could you go to the southwestern watchtower right now?

Matilda: What's wrong?

Lavender: There are some strangers at the school gate that are staring in its direction.

Matilda: Strangers? What do they look like?

Lavender: They're all adults, and they aren't dressed like the instructors or security.

Matilda: Please stay safe, Lavender. Merel and I are on our way.

Southwestern Watchtower Perimeter

Lavender: Over here, Ms. Bouanich, Ms. Van der Veer.

Lavender pops out from behind the bushes and waves the pair over.

Matilda: Is there anything else you remember?

Lavender: It looks like they might have come from one of the nearby towns. Not sure what they want. Should I call security?

Matilda and Merel exchange a glance.

Matilda: It's best that you leave for now. The Security Assistance Team will take over from here.

Lavender: But I can help, Ms. Matilda.

Matilda: I'm certain you would. But students are not allowed to make contact with outsiders.

Lavender: But I ... Never mind. You're right.

Lavender: The Monitor Director said she wanted to see me in her office anyway.

Matilda: Off you go then. You know how much she hates waiting.

Lavender acknowledges the order with a nod, but the worry is plain on her face as she leaves.

Once she's far enough away, the two of them speed toward the southwestern watchtower. The tower stares down at them above a tranquil wooded lake.

Merel: Matilda, do we really have to toss them out? They're just townsfolk, aren't they?

Matilda: Outsiders are strictly forbidden from the SPDM campus. Besides, the "Storm" will be here soon. Maybe we should ...

Uncertainty creeps into her voice.

Matilda: No. We must confirm their identities and arrest them if necessary.

A rustling sound coming from the southwestern watchtower draws their attention.

Merel: Listen. The watchtower's door just opened.

Matilda: Then we must go immediately.

First Floor, Southwestern Watchtower

First Floor, Southwestern Watchtower

Met by an open door at the watchtower's base, they tread with caution as they enter the dim, circular room beyond.

Merel: Huh? No one's here?

Merel: Where did the guards go? They were right here last time.

Merel & Matilda: ...

All at once, they're struck by a wave of odor, a scent both strange and darkly familiar.

Matilda: Calm down, Merel. This is precisely why they asked for our support.

Matilda: We'll report the situation to the security center, begin an investigation, and eliminate any threats we encounter along the way.

Matilda: That button on the wall should contact the security center.

Ever-confident, she reaches out and presses the button without a moment's pause.

Matilda: Um?

Merel: It's not working.

Realizing this, Merel pulls her communicator out and punches a few keys.

Merel: Oh no. My communicator doesn't have a signal either!

Matilda: But this alarm is directly connected to the security center through an underground wire. Its signal can't be blocked unless ...

Merel: Unless someone cut it.

???: 𠂇 ...

Merel: Intruder!

Matilda: Get down!

Manus Disciple: 幺！

Merel: Manus Vindictae?!

Merel whips around to see a dark figure descending the steps.

Even more shadowy figures emerge and rush downstairs behind it.

Manus Disciple: 歹 ... Stop ...

Manus Believer: The first of them blocks the watchtower's door while the others trap Matilda and Merel from the other side.

Matilda: Hmph. They're blocking the only way out. These filthy puppets have grown more intelligent.

Matilda: Think, Matilda. You must find a way to report this to the school and the Foundation.

Matilda: The wire is beyond repair, but Lavender was near the watchtower when she called me, which means the signal jammer is only covering a small area. That's it!

Matilda: Merel, do you think you can reach that window?

Merel: That window there?

Merel: It's a bit high, but I guess I could transform into a bird.

Matilda: Then I shall distract these puppets while you fly out of that window. Keep flying until your communicator has a signal again and report to the Foundation.

Merel: But what about you?

Matilda: I am Matilda Bouanich, Star Investigator of the Foundation and leader of the Security Assistance Team. You have no need to worry about me.

Matilda: Now! Go!

Attacking with a string of arcane skills, Matilda runs in the opposite direction of the narrow window.

The light refracting off her crystal draws away their attention.

Merel: I'll be back as soon as I can! Stay safe, Matilda!

Merel: She turns and fires a shot at the corner of the window.

Merel disappears in a burst of light, and a little blackbird darts through the hole in the glass.

The blackbird flies from the tower, dodging branches as she swoops downward.

Southwestern Watchtower Perimeter

Merel: Ugh!

Merel dispels the transformation and crashes to the ground.

Ignoring the pain in her palms, she reaches for her communicator.

Merel: Yes! Signal's back!

Merel: Security center, no response. Foundation, ah, alright! I'm through.

Merel: This is Merel of Team Timekeeper. Investigator Bouanich and I have engaged Manus Vindictae at the southwestern watchtower of the SPDM.

Merel: Number and purpose of intruders unknown. Requesting backup. Requesting back—

Merel: Matilda!!

The explosions immediately scatter the arcane signal.

All she receives in reply is static.

Merel: Update:

Merel: Manus Vindictae has destroyed the southwestern watchtower of the SPDM. Nearby areas will be exposed to the "Storm."

Merel: Matilda, uh, Investigator Bouanich was inside the watchtower when it was destroyed.

Ms. Stranger: Merel? Are you still there?

Judging from the reaction on the other end, it seems her message wasn't received.

Ms. Stranger: ...

She has no choice but to end the call.

Vertin: Manus Vindictae are attacking the SPDM?

Ms. Stranger: Yes. They have already destroyed at least one watchtower. The rest of the campus is almost certainly in danger.

Her hand flits over the communicator as she switches lines.

Ms. Stranger: The Pre-Storm Dispatch Center is sending an armed response force to the SPDM. Hopefully, the guards will hold out until they arrive.

Vertin: Merel and Matilda are already engaged in the fighting.

Vertin: We need a faster way to get there.

Marguerite: Well, in that case ...

Marguerite interjects with an understated satisfaction.

Marguerite: I may be able to help.

Burned Feathers

13TH-06

Burned Feathers

Matilda dodges nimbly around the cascade of rubble. She can see the cracks forming over the cement ceiling, leading to only one conclusion.

Matilda: That explosion came from the top of the tower. No, it can't be. They must be targeting the Shelter Dove.

Manus Believer: ㄟ ...

The believers freeze, then as if summoned, they raise their heads.

Matilda: If it's damaged, then this corner of the school will be exposed to the "Storm." If any students happen to be around ...

???: ...

An enemy—a humanoid husk shrouded in black—descends. Its bizarre, hulking movements manage to be even more unsettling than those of the disciples.

Matilda: What now?

Manus Disciple: ...

The figure raises its hand, pointing toward Matilda. A black vortex condenses at its fingertip.

Matilda: ...!

The vortex's impact dissolves the once-sturdy concrete as if it were foam, only narrowly missing its intended target.

Matilda teeters at the edge of this new hole. But gravity finds her, and she tumbles downward.

Matilda: Whoaaa!

Air Raid Shelter

Pain. Her first sensation is pain. It comes, sharp and certain, as she struggles to catch her breath.

Matilda: *cough* This is the underground shelter. *cough*

The hard fall leaves her head muddled, vision flickering and ears ringing.

???: *chirp*

Merel: *chirp*

As the floor above Matilda crumbles away, a little bird darts over the rubble toward her.

Merel: *chirp-chirp*

Merel dispels the transformation in a less-than-elegant fashion, then hurries to her comrade's side.

She can hear the enemy's footsteps above them, but the falling shards of cement and billowing dust obscure her vision.

Merel: Matilda! Can you hear me? Wake up!

Matilda: ...

Merel: Hang in there. I'll get these concrete blocks out of here in no time.

Merel: Alright. Let's—

Another attack thunders down from above. It grazes Merel's face, but before she can turn, she hears a scream as more cement tumbles down toward them.

Matilda: Ugh!

Merel: No! No, no, no, no, no, Matilda!

She lunges over to Matilda and, gathering all her strength, drags her from the rubble before the next attack can hit.

Merel: We have to move!

Broom Closet, Air Raid Shelter

Merel throws herself and her unconscious companion into a small, dark room.

Merel: Is this a broom closet? Alright, it'll at least take that thing some time to find us in here.

She takes a moment to recall her field first aid protocols, then lays Matilda down gently.

Merel: Please don't die. Can you hear me, Matilda?

Matilda: ...

Merel: Phew! At least she's still breathing.

Merel: Alright, let's see. Some bruises, no obvious fractures or internal bleeding.

Merel: Hm? What are these?

Several dull-looking shards have buried themselves in Matilda's clothes.

Merel: Are they crystals?

Merel: No, no, no, no, no, no. Focus, damn it. You can't get distracted.

Thoughts bombard her from every direction, but whether it's the adrenaline or some spark of confidence, she finds her center.

Merel: First, hide Matilda somewhere safe. Second, get the backup Dove to protect us from the Storm Syndrome.

Merel: Then, take Matilda to the central watchtower or the library and wait for rescue. That's the plan.

Her heart beats faster, stronger, but steady.

With deep breaths, she gets her trembling under control. Fear transforms into resolve, her mind and body reacting in sync like never before.

Merel: I can do this. I'm a soldier. I've trained for this.

Merel: Alright. Action.

Warehouse, Air Raid Shelter

Merel: The backup ... It's here. Oh, good thing I was actually listening when Matilda mentioned them.

She breathes out some relief when her Security Assistance Team key is enough to open the locked safe.

Merel: Hm. I doubt these can cover the same range without a pedestal. I'd better hurry back.

Merel: Who's there?

Cradling the Shelter Dove, she leans close against the door, listening for movement outside.

Merel: More Manus. Have they attacked the entire campus? I hope everyone's safe.

Waiting until the footsteps recede into silence, Merel slowly inches the storage room door open.

Merel: Who knows what I'll run into on my way back. Maybe I should cast invisibility on myself? But that would leave optical traces.

She racks her brain for a solution, silently cursing that she never practices these lesser-used arcane skills.

Merel: Hmm. Maybe there's something in here I can use as a disguise. Oh, how about that locker?

She crouches down and runs a hand over the sturdy metal locker.

Student: ...!

Merel: Huh? What are you doing in here?

Student: I ... I snuck out to meet Moss and Randy. We-We were going to meet ...

The sealed, empty space amplifies the approaching footsteps.

Merel: Ah, bollocks!

Merel: Stay there. Don't make a sound.

She closes the door with haste and dives behind a stack of supply boxes.

Manus Disciple: ...

Merel: I've never seen a Manus soldier like this before. What sort of weapon are they using?

Manus Disciple: ...?

Taking notice of the rustling, the dark figure lifts its finger and points toward a locker.

Rat: *squeak*

A rat scurries out from inside.

Merel: That power ... Never mind. Looks like they don't even need one.

Manus Disciple: ...

It follows the rat's movements and targets another locker.

The hand rises again.

Manus Disciple: ...?

Merel: Let me save you some trouble. I'm over here.

Merel: Are they dead?

The enemy falls, but Merel keeps her sights trained on it, watching with disgust as inky matter flows out from its broken "skull."

Merel: No, this isn't a person. It's something artificial.

Several heartbeats pass, but the enemy doesn't stir. Confident in her victory, she stows her weapon.

Student: *sob*

Beverly rushes out from his hiding place.

Student: What-What was that?

Merel grabs his head and forces him to look away.

Merel: Don't look. We'll ... We'll figure out what's going on. Just come with me for now.

Merel: ...!

Something snatches away the Shelter Dove she's holding.

Manus Disciple: ...

The loathsome creature rises to its feet, still missing half its skull. The inky void where it should be forms into eldritch tentacles as it pulls itself together.

It holds the stolen Dove in a vise grip, and with its other hand, it conjures another black vortex.

Merel: Get down!

Merel: Ugh, what?

Merel: V-Vertin? Sonetto!

Vertin: Merel, take cover!

Sonetto: It looks like their arcane skills can't pass through the crystals conjured by my incantations.

Her assessment is as calm and composed as ever, even under fire.

Sonetto: Which means I should be able to provide us protection going forward.

Merel: Its core is inside its head, Sonetto. Can you see it?

Sonetto: I see it—a breach in its skull. Maybe we can start by disabling its perception of Gnosis.

Sonetto: But I need to get closer before I can cast accurately.

Merel: Closer? I can help with that. Cover me.

Sonetto: Understood.

Sonetto: Merel, are you alright?

Merel: I'm fine.

Sonetto: Where's Matilda?

Merel: She's ...

Student: *sob*

The cowering Beverly, no longer able to suppress his terror, wipes away tears as he sobs.

Student: Will-Will it come back to life again?

Sonetto: Don't worry. We've shattered its core. It won't come back.

Sonetto: Come here. What's your name?

Student: Beverly ...

Sonetto leads the terrified student away and comforts him.

Vertin: What happened to Matilda, Merel?

Merel: She got injured badly. She's unconscious. The best I could do was hide her in a broom closet. I'll take you to her.

Merel: But how did you both get here so quickly?

Registration Desk, St. Pavlov Foundation

Yermolai: Teleport disks?

Ms. Stranger: Yes. A Laplace researcher gave the Timekeeper two disks when the alarm rang.

Ms. Stranger: She and her assistant used them to get to the SPDM.

Yermolai: How many more of these unregistered disks are there in the LSCC?

Yermolai waves his own complaints away. It isn't worth considering now.

Yermolai: Attacking headquarters is one thing, but the SPDM? What crooked reason could they have to hurt those kids?

Yermolai: Are they so desperate to replace their losses that they'd kidnap school children?

Paravyan: War makes monsters of us all, even more so for the Manus. Wait, that's where Blackbird was stationed. I hope she's alright.

Paravyan tries his best to analyze the situation.

Paravyan: The Timekeeper made the right choice. With her leadership and her assistant by her side, she should be able to keep things under control until reinforcement arrives.

Captain Osborn: Dispatch has given us our instructions. Right, Ms. Stranger?

The captain of the First Squad comes over.

Ms. Stranger: Yes. You will reinforce the SPDM with the First Squad. Meanwhile, I will mobilize the reserves and take over security here.

Yermolai: Creius picked a great time to get hauled off to court. Where are the Flying Witches?

Captain Osborn: The nearest flight unit is on its way from Zeno headquarters, but only those who are equipped with Equilibrium Umbrellas.

Captain Osborn: There's no doubt we'll be the first unit to reach the SPDM. Those children are counting on us.

Captain Osborn: Ms. Stranger, please continue the admission process. The chaos in the SPDM can't be allowed to spread to headquarters.

Lopera: First Squad assembled. Captain Osborn, we're ready to go!

Captain Osborn: Alright! Get moving!

Low on Supplies

小径

Running Out of Disks

A Brief Overview of Teleport Disk Usage in the Current Era

1. General Situation
Headquarters's teleport disk supply across all departments is critically low. As a single-use item with a limited capacity per teleportation, emergency rationing remains in effect based on current inventory. Priority is given to frontline and core mission units. Requests for additional supplies will not be approved outside of special emergencies or critical needs.

2. Cause and Background
The only known source of the primary materials for teleport disks is located in the core conflict zone of the ongoing war. Extraction operations have been fully suspended, and supply routes remain blocked. As a result of these uncontrollable factors, teleport disk production has dropped significantly, inventory continues to decline, and resupply remains uncertain.

3. Conclusion
Due to the disruption of material supplies, teleport disk stocks have entered a critical shortage. The Laplace Scientific Computing Center is actively researching substitute materials. Headquarters requires all departments to strictly adhere to rationing standards and optimize usage strategy. All combat objectives must be carefully evaluated, with disks reserved for critical junctures capable of turning the tide of battle, in order to manage current and future supply pressures.

The Alumni

13TH-07

The Alumni

Team Timekeeper's Room

Regulus: What in the name of Penny Lane is going on out there?

Regulus picks up on the shift in energy like a sour note. She rushes over to the window to look out toward the Foundation's eastern entryway.

Regulus: What's with all those people heading out? They finally got sick of being locked up in this place, too?

Regulus: But what's their angle? Busting out to put on a concert right before the "Storm" hits? Cor, that'd be mad. But you'd have to admire their rockin' spirit.

Sotheby: Oh, oh! That's Lopera.

Sotheby has, somewhat inexplicably, produced a telescope and joins Regulus as they peer out the window.

Sotheby: She's leaving too. But what's got everyone in such a hurry?

Not possessed of an abundance of sense for puzzles, the two turn to face the others in the room.

Druvis III: That's the Pre-Storm Quick Reaction Force she's leaving with. They're probably being dispatched to solve some crisis outside of headquarters.

Sotheby: A crisis?

Sotheby: Oh my! Is there anything we can do? Vertin—Huh? Where have Vertin and Sonetto gone off to?

Regulus: We might've been able to ask them if we hadn't been thrown in these boring gray rooms again. How dare they take our lovely, comfy Suitcase from us!

Regulus: This is just like the first time I got locked up in this pencil-pusher's paradise. I bet those suits are up to something this time, too.

Regulus: Not to worry though, 'cause this captain has her ways. My dutiful chief mate is already gathering intel.

The room's door creaks open, and, right on cue, APPLe floats inside.

APPLe: Captain, I ran into Ms. Stranger on the way back. I think she can explain the situation.

Regulus: Ms. Stranger? Wait, you mean that phony captain of the "Free Breeze"?

Ms. Stranger: ...

A sudden chill covers the room as the door widens to reveal the target of Regulus's exclamation. Yet the words don't find purchase on her elegant face.

Ms. Stranger: Team Timekeeper, I wanted to inform you of Ms. Vertin and Sonetto's status.

Ms. Stranger: Ten minutes ago, we received a report on an emergency at the SPDM. They've made their way there via teleport disk.

Regulus: Hang about, just the two of them? Not fair! Why're we cooped up here when we could be helping out?

APPLe: Erm, with all due respect, Captain, we do have a job to do.

APPLe: The rest of Team Timekeeper will serve as a reserve unit of the Pre-Storm QRF during personnel admission.

Regulus: Huh! Come to think of it, I did hear someone mentioning us being a reserve. But I thought that just meant we'd be stuck sitting on our hands waiting for something to do.

Ms. Stranger: The First Squad is on their way to the SPDM. They will join the Timekeeper as soon as possible.

Sotheby: Then let's get ready, shall we? Huh, ah, I'll whip up some pain-relieving dew and misty mist spray in a jiffy.

Regulus: I want the Foundation's fastest car. No, motorbike. Those kids need help, and this rockin' pirate is going to give it to 'em.

The two of them conspire together, poised to begin a heroic rescue mission even if it means running straight into the maw of the coming "Storm."

Druvis, meanwhile, locks eyes with Ms. Stranger.

Ms. Stranger & Druvis III: ...

Druvis III: Might I speak with you in the hallway, Ms. Stranger?

Ms. Stranger: Of course, Ms. Druvis.

The two exit to the corridor, leaving a growing ruckus behind them.

Druvis III: We won't be leaving headquarters, will we?

Ms. Stranger: No, but I didn't have the heart to rain on their parade.

Ms. Stranger: Your job is to protect headquarters, now that the First Squad has left.

Ms. Stranger: Dispatch doesn't want the emergency at the SPDM to interrupt the admission process. Both are equally important.

Druvis III: Hasn't the Foundation been recruiting more talent than ever in the past few months? I doubt manpower is a problem anymore.

Druvis III: Is it in any way possible to reassign this duty to another unit so we can reinforce the Timekeeper?

Ms. Stranger: We have expanded our staff considerably, but many of the new members are from the current era. This is their first "Storm." Their reaction to it could be unpredictable.

Ms. Stranger: Unfortunately, we've determined it's best not to put them on any tasks in the lead-up to it. In fact, we've been keeping them under close surveillance.

Ms. Stranger: It doesn't help that many of them still carry grudges from the war. Not all of them were on the same side.

Ms. Stranger: Still, there's no need to worry for your friends. The First Squad are experienced in dealing with Manus Vindictae. The Timekeeper is in safe hands.

She pauses to listen to the moth beside her ear.

Ms. Stranger: I don't suppose you can manage to pacify them?

Druvis III: They're hardly what I would call "obedient."

Ms. Stranger: Then they'll have to learn to live with it. The Foundation has rules for a reason.

Druvis III: ...

Druvis III: I'll do my best. But I can't promise anything.

Druvis III: The first time we came to the Foundation, they also took the Suitcase from Vertin under the guise of "research."

Druvis III: I'm afraid there isn't much I can do to dissuade their suspicion, nor their dissatisfaction.

Ms. Stranger: I'm grateful as long as you are willing to try, Ms. Druvis.

Ms. Stranger: "Razor" will contact you soon to give you further instructions.

Before she leaves, Ms. Stranger pauses at the door to Team Timekeeper's temporary lodgings.

Ms. Stranger: Apparently, neither you nor I like the characters we're playing on this stage.

Broom Closet, Air Raid Shelter

Vertin: How's Matilda doing?

Sonetto: Her vitals are strong, and she doesn't appear to have any dangerous wounds, but she still hasn't come to.

Sonetto: Her crystal ball is broken. I suspect it took the brunt of the damage. But we need to get her some professional medical help to know more.

Vertin: If only Ms. Tooth Fairy weren't at the UK branch with Flutterpage right now.

Vertin: Still, there should be medical staff on-site at the school. Let's move Matilda somewhere safe and start looking.

Merel: Vertin!

A dusty, disheveled Merel emerges from the corner.

Merel: I've checked the shelter. There aren't any other students or staff. Some walls have collapsed, though. We can't access the other underground facilities.

Vertin: There's no time to clear debris. We'll have to move above ground.

Merel: Aren't we going to wait for reinforcements?

Vertin: No. The clock is ticking. We can't afford to wait.

Sonetto, having already reviewed the manual from cover to cover after receiving their assignment, lowers her head in contemplation.

Sonetto: This tower's Shelter Dove has been destroyed. And the backup can only keep us safe for ten minutes without a pedestal.

Vertin: And to make matters worse, I don't have my Suitcase. If things go wrong, you could all be infected with the Storm Syndrome.

Merel: ...

Merel can't help but look at the Shelter Dove lying on the ground. Though only a few minutes have passed, its glow has dimmed significantly.

Merel: So, where should we go now?

Vertin: Normally, I'd suggest the central watchtower. It's where the instructors used to tell us to go in case of emergencies.

Vertin: But I don't imagine we'd make it that far with a comatose patient and a child.

Vertin: Our best choice is the library. It's close by and "Storm"-proof.

Vertin: With any luck, we'll find something useful, or at least some other people.

Beneath her calm exterior, new worries surface in the chief assistant's mind.

Sonetto: What if the Manus are already there?

Vertin: We take them down. And if there are too many of them, we'll pass through it to the clinic. We need to take Matilda there anyway.

Vertin: The plan is settled then. We'd better get moving. The "Storm" waits for no one.

Vertin: If combat breaks out, I'll do what I can to protect Matilda and Beverly.

Vertin: I'll trust you both to handle whatever stands in our way.

Sonetto: Understood.

Merel: S-Sure. Just leave it to us.

Vertin: Alright. Grab Beverly, and let's move.

Path, SPDM

Merel: Sonetto!

Sonetto: Regna sereno intenso ed infinito!

Light flows from the tip of her glasfeder, condenses, then cleaves through the air like a sword.

Manus Believer: ヒ ...

Merel: *exhalation* Vertin, Beverly, all clear.

Beverly: Wow!

Vertin: Stay calm and keep your eyes open. Watch your step.

Merel: Vertin? What are you looking at?

Vertin: Nothing. Let's get inside.

Vertin: The side entrance is right ahead. Keep going.

Merel: Let me get the door.

Merel turns. Just as she readies herself to run, the library's side door swings open.

Merel: ...?!

Lavender: Everyone, get in here. Quickly.

Hallway, Library

The door is slammed shut, and a small cadre of students inside slide desks and chairs into place behind them to reinforce it.

Beverly: Moss! Randy! You're alright!

Beverly runs toward his classmates.

Rows of bookshelves divide the library into a series of compact alcoves, nearly every one of which is now filled with children in white uniforms.

Merel: All these students ...

Lavender stands in shock as she watches the unconscious Matilda being carried into the library.

Lavender: What-What happened to Ms. Matilda?

Vertin: She's wounded. Could you find a quiet room and help me move her there? She may have suffered some trauma to her head, so we need to be very careful.

Merel: I remember there were couches in the reading room. Are they still there?

Lavender: They are. Do you remember where it is?

Merel: Yeah. Vertin, let me help you put Matilda there.

Vertin: Alright.

Lavender: ...

Lavender makes a sharp and precise turn to face Sonetto.

Lavender: Ms. Sonetto, my name is Lavender, Ninth Grade Monitor Assistant. It's an honor to meet you.

Sonetto: An honor? You know about me?

Lavender: You're an SPDM legend! A lot of us know you from the school parade.

Said legend finds herself struggling to accept the sudden burst of praise.

Sonetto: I'm flattered. It's very nice to meet you, Lavender. Are you the one who led all these students here?

Lavender: That's right. I'd just gotten back to the ceremony when the explosions went off. The instructors told us ninth-graders to lead all the students here.

Lavender: We're the oldest students and the only ones who have received any real training, so it's our duty to protect the lower grades. But, honestly, thank goodness you showed up.

It's clear she's attempting to seem more in control than she truly feels. The scale and danger of this crisis are far beyond anything she could have prepared for.

Sonetto: Where are the guards and your instructors now?

Lavender: I don't know. They just ordered us to head to the library. A few of them came with us, but they're not doing so well.

Lavender: They got hurt protecting us from the Manus on our way over.

Sonetto: You know about Manus Vindictae?

Lavender: Yes, and the "Storm" too. I was told about it as a part of my role as monitor assistant. All these things that are happening means the "Storm" is about to arrive, doesn't it?

Lavender: I-I understand that we're not allowed to talk about it on school grounds, but given the situation ...

Sonetto: I think we can make an exception. You need to be prepared for the possible dangers ahead.

Lavender: Thank you so much, miss. You don't know how relieved I was when I saw you coming to our rescue. So, you were sent here by the Foundation, right?

Lavender: That means headquarters already knows what's going on. Will there be more reinforcements?

Sonetto: Yes, and they're already on their way. We'll be safe soon.

Lavender: Thank goodness! Phew. We'll follow your orders until then. By the way, who's that woman who was carrying Matilda? Is she your assistant?

Sonetto: ...

Sonetto: That was Vertin, the Foundation's Timekeeper. And, in fact, I'm her chief assistant.

Lavender's eyes open wide in disbelief.

Lavender: You mean that was Vertin? THE Vertin?! I heard she ran away from the school and got expelled. How did you come to be her assistant?

Vertin: Yes, I'm the Vertin you've heard about. But I was never expelled.

Lavender: —?!

Lavender: S-Sorry. When did you ...?

Vertin: It's more than alright. It's only natural that people would start rumors with me coming here so rarely.

Lavender never imagined she'd run into so many "campus legends" all at once.

Lavender: How could it be? Ah, never mind. I'll do whatever I can to help, Ver—Ms. Timekeeper.

Vertin: Vertin is just fine, Lavender.

Vertin: Could you tell me more about the situation here? We need all the details.

Lavender: Of course, but it might be better to go somewhere that the other students can't hear us.

Bumpy Roads

13TH-08

Bumpy Roads

Study Room, Library

Lavender: That's everything I know.

Vertin: Thank you.

A map of the campus "on loan" from the library is laid out over the table.

Vertin: The good news is most of the students are accounted for within the library, and it's secure for now. But, that's basically where the good news ends.

Vertin: We haven't seen any signs of the instructors nor the school security. They may have retreated into the central watchtower, but if that's the case, I don't understand why they would send the children here.

Vertin: We've viewed what we can from the windows in the reading room. It seems impossible to reach the central watchtower safely.

Vertin: The campus is crawling with Manus believers, and that's just the ones we can see. I doubt we could even make it as far as the central square.

Vertin: All four corner watchtowers are damaged, and I believe their Shelter Doves have been disabled.

Vertin: As for the library, it's only safe because the Dove in the central watchtower is still operational.

Merel: So we just bunker down here and wait for reinforcements, right?

Vertin: ...

Vertin: I'm afraid we can't. The central tower's immunity range is shrinking.

Merel: What?

Vertin: Unfortunately, if I'm correct, the library will be exposed before the "Storm" arrives.

Sonetto: Then we need to make our way to the central watchtower. But I'm not sure we have the strength to clear a path there.

Sonetto: We can take advantage of the library's layout to hold the line for a little longer, but ...

Sonetto: If the major Dove's immunity range keeps shrinking, it won't make much difference.

Merel: So, then, what do we do?

Vertin: We wait.

Vertin: The Foundation's reinforcements should be here any minute. They'll have brought enough Equilibrium Umbrellas for everyone.

Inside the Car

5 minutes earlier.

Yermolai: Hold on tight!

The speeding armored vehicle collides with the ground.

Paravyan & Lopera: Ah!

Its front lifts as it rises out of the pit like a ship cresting over a churning sea.

Even with their seat belts fastened tight, the impact jostles the occupants. As they regain composure, eyes shift to the winding mountain road ahead.

Lopera: Why are these roads so bumpy?

Yermolai: What, haven't driven around here much yet? You'll get used to it. Rocks slide down off the mountain from time to time.

Paravyan: How far are we from the SPDM?

Yermolai: Fifteen minutes, give or take.

Lopera: How did Manus Vindictae manage to infiltrate the school? Security didn't notice anything?

Yermolai: Tsk. The guards are only equipped with tranq guns. They wouldn't have been much use against the Manus.

Yermolai: This isn't actually the first time they've attacked the SPDM.

Yermolai: But this time they've sent an army instead of Olitiaus. Won't be quite so easy to deal with.

Lopera twists around to survey the convoy behind them.

Lopera: That won't be a problem. We're more than ready, aren't we?

Paravyan: Blackbird was at the school before the attack. Just when I thought she might get to take a break. I hope she's alright. Well, she's probably completely freaked out, but I hope she's safe, at least.

Yermolai: Quit your whinging, Beagle. Focus on the mission.

Yermolai: Our little birdie's gonna be just fine.

Lopera: Is this Blackbird a friend of yours?

Yermolai: Yeah. She might not think she's a soldier, but she's a survivor. If Antarctica and the Eastern Front couldn't kill her, she can handle a school.

Paravyan: But she's never really fought the Manus directly, has she? Only Critters and penguins in Antarctica. Oh, and then the rebels.

Lopera: The rebels?

Yermolai: Ahem!

Yermolai: There's one thing you need to know, Beagle. Same thing I learned during her combat training—

screech

Paravyan & Lopera: Whoa!

The brakes squeal as Yermolai slams the armored car to a halt.

Lopera: What now?

Yermolai: Captain signaled us to stop. Let me go check.

Mountain Road

First Squad captain's car is stopped a short distance ahead. Captain Osborn stands nearby, issuing commands over his communicator.

Captain Osborn: All units, pull over. Formation Y, stay alert. We have a situation.

Captain Osborn: Arcane Support, move up ahead.

Captain Osborn: All team, check your wearable Equilibrium Umbrellas. Make sure they're functional.

He hangs up and turns his attention to Yermolai. The Equilibrium Umbrella at his hip, fastened with a Hofmann Knot, is emitting a faint glow.

Captain Osborn: Did you notice?

Yermolai: Yeah, and I double-checked too.

He gazes back over the rising hills surrounding them with intent.

Yermolai: I'm not claiming to be an expert on these roads, but I can tell you one thing: We turned that same goddamn corner three minutes ago.

Yermolai: Right down to that daft rat-looking boulder.

Yermolai: Oh man! Think we could be trapped in a Maze Net?

Captain Osborn: Unlikely. A Maze Net couldn't cover a convoy so large.

Captain Osborn: Well, at least of the ones we've encountered before.

Yermolai: *sigh* Hate wasting time with these arcane props.

Captain Osborn: Take it as a good sign.

Yermolai: Sorry?

Captain Osborn: If Manus Vindictae had the firepower, they wouldn't be trying to keep us distracted, which means we're a threat. They're trying to buy time.

Captain Osborn: Once Arcane Support decodes this arcane skill, or whatever it is ...

Yermolai: No, wait.

He raises his head to scan their surroundings again. It seems as if he's trying to sniff the danger out from thin air.

Yermolai: That can't be right. Manus Vindictae's grown way more aggressive since the war in Europe. They wouldn't back down from a fight.

Yermolai: If their only objective was to buy time, they would've set up closer to the school, somewhere they could reinforce quickly and keep us pinned down.

Yermolai: So, why choose this spot? Looking around, this seems like a perfect place for ... a f**king ambush!

Yermolai: Everyone, get back to your vehicles! Now!

Captain Osborn: *choke*

Yermolai: Captain! Damn it!

He dives under an incoming incantation, using the momentum to roll toward the safety of his vehicle.

Paravyan: Yermolai, get in.

Yermolai wastes no time getting inside.

Yermolai: Enemies on the slope. Fall back.

Square, Committee Building

Despite the ongoing threats, the Foundation continues trudging through its Pre-Storm procedures as planned, but it has become obvious that their capacity is being stretched to its limits.

People are loitering outside the Committee Building, waiting for further direction. Two squadmates squeeze through the anxious crowd of refugees.

J: I'm gonna disagree with you there, "El Capitan."

J comes to an abrupt stop as they end their patrol. His voice drips with contempt, though it isn't directed at his superior.

"Razor" doesn't need to guess what's coming—another complaint from his newest recruit. As a captain, he has weathered them a thousand times and obliges with a sympathetic ear.

J: All those people out there ... makes me think of the folks that line up outside the soup kitchens, only there ain't any soup. No shelter either. Just a shove to send them on their way.

"Razor": The Foundation can only admit so many people.

J: So, what, they get to pick and choose who lives and who dies? We throw equality out of the window just because of the "Storm"?

J: I've tried to understand why my sister chose to join the Foundation, but what would she say if she saw this?

J: I can't shake the thought outta my head: those cold-hearted bastards sitting back in their glossy offices with comfy chairs, pretending to be philanthropists while they leave people to die.

"Razor": Do me a favor, J. Do your complaining in private. I don't want to have to be the one pulling rank and charging you with insubordination.

J: Whatever. I know we can't help everyone, but you ain't convincing me that this is for the "greater good."

"Razor": We ... What we're dealing with here is more complex than things back on Haight Street. I'm sure you remember.

The ring of his communicator rescues "Razor" from an imminent clash of organizational discipline and street philosophy.

"Razor": ...

"Razor": Your shift's almost over, J. Why don't you go grab something in the lounge? Maybe have a chat with Todd.

J: You not coming with?

"Razor": I've got new orders.

Temporary Product

小径

Wearable Equilibrium Umbrella User Manual

> The Wearable Equilibrium Umbrella is a compact version of the standard Equilibrium Umbrella with the canopy removed. It retains the core Hofmann Knot structure, converter, and harmonizer, and is equipped with a waist-mounted nylon buckle—lightweight, durable, and secure against accidental loss. Designed for armed personnel operating in the "Storm," it reduces the burden of carrying a full umbrella while significantly improving combat mobility.
>
> Please note the following precautions during use:
> 1. To ensure the stability of the Hofmann Knot, the device retains a glass casing to maintain optimal arcane conductivity. Although the casing has been specially reinforced, it cannot withstand heavy impacts. Avoid striking it with force or exposing it to sharp edges.
> 2. As development time was limited, the rain-shielding effectiveness of this canopy-free design remains unverified, and distribution has been limited accordingly. Each person must carry and wear their own unit at all times. Sharing a single device between two or more individuals risks insufficient coverage and may result in serious consequences.
> 3. Armed units are advised to request backup Wearable Equilibrium Umbrellas and a number of standard Equilibrium Umbrellas when submitting their application, in case of emergencies.

Rules Are Rules

13TH-09

Rules Are Rules

Foundation Office

Operation Team Leader I: No comms from the First Squad?

"Razor" catches the bad news as he enters their makeshift command post. His brow furrows beneath his mask as he surveys the room.

Several familiar squad captains are present, as well as the one who summoned them—Ms. Stranger—now standing before a desk.

"Razor": Oh, everyone's here.

Operation Team Leader II: Over here, "Razor." We've just started.

"Razor": Don't mind me. You were talking about the First Squad? They were the ones sent to the SPDM, right?

Ms. Stranger: Dispatch has lost contact with them. We're not sure whether they're in danger or if communication has been jammed by the "Storm."

Operation Team Leader II: Will we send another unit?

Ms. Stranger: No. Dispatch has decided we can't risk sending anyone else with the "Storm" arriving so soon.

Though the piecemeal tactic is ultimately rejected, the captains in attendance know better than to openly defy their superiors.

"Razor": Is there any clearer reason why they made that decision?

Ms. Stranger: We can't risk leaving headquarters short-handed if an emergency breaks out. Besides, mobilizing another unit could easily spark panic among the people being processed.

Ms. Stranger: Dispatch has determined that if we cannot make contact, it'll be better to deploy after the "Storm" has passed.

Operation Team Leader II: Then what are we here for, Ms. Stranger?

Ms. Stranger: Your teams will be performing reconnaissance in force as soon as the "Storm" ends. You are to gather any intel about the status of the First Squad and SPDM as soon as possible. I need you to prepare your teams in advance.

Ms. Stranger: But let me be clear. The purpose of this mission and the status of the SPDM and First Squad are on a need-to-know basis. You are not permitted to inform the lower ranks at this time.

Ms. Stranger: We have to take into account the possibility that some of your newer team members may act on impulse if they hear the news, especially the arcanists among them.

"Razor": That's fair. I'm not sure I could hold some of them back from rushing into the "Storm" if they thought they could help.

"Razor": For the good of the operation, we'll keep our mouths shut. Human or arcanist, we need to prioritize our teams' well-being.

Operation Team Leader I: Osborn's team will be fine. They have numbers, skills, and the latest gear. The Manus won't take them out—not without a fight.

Operation Team Leader I: I bet they'll be crowd surfing above the cheering students by the time we get to the SPDM.

Operation Team Leader II: Ms. Stranger, I've kept an eye on Team Timekeeper as ordered. I wouldn't say they're the most disciplined group, but they're doing fine.

Operation Team Leader II: Except the one that claims to be some kind of pirate-rockstar-come-freedom fighter. She's been selling the others on an escape plan.

Ms. Stranger: ...

Ms. Stranger: "Razor," could I ask you to speak to Regulus? You saved her life once on the Aegean. Perhaps she'll listen to you.

Ms. Stranger: Here are your mission briefings: Keep them secret; keep them safe.

She hands each of the assembled captains a file.

Ms. Stranger: Please follow Dispatch's instructions and report in before you make further decisions. You have your orders. Dismissed.

The other captains take their leave, and Ms. Stranger prepares to follow.

"Razor": Wait, Ms. Stranger.

Registration Desk, St. Pavlov Foundation

Soldier I: What? I have to leave my things behind?

A soldier in a tattered uniform stands before the registration counter, a large bag set down beside him.

Registrar: Those are the rules, sir.

Registrar: I believe you've been informed that each individual is allowed only a maximum of 20 kilograms. Any excess baggage must be discarded unless it qualifies as military equipment.

Registrar: Since there is no military equipment in your baggage and ... You know what? I don't have time for this. Don't you see the line behind you?

Soldier I: Do you have any idea what I've been through to get here?

He points toward the Foundation symbol adorning the counter with a grim stare.

Soldier I: I spent three months in the trenches fighting Manus Vindictae for this organization. Now you're asking me to throw away what's left of my life?

Soldier I: And it's not just my belongings. I brought things for my little brother, too. The commander said we'd be moving again after we sign this contract. I don't see why I have to throw it all away.

Foundation security make their way over to the counter, flanking the man on both sides.

Foundation Security: Calm down, sir. You'll have to discard any excess baggage before we can allow you entry. No exceptions.

Foundation Security: We need to get you all processed quickly so you can sign your military service contracts. There's a lot of paperwork to do.

Soldier I: ...

Another soldier who had arrived with him approaches.

Soldier II: Just do as he says, Arthur. You know these bureaucrat types. They're no different here than any back home.

Soldier II: Heads are too clogged up with rules and regulations. There's no talking any sense into them. Might as well save yourself the bother.

At his comrade's behest, the soldier finally parts with his belongings.

Soldier I: Hmph.

From the other side of the hall, a tall and lithe woman has been watching the scene unfold.

Druvis III: ...

Someone else joins her.

Ms. Stranger: What are you doing here, Ms. Druvis?

Druvis III: Just looking around.

Druvis III: I guess I find it odd seeing all these long lines. It's not normal to have so many people waiting to come in, especially so close to the "Storm."

Druvis III: Soon, they'll be putting on Foundation uniforms. And then, just like that, they'll be told to say goodbye to their family, friends, homelands—their entire era.

Ms. Stranger: Please, Ms. Druvis, it's best we don't talk about that here. Most of those waiting in line aren't aware of this "issue."

Druvis III: They've been fighting Manus Vindictae for months. Don't you think they might have learned something from our enemies?

Ms. Stranger: The Foundation's policy forbids revealing information on the "Storm" to any personnel from the current era. It doesn't matter what they may or may not already know.

Druvis III: ...

Ms. Stranger: What is it?

Druvis III: Was that sarcasm in your voice? You find the Foundation's policy absurd too, don't you?

Ms. Stranger: I wouldn't say that.

Druvis III: Vertin told me about you. You went under deep cover in Manus Vindictae, forced yourself to become someone you're not, did things you've come to regret ...

Druvis III: You paid an unimaginable price to complete the Foundation's mission.

Druvis III: But even now, after you've returned home, you're dissatisfied with the character you're playing.

Druvis III: I can't help but wonder what the "you" you really want to be is like.

Ms. Stranger: ...

Ms. Stranger: I don't know. I've never had the time to answer that question.

Ms. Stranger: The Foundation only gave me a new role, not a new identity. They expected me to fall back into my old self.

Druvis III: Are you here to check in on us? To make sure we aren't planning anything too radical?

Druvis III: You can rest assured. It won't happen.

Ms. Stranger: I appreciate it. Then, let's put it behind us. Thank you for trusting the Foundation.

Druvis III: But I don't trust the Foundation. I've always doubted their ability to bring about their professed order and peace for all.

Ms. Stranger: It might be best to end our conversation here, Ms. Druvis.

Druvis ignores the suggestion.

Druvis III: They bring these people in under false pretenses, knowing full well that after the "Storm" wipes out their era, they'll be isolated and moldable. And just like that, the Foundation gets a new generation of puppets.

Druvis III: Uprooted, shorn down, and processed, like trees turned into logs. No one ever asks them what they want to be. They never get that chance.

Druvis III: I work with the Foundation only because of Vertin. I am loyal to her, devoted to her cause. Not yours.

Druvis III: I can face the uncertainty of the future because I know what I'm fighting for. How would these people react if they found out the truth?

Druvis III: Don't you think some of them would rather risk their lives to find another shelter than give up their freedom to the Foundation?

Ms. Stranger: You mean they might want to join Manus Vindictae.

Druvis III: Or the Gryphon Legion, or some other shelter we don't know of, like the Apeiron island.

Druvis III: How long do you think the Foundation's policies would hold if they didn't present themselves as the only option?

Druvis III: ...!

Ms. Stranger: That's a stage one alert.

A high-pitched alarm drones over their voices, blaring out from all directions.

The tone and rhythm are too rare a combination for most to immediately realize their meaning.

Registrar: What? What's going on now?

Soldier I: An assault? Or a bombardment?

Male Investigator: Everyone, stay calm and wait for further instructions.

Druvis III: Could it be something related to the Storm Syndrome? Or another attack outside?

Ms. Stranger: Neither. A stage one alert means ...

The color drains from her face as she turns toward the Committee Building.

Ms. Stranger: A major crisis is happening inside headquarters.

Ms. Stranger: Ms. Druvis, please return to Team Timekeeper and lead them to the nearest shelter.

Ms. Stranger offers a wordless goodbye and rushes off.

Druvis III: ...

Warning: Stage one alert. Unidentified intruders in headquarters. Emergency evacuation procedures initiated.

Broadcast: All personnel are to obey ranking officers during evacuation and await further instructions in the emergency shelters.

Broadcast: This is not a drill. Repeat: Stage one alert. Unidentified intruders in headquarters.

Arcana: Well, well. It is of little surprise—

Arcana: That the white fortress doth not extend its courtesy to an unbidden guest.

Arcana: Yet I shall brook no refusal.

Southern Garden, St. Pavlov Foundation

Ustrina: A most impressive display of strength.

İlmek: Look at them run. Perhaps I overdid things.

İlmek: *sigh* I wish I didn't have to be so rough with them.

Arcana: ...

Ustrina: Guiding One.

The followers watch as their deity approaches the Committee Building in slow, deft steps.

Taira: How has our ambush against the Foundation's Response Squad proceeded?

Krutov: They've been taken care of.

Taira: Hm. Impressive. Then I need only point my blade forward.

Krutov: Heh, bringing a knife to a gunfight, you are a hoot.

Krutov turns his gaze from the shell covered in warped patterns and toward his troops.

Krutov: Assault squads, lock down the first floor of the Committee Building. Eliminate any resistance.

Krutov: We'll demolish their tower and rip the guts from these arrogant hypocrites!

Manus Soldier I: Yes, sir!

Hallway, St. Pavlov Foundation

Foundation Staff Member I: Run!

Foundation Staff Member II: It's Manus Vindictae! I saw them!

Ms. Stranger: ...

A white figure brushes past her as the sounds of gunshots and incantations reverberate through the crowded corridor.

The footsteps grow sparser. It's time to go. She shouldn't push against the flow of the crowd anymore.

???: You ...

Arcana: Ms. Stranger raises her head.

Arcana: Grace, a moth sealed inside a human's cage.

Ms. Stranger: Arcana? No, this can't be happening.

Arcana: You need not fear. I come only seeking an answer. We have no dark designs.

Arcana: To speak thy name doth please me still, and I do not forget the deeds thou once didst for us, grieved though I am by thy betrayal.

Arcana: Come hither, child. For I carry a gift that should have long ago been bestowed upon thee.

Ms. Stranger: ...!

The Everlasting Chaos

小径

What's beneath your hat?

Choices

1. My head
2. My face

Branch 1

Just a head, no creepy black bones sticking out from your temples?

Thank goodness. I'm not sure I could handle another conversation with those lunatics.

I do hope, if you ever find a bone stuck through your brain one day, that you won't hesitate to see a doctor.

Branch 2

But why bother covering such a pretty face? You're young and good-looking.

Don't be so shy to show it off. If that boneheaded lunatic doesn't bother to hide her face, you shouldn't either.

But seriously, if you do find a bone stuck through your brain one day, don't hesitate to see a doctor.

I don't call that woman a lunatic without good reason.

Choices

1. I doubt I would survive it
2. It might hurt a bit

Branch 2.1

So you say, but you know what happened to her: she died and came back.

That is a rare privilege. How many can say they had the same gift? Death tends to be terribly final for most.

She was the exception, and just look at what she's made of it.

Branch 2.2

Life is pain. Lately it seems like every bone in my body aches ... Worse, the pain seems to come no matter the weather.

But I wasn't rewarded with immortality for all my pains.

It seems unfair that a privilege like that should be given to such a troublemaker.

This whole damned world is coming to an end!

Shared continuation

Shared continuation

The Everlasting Chaos

Emergency Measures

13TH-10

Emergency Measures

Countdown to the "Storm"

Courtroom

Broadcast: Warning: Stage one alert. Unidentified intruders in headquarters. Emergency evacuation procedures initiated.

Broadcast: All personnel are to obey ranking officers during evacuation and await further instructions in the emergency shelters.

Broadcast: This is not a drill. Repeat: Stage one alert. Unidentified intruders in headquarters.

Special Tribunal Officer: Quiet in the court. The trial will not be interrupted.

Special Tribunal Officer: The Foundation's security forces are more than capable of handling whatever emergency is occurring outside. This tribunal is perfectly safe.

Irinei: Your Honor, might I suggest a recess until the end of this crisis? There are a number of critical personnel gathered here.

Irinei: I have no doubt our security forces are capable, but without senior leadership to direct them, chaos is inevitable.

Pedra: We must evacuate to the nearest emergency shelter immediately and wait for rescue. As the ranking officer, Your Honor, you are in command of the evacuation.

Special Tribunal Officer: You're right.

Special Tribunal Officer: In that case, I declare a recess until the end of this present crisis. During this period, the defendant shall remain in custody. Other personnel will return to their positions and—

Creius: You're going to get people killed!

Special Tribunal Officer: Mr. Creius, I would remind you that any statements you make will be on the record when the court returns to session.

Creius: I know, but I'll say it anyway. Because I know the truth is on my side, Your Honor.

Creius: Listen to me, everyone. Forget the procedures. If the Manus are brazen enough to attack us at our headquarters while the "Storm" is imminent, then they must have come with overwhelming force.

Creius: We'll need all personnel and every asset to resist this assault. If we can concentrate our defenses here, the long and narrow corridors of the Committee Building can work to our advantage.

Creius: This will be a fight for our lives.

Special Tribunal Officer: Mr. Creius, what evidence do you have that this "assault" is beyond what is already accounted for in our emergency procedures?

Irinei: Indeed. You're a former Vigil, Creius; you should be well aware that there is simply no teleportation array with the capacity to move such a force into our security perimeter undetected.

Creius: Have you already forgotten our investigation into Hill 299? They hollowed it out and transferred ten thousand soldiers inside without being noticed.

Creius: We cannot rule out that Manus Vindictae now possesses some form of stealthy, high-capacity teleport array. We all but confirmed it following their movement patterns during the Don Operation.

Creius: There's a decent chance this assault is stronger than our protocols can handle. We have to mobilize everyone—anyone who can stand needs to be a part of this fight.

Pedra: Including our civilian staff? They don't know the first thing about combat! This plan of yours could only result in needless death.

Creius: I'm not asking for them to pick up a rifle. They'll set up barricades, run messages, care for the wounded—anything they can do to help.

Creius: We have a hall full of soldiers, veterans of this era's battle against Manus Vindictae, all prepared to sign our military service contract. They could be the key to organizing a counterattack, if they aren't already in the fight.

Special Tribunal Officer: Even if we agreed to execute your plan, no one present has the authority to command it.

There's static over the loudspeaker, then a calm female voice, so calm it seems as if it must be a pre-recorded warning.

Special Broadcast: Attention: This is an official Presidential Office broadcast. Emergency evacuation procedures are canceled. All combat personnel to battle stations.

Special Broadcast: Non-combatants in distress, prepare to resist within safe limits.

Special Broadcast: The Pre-Storm Dispatch Center takes command of all units, effective immediately. Any personnel unable to reach safety or receive direct orders are permitted to resist by any means available. There will be no liability assigned for any damage to headquarters sustained during resistance efforts.

Special Broadcast: May the peace be with us.

Battle stations—an unprecedented situation for headquarters. Across the sprawling complex, staff begin to organize.

Special Tribunal Officer: May the peace be with us.

The Special Tribunal Officer aims to be the first to the door, but Creius is faster, eager to take the opportunity to leave.

A tiny yet shrill screech rings in Ms. Stranger's ears. In the end, however, it's drowned out by a wave of other noises.

Room, St. Pavlov Foundation

Ms. Stranger: Ugh!

It feels as though her ears are bleeding. Fortunately, when she raises a hand to check, she finds it to be only sweat.

Ms. Stranger: How did I get here?

She tilts her head back. It offers some relief from the tinnitus.

Now, her senses are overwhelmed by the cries coming from outside the corridor, gunshots, and incantations.

Ms. Stranger: Arcana didn't kill me. What did she ...?

She presses her temple. She feels it—something massive yet hollow swelling inside her skull, enveloping her thoughts in the blackest of nights.

???: Ms. Stranger! You're awake.

Someone reaches out to help her up.

Eagle: Are you okay? Any pain?

Ms. Stranger: Ah, Eagle?

Ms. Stranger: Yes, I'm fine, I think. But how did we end up here?

Eagle: I got separated from Ms. Marguerite in the assault. The Manus captured the first floor before I could reach the emergency shelter.

Eagle: I was running along the hallway and found you passed out on the floor. Luckily, a guard saw us and helped me move you here.

Eagle: We're safe here, well, for now.

Ms. Stranger: Thank you, Eagle. What about the guard?

Eagle: He ...

Eagle looks over to a guard lying in a heap along with a Manus soldier. Both are dead.

A damaged mask lies at Ms. Stranger's feet.

Ms. Stranger: ...

Ms. Stranger: We need to go.

Eagle: But where, Ms. Stranger?

Ms. Stranger: Somewhere—anywhere else. It's too dangerous to stay here.

Ms. Stranger: If they've secured the first floor, then they've likely already begun searching it room by room for survivors.

Eagle: But there are so many of them out there. We can—

She spots the mask in Ms. Stranger's hand.

Eagle: Please don't put it on, Ms. Stranger.

Ms. Stranger: It'll deceive the Manus soldiers. I'll use it to find a way out for us.

Ms. Stranger: Don't worry. The Foundation's headquarters was designed as a military fortress. There are plenty of hidden shelters around. We'll find a safe place.

Eagle: But once we're out in the open, it'll be just the two of us against all of them. The Scout Code would say that we should hold in place and wait for rescue.

Ms. Stranger: The battle is still raging. Even if they've managed to hold the line somewhere, it's unlikely they'll be sending rescue teams any time soon.

Eagle: Hmm? Ms. Stranger?

Ms. Stranger: Manus Vindictae could find this room at any time. We can't stay here.

Ms. Stranger: I promise I will get you out of here, Eagle. You wouldn't have been trapped if you hadn't saved me.

Eagle: It's not your fault, Ms. Stranger. I made that decision myself.

Ms. Stranger: I know. It's just ...

Ms. Stranger: I can't shake the feeling that I'm to blame. I must have missed something, some detail that could have helped us foresee this attack.

Ms. Stranger: I need to make up for this mistake, even if all I can do is save one life.

Ms. Stranger: We need to go. Now.

Ms. Stranger is once again her calm, collected self. She's still holding the mask. Black globs of liquid drip from it.

Eagle: Are you really going to put it on?

Ms. Stranger: Only when I have to. I need a disguise if I'm to avoid combat.

Ms. Stranger: —?!

???: There they are!

???: Wait! She's got a mask in her hand.

???: Watch out! There's a kid, J.

J: Oh, sorry. I figured you were one of them.

J: You don't need that mask anymore. So, would ya mind dropping the thing?

Ms. Stranger: Understood.

She does precisely as he asks.

J: Phew. Thanks.

Marguerite: I knew I'd find you here.

Eagle: Ma'am!

Marguerite: You didn't lose the badge I gave you, even when you were in danger. Nicely done.

Marguerite: That badge was enchanted by X to emit a special kind of arcane trace that my Rumbling Roaring Box could identify, but I lost the thing in battle.

Marguerite: Thankfully, despite most of these checkered doormats being about as useful as a flat tire, they do carry monitoring devices capable of picking up those traces, so ...

J: Wait, you put a tracker on this kid?

J: *sneer* Not cool, lady.

Marguerite: Technically speaking, it's only an arcane trace emitter.

J: Ugh, never mind. At least everyone's okay.

Ms. Stranger: I thought the first floor was fully under Manus Vindictae's control. How did you manage to get to us?

J: Well, when all this s**t went down, we decided to swing by the Arcanum Containment Department. Found this weird screaming box there. Turns out it works pretty good as a distraction.

"Razor": Ms. Druvis managed to evacuate most of the survivors to the Arcanum Containment Department in the Eastern Building.

"Razor": The Manus have focused their efforts on reaching the top level of the Committee Building.

Ms. Stranger: The top level? They must be heading for the president's office.

Marguerite: We can't worry about that now. We have our own problems.

"Razor": Agreed. Let's fall back to the Arcanum Containment Department. We'll make our next plans there.

Arcanum Containment Department

"Razor": This is all the men we could gather so far.

Name Day: You've found more survivors, Captain.

Name Day: Then it's not all bad news after all.

Name Day stows his knife and returns to the corner.

Sotheby: Hooray! New friends joining Typhon's legion!

Regulus: An Eagle Scout and the phony captain. Ha, never thought I'd be happy to see you again.

Regulus and Sotheby welcome the new survivors with a burst of enthusiasm.

Eagle: Wow! This is a lot more people than I'd even hoped for.

Ms. Stranger: ...

The staff shuffle between different storage areas, doing their best to avoid unexpected dangers.

Loggerhead: Don't touch anything on the shelves, people. Everything's totally harmless, just as long as you leave them be.

Recoleta: Please do as she says. Latham already wastes eight hours a day keeping all these knick-knacks in order. Let's not make it any more.

Marguerite: Then I wonder what exactly you do here, Ms. Recoleta?

Recoleta: Oh, Ms. Butterfly! It's great to see you again.

Recoleta: I've been working on a sequel to *The Turquoise Serpent Club*. Though, being stuck in a building with nothing but gray-and-white checkers to look at isn't exactly inspiring.

Recoleta: Oh, right, how have you been? Any new adventures to share?

The survivors find themselves with new companions to chat with.

Ms. Stranger: Ms. Stranger stays by the entrance, unsure of just how to deal with Regulus's enthusiasm.

Druvis III: Ms. Stranger, I'm glad to see you're alright.

Druvis III: Perhaps you'd like an update on our current situation?

Ms. Stranger: It would be much appreciated.

Druvis III: Follow me. Regulus, could you give us a minute?

Regulus: Ah? And just when I thought we were bonding. Ah, go on then. Plan whatever plans you're gonna plan. Just don't you dare leave me out of them!

Druvis leads Ms. Stranger aside. Jars line the cabinet behind them, each filled with specimens taken from arcane creatures.

Druvis III: We've lost contact with the Committee Building. All we're getting are small snippets of information from survivors as they make their way here.

Druvis III: It appears their attack is focused there, so we've avoided them so far. That said, we shouldn't wait around to be discovered.

Druvis III: In better news, I've found a method to contact the LSCC.

Ms. Stranger: How? I thought all our signals were being jammed.

Druvis pulls out an incubator nurturing a plant.

Druvis III: This is a Chattercap I found on the shelf. It can communicate messages to all its symbionts.

Druvis III: And the Containment Department's logs show that Director Ezra happened to borrow one of these symbionts, taking it to Laplace.

Druvis III: I've awakened this one, and fortunately, it managed to build a connection with its symbiont there. The signal is unstable, but at least we're no longer alone.

Ms. Stranger: I wonder what the situation is like over there.

Ulrich: I hear voices coming from that mushroom again.

Pointer: Yes, but it doesn't sound like Ms. Druvis. They're asking about Laplace's current situation.

Ulrich: Right now? We're doing all we can to hold out. Researcher Hissabeth has formulated a plan to stop the Manus, though.

Enigma: That's right. Ask the lady on the line how she feels about getting blasted into the sky by an exploding "Fire Salamander" fuel tank from the Uranus-4 rocket.

Pointer: Hissabeth seems confident that Laplace's security doors are strong enough to withstand the explosion and that her firepower should provide just enough cover to allow the Foundation to rescue her team. I'll speak with her, if she's still inclined to listen.

Marguerite: In summation, things are about as expected there.

At some point, Marguerite makes her way over. She peruses the specimens in the storage cabinets behind them.

Marguerite: Those lab geeks should be just fine as long as Hissabeth gives up her plan.

Marguerite: Hm. Hissabeth? Give up? Listen to yourself.

Ultimately, nothing on these shelves suits the cold-eyed woman.

Ms. Stranger: ...

Ms. Stranger: It may be best for me to share my intel on Manus Vindictae with all of you. Rules and regulations would only hold us back at this moment.

Druvis III: You read my mind, Ms. Stranger. I think we deserve to know.

Ms. Stranger: Allow me to start with a list of the Manus's high-level figures and their basic information.

Ms. Stranger: We can't be sure just how many of them are part of this attack, but if you run into any of them, please be extra careful.

"New Faces, Old Friends"

小径

Manus Vindictae Leaders

[A flowing handwritten note; faint scale powder clings to the paper.]

Taira
His true form is a crab that latches onto the faces of others. Through his arcane skills, he can control the movements of his host. The death of the host does not harm him. Always be wary of the crab.

Lyra
She can control—or amplify?—emotions through song. Her voice is highly mobile, and her wind-based arcane skills are wide-reaching and difficult to guard against.

Ustrina
The medium of her arcane skills is possibly a shadow in the shape of a sickle. She can use it to inflict mental damage, though her victims show no visible physical wounds or signs of pain. Evade the sickle, and use mental defense arcane skills if possible.

Hypothetik
He takes the form of a giant stitched puppet. His arcane skills allow him to implant emotions, beliefs, or fragments of consciousness into the minds of others—most commonly fear. Counter him the same way you would against Ustrina.

İlmek
No arcane skills have been observed, but her strength and endurance far exceed ordinary limits. Avoid engaging her up close.

Prima
Skilled in hypnosis and torture, and known for her brutal nature. Her mother, Animus, was a Manus Apostle and died during the Antarctic incident.

...

No deeper contact has been made with the remaining leaders. Physical descriptions of suspected leaders are recorded in the appendix.

A Hard Choice

13TH-11

A Hard Choice

Lopera: Help me get Paravyan over here, and remember to keep yourself in my smoke at all times.

They crouch low and drag Paravyan behind cover.

Alchemical smoke flows out from her crucible, obscuring them further, at least temporarily.

Lopera: Oh no. He doesn't look good.

Paravyan: ...

Paravyan: Just leave me. We're doomed. We ... We're all gonna die here.

Lopera: What are you yammering about! Toughen up, soldier!

Paravyan: I don't want to fight anymore. It's all meaningless. The world's ending anyway.

Paravyan: The Foundation, Manus Vindictae, wh-whatever. Just leave me be. I can't get back on my feet again.

Lopera: Come on, all you've got are a few bruises. What happened?

Yermolai: Make way!

Yermolai rushes over, kicking a black-clothed corpse down the hill along the way.

He kneels and looks Paravyan over.

Lopera: Wait. His Umbrella's broken.

Head lowered, Yermolai unfastens the buckle at Paravyan's waist and swaps the damaged Umbrella for a new one.

Yermolai: I knew it.

Yermolai: He didn't notice the damage to his Umbrella, and now he's infected with the Storm Syndrome.

Yermolai: There's a few others like him. Look fine on the outside, but their insides are wallowing in total despair.

Yermolai: It's like the exact opposite of the war craze from before the 1914 "Storm."

Lopera: Where did you get another Umbrella?

Yermolai: From someone who doesn't need it anymore. Better used on Beagle, I'd say.

Lopera: ...

Yermolai: He'll take a while to recover. Just leave him be.

Lopera: Have we found a way out?

Yermolai: No. Arcane Support's still working on it.

Lopera: I can—

Yermolai: Listen, soldier. We all have our own duties, you included. You're not an array expert. Doesn't take an arcanist to know that.

Yermolai: Osborn's down, so I'm the ranking officer here. Understood?

Yermolai: Have you and Beagle completed the mission Osborn gave you?

Lopera: We almost did, until he suddenly refused to cooperate.

Yermolai: Can you finish it? How much longer will it take?

Lopera: Yes, sir. In about three more minutes, before my arcane smoke lifts.

Yermolai: Got it. We'll cover you in the meantime. Let me know when you're ready.

Lopera: All set!

Yermolai: All units, fall back!

Soldiers stagger back toward their shrinking defensive line.

Manus Disciple: 〆 ...!!

The Manus disciples follow up with another attack, threatening to overrun their previous positions.

Lopera: Whoa!

There is a chain explosion of alchemical mines, sending both Lopera and the Manus disciples rolling down the slope.

Paravyan: Lopera! Are you alright?

Paravyan, now recovered from the Storm Syndrome, slides down the hill and searches for Lopera through the smoke.

Lopera staggers out of the mud and rises to her feet.

Lopera: I'm fine. My Umbrella, too. I just still can't control the explosion precisely. How are you holding up?

Paravyan: Better now. Sorry I let you down back there, but I'm not afraid anymore. I'll cover you.

More hostiles appear from the dense smoke of the explosion, encroaching on them like a ring of growing shadows.

Manus Disciple: Attack! 攻!

Lopera: How many of them are there?

She draws her gun and ducks behind cover.

Lopera: Stay put, Paravyan. They're charging.

Paravyan: Copy that. I see them.

Lopera: Damn it!

Lopera: Paravyan?

Lopera: Hmm? What?

All-too-familiar runes radiate along the dirt around her.

Lopera: N-No way.

Lopera: Ugh!

Try as she might to stand up, she's knocked back down.

A cacophony of shouts mixes into sharp bird calls in her ears.

Footsteps draw near.

Voice I: There's another one over there. I'll go take a look.

Voice II: Be careful.

Voice I: Hey. I've got a girl? Lieutenant, you need to see this.

Lopera: Who's ...?

She rages against her own helplessness.

Lopera scrambles for her revolver, just barely managing to find it on the ground. She breathes out and prepares to make her last stand.

Lopera: You ...

Voice II: Don't shoot!

Lopera: ...!

She feels herself being pulled into an embrace.

Moldir: Lopera!

Lopera: Molly, is that really you?

Moldir: Hang in there. I'll get you somewhere safe.

Igor: *cough*

Ptolemy: Are you alright, Father?

Igor surveys the battlefield.

Igor: Manus Vindictae won't be able to launch another attack for some time.

Igor: Ptolemy, we must reach the convoy's commander. Let them know we are not their enemy.

Ptolemy: Yes, Father.

The chaos following the Gryphon Legion's arrival settles into an uneasy pause. There are more pressing matters at hand.

Ptolemy: The Foundation convoy has calmed down, as you predicted. We've avoided any unnecessary casualties.

Igor: We saved their lives. They have the sense to see that. Who is their commanding officer?

Ptolemy: Their commander was killed, Father. The ranking officer is called Yermolai. He seems able enough. It wasn't difficult to persuade him that we were here to help.

Ptolemy: They're from the Foundation's QRF. The Manus ambush nearly wiped them out.

Ptolemy: I'll bring their officer here. And Father, Lopera wants to see you.

Ptolemy salutes, turns, and leaves.

Moldir escorts Lopera over to her father.

Moldir: You might have an internal injury of some kind from that explosion, Pera. We'll have time to talk, but for now you need to—

Lopera: Get away from me.

Moldir: ...

Lopera turns to face her father.

Lopera: What are you doing here?

Igor: Trying to help.

Igor: Our intention was to arrive directly at the Foundation's headquarters. But it seems whatever arcane skills the Manus have employed are interfering with my own.

Igor: You were fortunate. It seems we arrived without a moment to spare.

Lopera: And what? You're going to force me to join your assault on the Foundation?

Igor: Our goal is to protect the Foundation, not destroy it.

Lopera: Huh?

Igor lets the statement rest and moves on.

Igor: Do you have enough Equilibrium Umbrellas for everyone?

Lopera: We should, as long as our missing vehicles are intact.

Igor: Then the answer is no.

Igor: What do you plan to do, Lopera? Draw lots for the remaining devices?

Lopera: Our orders were to reach the SPDM. They have an immunity area, as long as we can manage to secure the school.

Igor: Can you be certain that you will secure the immunity area before the "Storm" arrives?

Igor: There is no choice in the matter. You will come with us to our shelter.

Lopera: Your shelter?

Igor: I must put my soldiers first.

Igor: We don't have enough Umbrellas for the entire legion. My men risked their lives to follow me here.

Lopera: What? Are you out of your mind? You mean they're all exposed to the Storm Syndrome right now?

Lopera: Don't tell me that includes Molly!

Moldir: It's alright, Pera. We'll be fine as long as we get back to the shelter before the reversion starts.

Moldir: We volunteered for this operation. Please, Pera, we're trying to help you.

Lopera: How did you know the Foundation was under attack?

Moldir: We have our sources, but the intel came too late. We missed our window.

Moldir: We're unable to teleport there, which means there's nothing we can do to reinforce the Foundation. We're out of options, and I have no intention of leaving you here to die.

Lopera: I won't go.

Yermolai: Lopera, I'll remind you that I'm your acting commander.

He watches Lopera struggling in Moldir's grip, then turns to Igor.

Yermolai: Your deputy said that headquarters couldn't reinforce us. Why is that?

Igor: The situation there is much worse.

Yermolai: Tch. I've had dreams of burning that place down, but not today, not now. What's happened?

Igor: I do not have the time to brief you.

Igor: I am only able to open my gateway once more before the reversion begins. I can take what's left of your squad to safety.

Igor: We will fall back to our shelter. It is the only safe location I can reach without risking Manus interference.

Igor: For now, I have ordered my legion to assist in decoding this array.

Igor: But if we can't break through before the "Storm" arrives, you'll have no choice but to leave with us.

Yermolai: Then we'll be marked as "traitors," wanted by the Foundation. Just like you.

Igor looks out in the direction of the Foundation. He doesn't argue the point.

Yermolai: I may not be the fondest of them, but I'm not exactly looking to have their guns pointed at me either.

Igor: Your complaints can wait. The Manus are preparing another attack.

President's Office

The top floor of Foundation headquarters remains tranquil despite the chaos below.

By the time the tremors of explosions and incantations reach it, they do little more than stir the dust in the president's office.

Secretary General: May the peace be with us.

President: Is she here?

Secretary General: Arcana has been confirmed to be within the Committee Building. Based on the strength of her forces, I estimate she'll reach us within 30 minutes.

President: How long until reinforcements arrive?

Secretary General: The nearest ground units are 90 minutes away. Unfortunately, they'll need to brave the "Storm" to reach us. They're sending whatever troops they can equip with Equilibrium Umbrellas.

Secretary General: The Flying Witches are also en route. They should arrive soon, but they don't have the numbers to change our situation. And their air advantage won't be of much use indoors.

President: Grant all personnel at headquarters access to restricted areas and any available weapons. I want everyone armed.

President: That should buy us another 30 minutes.

Secretary General: Do you believe the Foundation is no longer capable of solving this crisis on its own?

She poses the question despite already knowing the answer.

President: Yes.

Secretary General: What's the Timekeeper's status?

President: We can't reach her. We lost communication with the SPDM over an hour ago.

Several doves, almost ethereal in their luster, perch calmly on the edge of the president's desk.

He picks one up and strokes it.

President: How long until the Pax House responds?

Secretary General: Soon.

Secretary General: The Philosopher King is aware of her arrival.

President: Then that's all we need.

The president holds the dove to the window.

President: May the peace be with us.

Whisper of Flowers
小径

Fragrance from Afar

> [A flower carried on the "wind." From its heart drifts the scent of honey and the soft voice of a woman.]
>
> Prima, Igor, and his Gryphon Legion have rescued the Foundation's support convoy. I need you to stall them for as long as possible—though slowing them down is all that's required.
> Don't ask. I never agreed to take part in this operation, and I still oppose the attack on the school. Pointless fighting and bloodshed do no good for the future of arcanists … But I still have my duty to fulfill. Whatever comes, we must give everything we have to Her cause. That's all—I'm only here to deliver this message. Don't come looking for me. I'll be gone soon.
>
> [The sweet fragrance and the faint voice fade together.]

Secret Communication
小径

Burn After Reading

> [A quill grows hot without warning. Drawn from a uniform coat pocket and set upon blank paper, it begins to move on its own, leaving lines of scorched writing.]
>
> SPDM is under attack by Manus Vindictae. I'm on my way to assist. The attack came without warning. Amid the Foundation's containment expansion, headquarters is crowded with unfamiliar personnel. I suspect Manus Vindictae's plans run deeper than this. Share any relevant intelligence if you have it. Fewer than three hours remain until the "Storm." Stay cautious.
>
> [As the admiral reads the final word, the quill's glow dims. The writing catches fire along with the paper, consuming it in an instant, leaving not even ash.]

The Shapeshifter
13TH-12

The Shapeshifter

Book Stacks, Library

Merel: Excuse me, miss. May I borrow this book?

School Librarian: *Five Easy Recipes to Brew an Invisibility Potion*? Are you sure you've picked the right book, dear? The final exams are coming up, and I doubt this appears anywhere on your syllabus.

Merel: No, it doesn't, but …

She hunches her shoulders.

Merel: I just want something different to read. I've gone through every book on the syllabus, or at least stared at them until my brain gave up.

Merel: I'll probably fail. Maybe that's for the best.

Matilda: Merel!

A noise from the nearby bookshelves grabs Merel's attention. She turns to see another girl approaching her, beaming with confidence.

Merel: ...?!

Merel: S-Sorry. Do I know you?

Matilda: I am Matilda Bouanich. Though you have doubtlessly heard of me.

Merel: Um, okay. How did you know my name?

Matilda: Why, I remembered it, of course. I remember everyone's name. You should learn to do the same, starting with mine. That way, you'll know who to turn to if you need any help.

Matilda: You're one of the new students, isn't that right?

Merel: Yeah.

Matilda: I know you've been struggling, but not everyone arrives having mastered the entire syllabus as I have. You'll get the hang of it in no time. Trust me.

Merel: I guess so. Are you borrowing books too? What did you get? *An Introduction to Shapeshifting and Its Practice Through Time*?

An intimidating book, thick as a brick. Merel doesn't need to open it to know every page will be filled with walls of teeny-tiny text.

Merel: Are you trying to learn to shapeshift, Matilda?

Matilda: I just want to get a taste of it, that's all.

Merel: But that book's huge. Err, how about *Fiddler Crab Shapeshifting for Dummies*? I've read it. It's simple and fun, perfect for beginners like us.

Matilda: Excuse me?! I've never read a more insulting title! Matilda Bouanich is no "dummy," and she absolutely will not read a book that is meant for one!

Matilda: If I am to learn shapeshifting, I will do it properly and learn from the best! I will not end up as some sorry, soggy, crabby little thing crawling around on the floor.

Matilda: Besides, we've already had quite enough dummies knocking on the infirmary's door with claws instead of hands.

Matilda: Though, I did hear Sonetto once borrowed that book. But I simply cannot imagine her turning into a crab. Hmm. I wonder if she succeeded? There must be a way I can find out.

Matilda: N-Never mind. Why would Matilda concern herself with such petty tricks? We Bouaniches have already mastered something far more powerful—command of the crystal orbs.

Matilda walks away, hefting a copy of *An Introduction to Shapeshifting and Its Practice Through Time*.

Merel: ...

Reading Room, Library

She holds a book she picked up from the library corridor.

Merel: To be honest, I wasn't exactly thrilled when they told me I'd be sent here. But I guess there are worse places I could've been stationed, so I didn't complain.

Merel: I can't say I've missed the school announcements, or the electric fences and detention rooms. Not even for a second.

She places the book beside Matilda's pillow.

Merel: But I've always liked the library. It's probably the only part of this school that I did.

Matilda: ...

She's alive but hasn't stirred at all since they brought her in.

Merel: I will see this through, Matilda. Not for the sake of the school, though—

Emilia: The instructors are hiding something. But if we'll find out one day anyway, why don't they just tell us now?

Emilia: Miss, why can't you just tell us what's happening out there? I swear we'll keep our mouths shut.

Lucas: Don't bother, Emilia. They're not gonna tell you anything.

Lucas: They know. But even if they used to be students like us, they're just like them now.

Merel: —But for our friends and for the students who remind me of who we once were.

Merel: This war will end someday. And when it does, I hope they'll live in a kinder world than the one we grew up in.

Merel, hearing light footsteps echo behind her, turns around.

Lavender: Merel, is Ms. Bouanich going to be okay?

Merel: *sigh* She still hasn't regained consciousness. It might have something to do with the arcane skill that hit her.

Merel: But her vitals are stable, and the casualty assessment didn't show anything serious. The rehab center should have her back on her feet in no time.

Lavender: Casualty assessment?

Merel: Yeah. It's a process I learned back at the Vigiles Bureau. Just glad I haven't forgotten it.

Lavender: The Vigiles Bureau ... Was that your first job after school? You're incredible.

Merel: I doubt my instructor back then would agree. I didn't do very well in the exams.

Lavender: Ms. Bouanich once told me that grades aren't everything. You must have had other strengths the Vigiles Bureau valued.

Lavender's reverent gaze makes it hard for Merel to tell her the truth.

How could she confess that her grades were so bad that nobody except Creius, who was so desperate he'd accept any graduate with a pulse, would take her in?

Lavender: When I graduate, I hope I can join the Vigiles like you or be an investigator, like Ms. Bouanich. Do you think I stand a chance?

Merel: Of course! But you should really consider working at the Foundation's headquarters. It's much safer behind a desk than out in the field.

Lavender: I don't want to be stuck indoors. Besides ...

Lavender: Ms. Bouanich and Ms. Sonetto chose to be field operatives, and so did you. You all must've seen a reason to do it.

Lavender: I don't really know all the details of what investigators, Vigil officers, or soldiers actually do out there, but I know it's what I want to do.

Merel: They aren't all that different, really. Sometimes you'll find their duties overlap.

Sonetto: Merel?

Sonetto stands in the reading room's doorway.

Merel: Over here! Matilda's condition hasn't changed. Is there something you need?

Sonetto: The Timekeeper wants a word with you in the study room.

Merel: Sure. I'm on my way.

Lavender: I better go check on the other students again—see how they've been behaving.

Lavender: Some of the younger ones think they might find a solution to the impending "Storm" in the books. But I figure if the answer really was in a book, someone would have found it already.

Lavender exits the room and reenters the crowd of nervous students in the library corridor.

Study Room, Library

Despite the mess, the study room's atmosphere feels solemn. Merel can't help but sense the tension.

Merel: You wanted to see me? What's wrong?

She looks away from the window.

Vertin: The convoy should've arrived by now, but there's no sign of them. I haven't been able to reach headquarters either.

Vertin: I'm afraid we have to prepare for the worst.

Merel approaches the table, looking over the map that they've laid out depicting the SPDM campus.

Merel: Is this the contraction rate of the immunity area?

Vertin: Yes. Its radius has reduced by 30 meters in the last 15 minutes. It's shrinking even faster than I'd anticipated.

Vertin: At this rate, the library will be exposed ten minutes before the "Storm" arrives.

Merel: But, there are so many students.

Vertin: That's why I called you here. We don't have the luxury of waiting for rescue anymore. I've decided to see whether the "boon" can be of any use.

Sonetto: ...

The resigned silence conveys her feelings on the matter.

Merel: "Boon"?

Vertin: It's an item Igor gave me during the Don Operation.

Vertin: It's possible that it could generate an immunity zone. But ...

Sonetto: But we have almost no idea what's inside it. It could save us or destroy us. It was a gift from Arcana. Let's not forget that.

Merel: Arcana?! Then, shouldn't we stay as far away from it as possible?

Sonetto: I think so too. It really is like Pandora's box. Once opened, there'll be no undoing the consequences.

Vertin: Even so, it may be our last hope to save everyone here.

Igor: "You are the true savior destined to lead us from the flood. Take it."

Vertin: Igor believed that I was meant to have it. He was absolutely certain, though I still don't understand why.

Vertin: But if I can make it work, it could shield us all from the "Storm." I'd be saving not just you two, but all the students here.

Vertin: Igor managed to protect his entire army from the "Flood" in Antarctica, and I believe he did it with the power of this cube.

Merel: But that's hardly for certain. What if we open it and find out there's nothing inside?

Vertin: Then we attempt to reach the central watchtower, assuming the Manus hasn't destroyed the Dove there too.

Sonetto: They'll hit us with everything they have out there. And even if we somehow avoided them, how could we manage to get all these children out safely?

The implication leaves Merel's palms cold.

Merel: There really aren't any options left, then.

The "boon" appears in her hands once more and casts its mysterious, unpredictable glow across the room.

Vertin: I've already applied the alchemical compound Ms. Marguerite gave me. She said it will begin to dismantle the shell as soon as the incantation is recited.

Time. She needs time to calm her nerves.

Sonetto & Merel: ...

Vertin: Unlock the leaden secret.

The momentary chaos ends, and an empty, black gate manifests ahead.

An extraordinary aura radiates out from it, painting its surroundings in colors too mystical and ancient for description.

Sonetto: A gate? The "boon" is an entrance?

Vertin: I hear something. A voice. Someone's calling out.

Sonetto and Merel exchange a look of suspicion.

Merel: I don't hear anything at all.

Sonetto: There's only wind, blowing across the ground. No voices.

Vertin: It's calling out to us. I hear my name and yours, Sonetto.

Sonetto: Timekeeper, it's entirely possible that this is a trap. Stepping in there could be exactly what Arcana wants.

Vertin: But the voice ... It sounds just like mine.

Merel: Sorry, you're saying the voice coming from that gate is yours, and only you can hear it?

Vertin: I know how impossible it must sound.

Vertin: But I want to see for myself. I have to try.

Sonetto: ...

Sonetto: Then, please, at least allow me to accompany you.

Vertin: Of course. Merel, can I ask you to wait here? Someone has to look after the students if we don't make it back.

Vertin: You have to get them to the central tower before the library is exposed to the "Storm."

Merel: I-I have another idea.

Merel lifts a trembling hand. It feels as if she's back in school again, but volunteering ... That is a new sensation.

Merel: I'll go to the central tower myself and bring back the Dove installed there.

Sonetto: On your own? That's far too risky. The Manus are everywhere. They've likely taken control of the entire campus.

Merel: Just listen. The Manus we've encountered so far have been manageable, tough but dumb. They haven't sent anything I can't handle.

Merel: Acting alone might even be an advantage. I'll be much quicker and quieter without trying to move all these kids with me too.

Merel: If I shapeshift on the way, I might even be able to draw some enemies away from the library.

Merel: So, go on. Check what's behind the gate. I'll head for the Dove. It probably won't last long off its pedestal, but what's left inside should be enough to get us through the "Storm."

Sonetto: And if the Dove runs out of energy before the "Storm" arrives? Or what if something happens to you on the way? The stakes are too high. We can't afford to leave this to chance.

Merel: We're already betting on luck, aren't we? And just waiting isn't going to improve our odds any more. What if you come back empty-handed? What then?

The chaos in her mind causes the words to come out knotted and unfocused.

Merel: No, we need to stack the cards, or-or spread the risk or something like that! Do you see what I mean?

Merel: And to be honest, if you don't make it back, I doubt I could get everyone to safety by myself.

Merel: But going out alone? That I can do. This way, we double their chances of survival.

Merel: "Always have a plan to fall back on." Creius is always saying that to me.

Merel: And this time, I've got one.

She punctuates her speech with a deep gasp of breath.

Sonetto: ...

Vertin: I admire your courage, Merel, truly.

Vertin: Go then. I trust you. And I need you to trust me, too.

Vertin: We meet here again before the "Storm." And whatever happens, we move forward together.

Merel: Mhm. I promise.

Having agreed upon a rendezvous location, they exchange a final glance—a moment of utmost trust.

Vertin: It's time. Let's go, Sonetto.

The dark entrance welcomes them in.

A strange rumbling follows. Then, both gate and cube vanish altogether.

Merel: They're gone.

A moment later, Lavender bursts into the study room.

Lavender: Merel? What's going on? Where did Ms. Vertin and Ms. Sonetto go?

Merel: They've gone to find a way to get us all through the "Storm" safely.

Merel: I ... I'm going to leave soon, too, Lavender. I need to get to the central watchtower and see if I can find something that might help us there.

Lavender: By yourself?

Merel: Y-Yeah. Don't worry. I know a way to slip past the enemies outside.

Lavender: Those Manus monsters have just been hanging around so far. They don't seem to be trying to get in. But even if a few try, the senior students and I should be able to manage.

Lavender: We'll be alright here, as long as they don't all come charging in at once. You go ahead.

Merel: I couldn't ask for more. I'll be back as soon as I can.

Lavender takes a deep breath and offers a solemn nod.

Ten seconds pass. Then, a little blackbird clumsily flies from the library's north-facing window.

Thorny Thicket

13TH-13

Thorny Thicket

Foundation Office

Soldier I: Have you lost your mind? Get out from under there, now.

Registrar: I ... I ...

He trembles in his checkered uniform, frozen in a corner. The paleness of his face is rivaled only by his white knuckles as he grips a stack of papers for dear life.

Soldier I: Forget your bloody paperwork. Just get somewhere safe.

Registrar: Those things out there ... Are-Are they ...

Soldier I: Yeah. Nowhere's safe anymore. Welcome to reality, sunshine.

Soldier I: Now get on your feet and help me move this table outside. We need to barricade this place.

Registrar: Wh-What about those monsters? What do we do about them?

Soldier I: We put a bullet through their heads, if we're lucky.

The soldier pauses, realizing in that moment the reason for the young man's terror.

Soldier I: For Pete's sake, don't tell me this is your first time seeing the Manus up close.

The terrified young man nods. Years of experience and long tenure in the Foundation's bureaucracy count for little in this moment.

Soldier I: Well, I'll be damned. I fight these things every day, and half of you checkerheads haven't even seen one in the flesh!

Soldier I: Listen, if all you're going to do is stand there shaking, then I'm leaving without you. I've got to try to find my team.

Registrar: No, wait, wait! Please, don't leave me here.

Soldier I: Alright, then what are you going to do?

The registrar finally pries himself up from the corner.

Registrar: I'll come with you. Let's move this table outside.

Fourth Floor, Committee Building

Soldier I: Just a little more.

Registrar: Ugh!

Outside the office, staff dressed in checkered uniforms flit around like a startled flock of birds, their "wings" flapping without any clear direction.

Irinei: Non-combatant staff must evacuate to higher floors immediately. Clear the main stairwell—military use only.

Foundation Staff Member I: No, no. Don't jump. This is the fourth floor.

Foundation Staff Member II: Out of the way. Soldier, find me a weapon.

Irinei: Enough. We don't need file clerks wasting ammunition. Just find somewhere safe with the rest of your colleagues.

Amid the flurry of documents stand several operation team members, calm and composed.

Operation Team Leader I: Looks like you're free for now, Creius.

Creius: For the moment, yes. The trial will start up again once this all blows over, assuming we're still alive.

Creius: Where's my squad?

Operation Team Leader I: They're with the Quick Reaction Force that was sent to the SPDM. We've lost contact with all our operatives in the field.

Creius: I suppose that makes me the sole member of the "XII," then.

Operation Team Leader II: We've attempted to reach "Razor" and the others, but so far we've got nothing. They may have gotten cut off downstairs.

Creius: What's the ETA on reinforcements?

Constantine: Fifteen minutes.

Constantine hasn't left her post yet, but the front line creeps closer to her door each moment.

Constantine: Inform everyone you can reach: air support is on its way.

Creius: With respect, ma'am, you ought to at least be giving your captains the hard truth.

Constantine: Forces are an hour out, maybe more. Until then, we hold the line. Understood?

Creius: Understood. Reinforcement ETA: 60 minutes.

Z: Ma'am, we have representatives from the House of Integratus waiting. They request a brief meeting.

Constantine: I'm on my way. Best of luck, soldiers.

Z: Godspeed, officers.

With that, the gathered politicians hurry away.

Operation Team Leader II: Plan's simple. We let them push up, layering out a defense in depth, giving ground as necessary to conserve ammo and avoid exposure to the "Storm."

Operation Team Leader II: Priority for now is to buy time for all non-combatant staff to reach the top floor. If reinforcements don't come in time to save our necks, then at least we'll die standing.

He pats Creius's shoulder.

Operation Team Leader II: The Dispatch Center will be coordinating our teams to focus on the Manus's arcanist troops. You coming with us, Creius?

Creius: The "XII" Squad always stands ready, even if I'm the only one left.

Creius: Let's move out.

Their team moves through fleeing bureaucrats and takes the stairs down toward the ever-nearing battle.

Third Floor, Committee Building

Foundation Security: Get down!

Thick cement manages to block a fatal incantation.

Crouching low behind cover, Creius makes his way to the commander's side.

Creius: We're from Special Operations. What's the situation here?

Foundation Security: We've lost the second floor. The Manus are pushing up the main stairs.

Foundation Security: We've got nothing reliable on their numbers or composition, sir. At this rate, I doubt we can hold the third floor for long.

Foundation Security: Dispatch told us reinforcements are coming. What's their ETA?

Creius: Um. We need you to hold on for 15 minutes. Understood, soldier? Spread the word.

Foundation Security: Fifteen minutes. We can manage that.

The defenders steel themselves and fight with renewed vigor. Their flagging morale is centering on a single clear goal: 15 minutes, hold the line. That's it.

At the far end of the room, a Manus soldier leaps out of cover. Both sides are close enough to make out each other's expressions.

Krutov: They're stalling for time. Push through.

Krutov: We have numbers on them. They won't hold. Units Two and Three, probe for any weak points in their defenses.

Manus Soldier I: Yes, sir.

Krutov's soldiers push forward with a discipline far exceeding that of normal arcanists.

Krutov: We're behind schedule. These Foundation dogs have finally found their footing.

Krutov: Where is İlmek? She was supposed to be leading the vanguard. Late? Or simply proving herself useless again?

Krutov: What is it now?

The tremors were not part of the plan, but Krutov has grown used to his fanatical arcanist troops acting of their own accord.

Krutov: Whose arcane skill was that? Imbeciles! If there can be anything said for humans, at least they can follow a plan.

He storms out of cover, two arcanists leaping with him to serve as his bodyguards.

Krutov arrives at the outermost corridor, planning to find the source of the tremors for himself.

Krutov: Whoever's doing this, I will—

Krutov: ...!

A thick branch smashes through the Committee Building's wall.

Soldier I: Wha—huh?

Druvis III: No need to be alarmed, soldiers. This thicket will provide you cover.

J: We figured you guys could use a couple arcanists on your side. Pretty sweet, huh? Hold on. Recoleta? What're you doing here?

Recoleta: At first, I only planned to observe and record the noble deeds and heroes of this great fight.

Recoleta: But I've had a change of heart.

Recoleta: I will join you in this fearless all-or-nothing adventure. I'll fight, just like everyone else. Please, let me stand by your side.

APPLe: Caution, everyone. Please clear a space around the light beam as quickly as possible.

Soldier II: Light beam?

Soldier II: Wait, there's something flying straight at us. Missile incoming.

Soldier I: You heard the apple. Move it!

Nautika: Ah!

Nautika: Did I ... Did I land right? Everyone okay?

Marsha: That was unlike any transport I've ever ridden before, Nautika.

Marsha suppresses the momentary exhilaration of the flight and focuses her mind on the battle.

Marsha: Don't worry. No injuries. Everyone moved away from the window. Excellent timing, Mr. APPLe. Now, do you remember what I said?

Nautika: Y-Yes, disrupt the enemy's coordination.

Manus Soldier I: A Chimera. It's the one from Antarctica. Then the rumors were true.

Krutov: If I hear another word from you, coward, I will personally put an end to you. That beast there is nothing more than an easy target.

Krutov: Now take her down!

Manus Vindictae's assault begins to slow as the Foundation's troops establish strong points along their lines.

Foundation Security: We can't thank you enough. You really saved our bacon back there.

Druvis III: There's a path down to the lower floor under this tree trunk. We can use it to move between floors behind enemy lines.

Foundation Security: Excellent news. Now we can send down teams to look for weapons and ammo.

Marsha: On that subject, we've brought supplies from Laplace. Nautika?

Nautika: Oh, right! I've got everything here.

Nautika shakes several silver packages from her back. A tin box clatters to the ground alongside them.

Tin Box: Ahem. Ahem.

He picks up the talking tin box.

Foundation Security: What's this?

Tin Box: Hi there, whoever you are, this is a prerecorded instructional message from X.

Tin Box: Now, allow me to walk you through the specifications of the equipment. First up: the semi-automatic construction arm.

The aftershocks of the battle for the third floor reverberate through the building, shaking both the higher and lower levels.

Ms. Stranger: Ms. Druvis has checked in. They've made it upstairs and joined the fight. I'm ready to set out for my mission as well.

Ms. Stranger: I'll be going behind enemy lines in an effort to find out how they breached our security. With any luck, I might find a way to close it and isolate their forces here.

Ms. Stranger: Researcher Marguerite, I'll leave the rest to you here.

Lorentz Butterfly: Not so fast. It's finally just the two of us. A good chance to speak face-to-face, don't you think?

The words momentarily take her away from thoughts of the battle ahead.

Lorentz Butterfly: Let's set aside this little "saving the world" matter for the moment and talk about what really matters. I've been waiting for this since the day I joined the "boon" research team.

Ms. Stranger: If this is about my past with the Manus ...

Lorentz Butterfly: No, no. I have no interest in that.

Lorentz Butterfly: Does the name "Loop Laboratory" ring a bell?

Ms. Stranger: You know about the Amber Room.

The color drains from her face.

Lorentz Butterfly: The secret lab built after the second "Storm" in collaboration between Zeno and the Foundation. Yes, I know about the Amber Room.

Lorentz Butterfly: I also know that, for years, Zeno has been tracking down soldiers reversed by the "Storm," labeling them as "deserters," and sending the Hush Troopers to ferry them to that very laboratory.

Lorentz Butterfly: And I know that using the same theory and reasoning behind the vessel ensoulment experiment, they developed a new technique.

Ms. Stranger: Phototaxis.

Ms. Stranger: A complex technique used to engrave a subject's skin and cerebral cortex with countless arcane incantations ...

Ms. Stranger: Enhancing their performance, resilience, and guaranteeing their unwavering loyalty.

Joy, terror, pain—the emotions stir in her mind like a deadly poison.

Lorentz Butterfly: Caring Cecilie, sweet Kayla, Grace the Specimen Enthusiast ... The Foundation has always kept you moving from one identity to another.

Ms. Stranger: There are many things I regret doing under those stolen names.

Lorentz Butterfly: But somehow your true self was never lost, not like with the others. I've been keeping my eye on that laboratory and its subjects. Most collapsed under the weight of their identities. But not you.

Lorentz Butterfly: It's no exaggeration to say you are the laboratory's finest work, a perfect specimen for Constantine's needs.

Ms. Stranger: That's quite enough. What do you want to say?

Lorentz Butterfly: There's a puzzle I've been looking to solve all these years. And only someone who survived that system can give me its final piece.

Lorentz Butterfly: You, Ms. Stranger, are the key to solving this mystery.

Lorentz Butterfly: I'd like to examine your brain to see whether it can rebuild your original self after the "Storm" washes it away.

A prolonged silence. But what breaks it isn't dispute, isn't indignation or concern. It's a light, almost sarcastic chuckle.

Ms. Stranger: ...

Ms. Stranger: I'm afraid you'll be disappointed, Ms. Marguerite. The Phototaxis is no longer in me.

Lorentz Butterfly is caught at a rare loss.

Lorentz Butterfly: Luck mocks me once again. But if that's so, then tell me: Who removed it?

Ms. Stranger: Arcana. She freed me from it in our confrontation earlier.

Lorentz Butterfly: She does seem quite taken by you, doesn't she? Her little pet. Maybe the Foundation should have let you stay by her side.

Ms. Stranger: It wasn't an act of kindness. She takes pleasure in the thought of me losing my mind, a mad dog off her leash, or collapsing once there's nothing left to hold me together.

Ms. Stranger: She let me live only to savor my misery.

Ms. Stranger: I suppose I should feel lucky to have regained my freedom, but it has come at a price—an emptiness that gnaws at me every waking moment.

Lorentz Butterfly: So, you have your freedom, yet you're still acting as if you're under the Foundation's control. Why is that, I wonder?

Ms. Stranger: I hate what they made me do—stealing people's names and lives. The guilt of it sits in my chest. But today, my choice is my own.

Lorentz Butterfly: You are a strange one, Ms. Stranger. You mean to say you're risking your life for the Foundation by choice?

Lorentz Butterfly: All the same, you've satisfied my curiosity, in a way. I suppose I should offer you something in return.

She smiles and hands over a mask that Ms. Stranger is all too familiar with.

Lorentz Butterfly: A friendly warning: this may corrupt you, and without the Phototaxis's protection, its effects could be permanent.

Ms. Stranger: Your warning is appreciated, truly, Researcher Marguerite.

An Unexpected Conversation

小径

Excerpt from the New York Times

> Around midnight two days ago, a large fire broke out in the oak forest on the western outskirts. The delay of the warning and the complex terrains full of inflammables in the forest resulted in a fire that lasted a whole night till dawn and 13 deaths.
> The victims entered the forest at dusk. Identities of 6 of them have been confirmed: the Weyerhaeusers, their buyers Tomson Joyce, Shelley Gerald, Kelly Keith, and the project manager Russell James. The others' are still being verified.
>
> The Weyerhaeuser used to be a leader in the wood industry, yet it went bankrupt not long ago due to the wood supply crisis these years. After donating the formula of the Resurrection Potion (basic version) to the Maria Sanatorium in New York, the Sacred Heart Sanatorium in Ohio, and the Presbyterian Church Health Center on certain conditions, the Weyerhaeusers sold all of their forestry lands.
> On the night of the fire, the Weyerhaeusers, their buyers, and the workers went into the forest to start the disafforestation project before they died. The police has found traces of arcanist's activities and a small amount of gasoline at the scene, which shows the case is an arson attack. More investigations are needed to identify the suspect.
>
> Reporter: James Welles/Dorey Johnson

Disagreement

小径

Excerpt from the New York Times

> Around midnight two days ago, a large fire broke out in the oak forest on the western outskirts. The delay of the warning and the complex terrains full of inflammables in the forest resulted in a fire that lasted a whole night till dawn and 13 deaths.
> The victims entered the forest at dusk. Identities of 6 of them have been confirmed: the Weyerhaeusers, their buyers Tomson Joyce, Shelley Gerald, Kelly Keith, and the project manager Russell James. The others' are still being verified.
>
> The Weyerhaeuser used to be a leader in the wood industry, yet it went bankrupt not long ago due to the wood supply crisis these years. After donating the formula of the Resurrection Potion (basic version) to the Maria Sanatorium in New York, the Sacred Heart Sanatorium in Ohio, and the Presbyterian Church Health Center on certain conditions, the Weyerhaeusers sold all of their forestry lands.
> On the night of the fire, the Weyerhaeusers, their buyers, and the workers went into the forest to start the disafforestation project before they died. The police has found traces of arcanist's activities and a small amount of gasoline at the scene, which shows the case is an arson attack. More investigations are needed to identify the suspect.
>
> Reporter: James Welles/Dorey Johnson

Vacuum of Arcanum

13TH-14

Vacuum of Arcanum

Countdown to the "Storm"

Countdown to the "Storm"

Hallway, St. Pavlov Foundation

Regulus: Ah. They're not here either.

Regulus dispels her optical stealth with a frown.

APPLe: Captain, I find it rather unlikely that the leader of the Manus Orchestra would simply be hiding in a room waiting for us to wander into them.

APPLe: Assuming they have an orchestra at all and that there's someone leading it.

Regulus: Fair point, Mr. APPLe, but I'm not letting any sensible conclusions hold me back, not after all that clanging and clattering battered my poor ears on the "Free Breeze."

Regulus: Besides, my dear chief mate, why else would they have become all musical instrument-y if there weren't some barmy conductor leading it all?

Regulus: Therefore, ipso facto, Bob's your uncle, this conductor must be operating from behind enemy lines.

APPLe: And if I may ask, Captain, what will we do if we actually find this conductor?

Regulus: Simple. That's when we bust out the "Gluey Gooey Gum Gun" our dear old X sent us.

Manus Believer: 歹！

Regulus: Urgh, you tone-deaf twit. Listen, if you can't play a proper tune, then stop acting like an instrument. It's insulting!

APPLe: Captain, I strongly advise we make a tactical retreat.

Regulus: Not to worry, Mr. APPLe. It's only one measly Manus—

Taira: What's this? A Foundation fool has sneaked their way behind our lines.

Even more shadowy figures emerge behind the crab-faced warrior.

Taira: Seize her! And that apple as well.

Regulus: Cor, look at that face. He's redder than the guy on the King Crimson album. Come on, Mr. APPLe. Let's give this Gum Gun a try.

???: Eyes up, soldier.

Regulus: Huh?

Regulus: Whoaa!

APPLe: Captain!

The explosion causes Regulus to stumble and coats APPLe's peel in dust.

Someone lands inside the dust, and after a quick survey confirms their enemies have been eliminated, she turns to Regulus.

Lilya: Well, well. What are the chances?

Regulus: L—*cough*—Lilya? You took your bloody time and a half, didn't you? They were saying the Flying Witches wouldn't make it.

Lilya: Ha! Then "they" clearly don't know how fast my brand-new Red 38 flies or who they're talking about.

Lilya: So, what, we take our eyes off this place for ten minutes and the Manus are all over you? Look at all these Olitiaus buzzing like flies on a corpse. Makes my skin crawl.

Lilya: Whatever, catch you later, rockstar. But don't forget. You owe me one. And I mean something harder than Dr. Papper.

Regulus: That's it? You just swoop in, save the day, and fly off? Why not stick around and give these Manus stooges a bit of what for?

Lilya: Oh, I will. But I'm not wasting my time charging around on foot.

Lilya: Plenty of stooges to deal with outside the Committee Building. Spotted them taking out some heavy machinery on my way in. Things are about to get wild.

Lilya: You two should get moving. Let the Foundation know what's up. And no more wandering off. I don't babysit.

Lilya mounts her new broom and takes off into the sky again.

Regulus: Wait! Is Dr. Papper really out of the question?

Vice President's Office

Madam Z watches Lilya's broom arc through the sky.

Z: We've gotten reports that the first group of Flying Witches has arrived. But I only see one of them, Lilya.

Constantine: She's the quickest of them, no doubt. But even her entire squad won't be enough to turn the tide.

Constantine: It's time, Z.

Z: But ma'am, withdrawing now could damage morale.

Constantine: I trust our soldiers. After all, we're not fighters. Our presence here does nothing but slow them down.

Constantine: Contact every Committee member and House of Integratus representative you can reach. We're relocating to the top floor of the Spire by the president's order.

Z: The Spire ... Understood. Is there anything you'd like me to bring, ma'am?

Constantine: Your kettle and some tea. You'll need it.

Z: You don't seem at all concerned. Is there something I don't know about?

Pyrodrake Phlogiston Incendiaries rain down on the Manus. Though few in number, they're enough to throw the enemy's reserves into a panic.

Southern Garden, St. Pavlov Foundation

Manus Soldier II: Cannon, the cannon!

Manus Soldier II: Damn it, cannon's lost! Get out of here! Those trees are catching fire!

The Manus soldiers scatter and flee the mazelike gardens. From the air, they look like startled ants.

Ritualist: Witches! How did they get here so quickly?

A dark-clad soldier crosses a hedge to reach the ritualist.

Manus Soldier I: Ma'am, General Krutov has sent word again.

Ritualist: Do I look like I have time for his sniveling? Tell him to fix his own messes.

Ritualist: I would have had the array ready for those Flying Witches if you idiots hadn't kept getting in my way.

The ritualist pushes the frightened soldier aside and walks toward a building near the garden.

Hallway, Southern Annex

Infuriated, she enters the building. The hall inside is oddly cool amid the fires of battle.

Ritualist: Buzz all you like, pests. I'll clip your wings soon enough. We need to move the array rites elsewhere.

Ritualist: Somewhere those irksome flies cannot bother us. Not under a roof, but nowhere fully exposed.

Ustrina: Was this not the place set aside for you?

Ritualist: You've got some nerve asking that. Where have you been? Off in your whimsical little world again?

Ritualist: In case such practical matters slipped your mind, your witless rabble were supposed to be hunting down the Foundation's arcanists.

Ustrina: All is in hand. Though there has been some unexpected reluctance from them, the reason for which still eludes me.

Ritualist: You're trying to understand them?

Her staff slams against the gray and white checkered floor.

Ritualist: I can't waste any more breath on this.

She passes Ustrina and leaves through the building's other exit.

Stomping feet echo through the corridor, fortunately concealing another's approach.

???: ...

Southern Annex, St. Pavlov Foundation

The ritualist arrives at an outdoor space behind the building, where the wide-open gardens are replaced with tidy pathways.

Ritualist: With those Flying Witches focused on the gardens and the plaza, this location must suffice.

???: Prima.

Ritualist: —?!

She whips her head around to face the voice's source.

Ms. Stranger: I didn't expect to find you working alone. You've grown careless.

Ritualist: Grace? Impossible. How did you get here?

Ms. Stranger: As I always do. You of all people should know my means.

Ritualist: *sneer* And you think you can simply show your face here and get away unscathed?

Ms. Stranger: Come on, then. Let's see what tricks you've picked up in my absence.

Ritualist: *choke*

Ritualist: Grace, you deceitful parasite! I'll make you pay for my mother's death in Antarctica.

Ms. Stranger: Level your accusations later. Now, tell me how you got past the Foundation's security.

Ritualist: *cough* Traitor, thief! You'll get nothing from me.

Ms. Stranger: Enough, Prima. I don't have time for your tantrums.

Ritualist: ...!

Ms. Stranger: Stay calm. This will only take a moment. You might even survive if you're lucky.

Ritualist: I curse you, Grace! You'll never be free. You'll die a pathetic, sniveling slave.

The moth beats its wings once more and flutters away from Ms. Stranger's fingertip, then lands on the ritualist's face.

Ritualist: Take it off. Get this thing off my face!

Ms. Stranger: ...!

It's as if something sucks away the air around them.

Then the moth forged by her arcane skill turns into fine powder before their eyes.

Ms. Stranger: No. What? What's happening?

Marsha: Don't stay out in the open like that, Nautika. You're too exposed.

Nautika: It's okay. They can't hurt me, really.

Manus Soldier I: Damn it!

The Manus's attacks on Nautika glance off her like water over a stone.

Ricocheting incantations slam against the walls. Fortunately, the Committee Building is sturdy enough to withstand them.

Foundation Security: Take this: Smashing Bouncing Ball!

A fist-sized sphere flies out from behind cover, bouncing off the floor, walls, and ceiling.

Manus Soldier I: Get down! Ugh!

The ball smashes a dent into a black helmet.

Foundation Security: You've got to give them credit. Those Laplace brainiacs sure know how to build some solid toys.

Soldier I: Impressive. But I still don't get why you have to shout that bloody name every time.

Foundation Security: The higher the volume, the greater the damage. That's what the guy in the tin box said.

Soldier I: Alright, can't hurt to have a little fun. Let me try one.

The security staff and soldiers fall back behind cover and continue making use of their new "toys."

Meanwhile, from the other end of the battleground, Krutov observes the escalating counterattack.

Krutov: Their Chimera is immune to our incantations. Nothing a swift bullet to the head couldn't solve, if that druid weren't so incessant.

Krutov: We don't have the forces for close-quarters combat. Where the hell is our heavy firepower?

He steps back a bit, attempting to get a wider field of view. His troops are on the edge of breaking. The unthinkable occurs: A tactical retreat may be necessary.

But then, Arcana appears.

Arcana: ...

Krutov: ...!

An indescribable force compels Krutov to step aside.

The battle of black and white comes to an eerie pause. All present seem to be paralyzed with awe and terror.

Arcana: It is a wondrous form thou hast claimed, Nautika. I cannot help but behold thy beauty with some awe.

Arcana: Did we not return to this world upon the same blessed day? Pray tell—how fares thy second life, and the powers thou hast seized?

Nautika: My-My life has nothing to do with you, Arcana.

Arcana's focus shifts, not dismissively, but as effortlessly as a turning wind.

Arcana: Ms. Weyerhaeuser? Charming as ever. What a delight to chance upon thee here as well.

Druvis III: ...

Arcana: Too long has it been e'er last we spoke. And a question hath weighed upon me since then: why protect these humans, the cause of thy family's ruin?

She takes a step closer.

Nautika: Leave her to me!

Nautika spreads her wings and lunges at Arcana.

Yet Arcana stands unmoved and unafraid, as if she is only watching a performance.

Arcana: Hush, child.

Nautika: ...!

Druvis's thorns wither away, and Nautika comes crashing to the marble floor below.

Her entire body feels heavy, as if she had been drained of all strength. With effort, she manages to move her upper half, but her lower limbs are motionless.

Nautika: I ... I can't get up.

Marsha: Something's wrong.

Each and every arcanist feels it, a sensation like having the air ripped from their lungs, like being pulled down to the ocean floor, at once both pressure and suffocation.

The massive tree behind them begins to buckle and shake until it comes crashing down.

Druvis III: There are still people under the tree.

Recoleta: No. My adventure ...

Arcanists across the battlefield begin to waver and collapse into unconsciousness.

Arcana stands at the other end of the long hall, wearing a satisfied expression, like an artist overlooking their work.

Arcana: Rise.

Nautika: ...!

She is suddenly pulled up into the air as if weightless.

Nautika: Something's picking me up.

Arcana: Fall.

She sinks back down only to be pulled to one side, her body dragging against the rubble-strewn floor.

Nautika: N-No! I can't stop!

Then, with a flick of her wrist, Arcana sends Nautika and all the people, objects, and foliage in her path hurtling out of the building.

...

Arcana: At last, some peace and quiet.

Rational Passion

小径

"No Longer Poles Apart" Research Project Proposal

Dear and wonderful Ms. Nautika, Laplace Scientific Computing Center has taken a keen interest in your new body. We are writing in hopes that you will agree to participate in our experiments and research. Rest assured, we remain fully committed to humanitarian care and professional research ethics—which is why you are welcome to check off only the projects you are willing to take part in. The research projects regarding "No Longer Poles Apart" are listed below:

√1. October 13 - December 20, Research Theme: Biotic Force Field and Arcane Cell Compatibility in "No Longer Poles Apart"

Projects: Blood draw (a significant volume of blood samples is required—you are welcome to decline if you are sensitive to pain), lab analysis, Picrasma Candy sensitivity test, triathlon comparative study (humans as control group), epidermal cell stress test, unknown mucus DNA sequencing ...

√2. November 4 - January 29, Research Theme: Psychological Study of Self-Identity and Special Socialization Based on the Reconstructed Body of "No Longer Poles Apart"

Theme: Social anxiety assessment in the tiered lecture hall, avoidance-attachment relationship test in the auditorium (you are welcome to share your mythological archaeology), physical coordination test in Uluru Stadium, emotional and psychological clinical evaluation ...

√3. December 15 - January 30, Research Theme: Spatial Compatibility of the Photon Dynamic Holographic Dress with "No Longer Poles Apart"

Content: Human-form photon holographic dress design study, personal aesthetic preference research (we're very curious!), compatibility study of photon dress materials with mucus and bone, cell photosensitive spectrum determination range study, height measurement, weight measurement, arm—or wing—span measurement ...

Behind the Door

13TH-15

Behind the Door

Countdown to the "Storm"

Countdown to the "Storm"

Square, SPDM

Manus Believer: ?!

Merel's soaring figure lunges forward. There's a flash of an arcane skill, then a nimble Moon-Eyed Fiddler dodges an incoming strike.

Merel: Kaarrr!

The rolling fiddler crab crashes into the watchtower's door, pushing it open.

Merel: ...

Merel: Kaarr, hiss ... <Protocol says, in case of a campus-wide emergency, instructors without other duties are to assemble at the central watchtower and wait for deployment ...>

A rotunda, somehow both stifling and spacious, welcomes her.

Merel: Hiss? <But it's empty. No instructors. No security. Where did everyone go?>

She has no time to ponder the question further. The moment she dispels her transformation, Merel rises to her feet and goes to close the door.

Merel: Ah!

But before she can shut it, something powerful shoves it back open, knocking her to the ground.

A heavy hammer swings toward her.

Manus Believer: 幺!

Merel: No way out.

Yermolai: If you're outnumbered? You run. Simple as that.

Yermolai: No heroics. Dead soldiers don't win wars.

Yermolai: Invisibility incantations might help, but arcanum isn't reliable. Guns never fail. Burn that into your skull.

Merel rolls out of the path of the hammer just as it slams down.

Arcane radiance conceals her body. All that's left is her voice echoing in the rotunda.

Merel: Let's see how you like this.

bang

She empties her magazine.

Manus Believer: 歹!

Gunshots. Screams. A brief pause on both sides. Then she reloads.

Manus Believer: 尢?

The cluster of believers falls back. Black ooze and blood splatter reveal Merel's silhouette even before her optical illusion fades.

She charges toward the stairs and turns to face her enemies. They're retreating upstairs.

Merel: Second floor. There's a door. I can lock them out. Should buy a little time.

Merel: I just hope the security team's master key works here.

bang-bang

Merel fires two shots straight ahead in an attempt to buy herself a few seconds of respite, then turns and runs toward the second floor's blast door.

The key sticks in the lock with a frustrating clink.

Merel: Come on. Don't do this to me.

Manus Believer: 幺!

Merel: ...!

She reflexively shields her face with her hand only to find that her foe's arcane skill hasn't hit her. A square of metal mesh, curved by the impact, rocks back and forth on the ground.

Merel: Wh-Where did that come from?

Emilia: Heads up!

A young girl pokes her head out from the vent. Radiance still lingers from the staff in her hand.

Emilia: Seems like I did the incantation right.

Merel: Emilia? What on earth are you doing here?

Emilia: Shouldn't I be asking you that?

Though she answers the question with one of her own, she exits the vent rather than waiting for a response.

Merel: No, wait. Just stay right there.

Emilia: There are so many of them. Why are they gathering around like this?

Regret wells up in Merel's throat.

The blast door feels like the jaws of a trap. They're cornered now.

Merel: Hop on, Emilia! I'll get you back into the air vent.

Emilia: What about you? You won't fit in there.

Merel: I'll find a way.

click

The sound of salvation comes from the door behind them.

Merel: Wait. It's open?

She doesn't have time to consider the answer.

Merel: Emilia, help me open this door.

Lucas: Hey!

Lucas's youthful face flushes red with effort as he pulls on the door.

Lucas: Quick! Get in.

The three of them shut their pursuers out. Only when the lock clicks into place do they let out a sigh of relief.

Second Floor, Central Watchtower

Merel: *pant*

Merel straightens up and turns to the young children, her saviors, adopting an uncharacteristically serious expression.

Merel: Lucas, Emilia, what are you two doing out here?

Emilia: They put us in detention, remember? Then the alarm went off, and an explosion blew a hole through the wall, so we ran.

Merel stumbles over her thoughts and looks away. She can hardly criticize them for running to safety.

Merel: Sorry. You wouldn't have been left in there if it weren't for me.

Emilia: Oh. That wasn't your fault. We broke the rules, after all.

Emilia: We knew the central tower was where people were supposed to go, so we headed here. Looks like that was a mistake.

Lucas: We ran into a whole load of weird monsters on the way here. Guess what the instructor said about the dangers outside wasn't just to scare us after all.

Lucas: But where is everyone, miss?

Merel: The library. That's where the instructors sent everyone. I just came from there.

Lucas leaps to his feet.

Lucas: See, Emilia? I told you we should've gone to the library.

Emilia: There's always security here at the tower. How was I supposed to know they'd all be gone?

Merel: Alright, you two, now's not the time.

Merel: I'll get you to the library. But first, there's something important I need to get from upstairs.

Merel: You two get back in the vent and wait.

She looks down in thought, attempting to devise some plan to get these kids from here to safety, but her thoughts are quickly interrupted.

Emilia: What do you mean? Can't we go with you?

Merel: Well, it ... it's too dangerous.

Emilia: All the more reason to not split up.

Lucas: She's right. And trust me. You're gonna need us. I know all kinds of stuff they don't teach in class.

Merel: No. Please, both of you listen. I've fought those monsters before. They don't care how smart you are or how many incantations you know.

Merel: See that hammer that guy's holding? I've seen it smash trained soldiers to pieces.

The young, caged doves stare at her blankly for a long moment.

Emilia: But how are you going to get up there? Every door is locked except the main one. We've checked.

Lucas: That's why we ended up hiding in the vent.

Merel: I've got a master key.

Emilia: But it didn't look like it worked on that door you tried it on.

Merel: Well, then I'll shapeshift and get to the top through the vent. Once I've got what I need, I'll open the door from the inside and take the stairs.

Emilia: That won't work. The vent was blocked in the explosions. You can't get past the second floor. We've tried.

Lucas: And the blast doors won't open from the inside.

Merel: What do you mean? Didn't you just open that one for me?

Lucas: No. I thought you opened it.

Emilia: I just told you. Her key doesn't work.

Merel: ...

Merel: Then who did open it?

???

All sense of direction is lost.

Dust swirls in the air.

???: You've come to me at last, Vertin.

Vertin: Who are you? Where's Sonetto?

???: There is no name that I might give you that will serve your understanding.

???: As for your friend—she was not meant to be here.

Vertin: Your voice ... I've heard it before, through the monitor.

Vertin: But you're not Arcana.

Vertin: You are the true creator of this "boon."

Snow Blindness · 1/2

13TH-16

Overexposed

Vertin: You are the true creator of this "boon."

???: And you are its rightful receiver.

Vertin: Rightful receiver? Then why was it in Arcana's possession? And why was it given to Igor?

???: You know the ways of time and fate. The "boon" comes to you only at the proper moment, just as you have come to me.

Choices

1. I'm tired of riddles.

2. I don't know anything about time or fate.

3. How do you know me?

Branch 1

Vertin: Perhaps on another day I would be willing to solve your riddles, but not now. I want a clear answer.

???: The answers you seek will come. They will find you when the sleeping mind awakens.

???: There is one final veil between you and the truth.

Branch 2

Vertin: So you say, but I've had remarkably little luck understanding either lately.

???: In the river of time, all creation is naught but drifting sand.

???: Only the weavers of the golden thread may ride upon its tides.

Branch 3

Vertin: You speak as though you know me. Have we met before?

???: Beneath the ruins of civilization, in an ancient past.

???: Yet neither of us came to seek that story. Not on this day.

Shared continuation

Vertin: Igor was promised that the "boon" would protect him, but it didn't. Will that happen to me as well?

???: The promise still stands.

???: But mortal hands cannot stop the sand from slipping through their fingers.

Vertin: What are you expecting me to do, then?

???: You need no counsel from me. The "boon" is already yours.

???: I do not seek to bestow blessings, for you need none.

???: Vekiĝu en la regno de mortemuloj.

Vertin: ...!

Vertin: Vekiĝu en la regno de mortemuloj.

Vertin: ...?!

The flowing dust is blown away, revealing a familiar library, but everything appears hollow and fake, like stage dressing.

The light shines colorless and stark.

Sonetto: Timekeeper?

Vertin: Sonetto? Where are you?

Sonetto: I'm right here. Can't you see me?

It is difficult to make out where Sonetto's voice is coming from.

Vertin: No. I can't see anything. It's too dark.

Vertin: Sonetto, where are—

A pair of surprisingly small hands reach out and take hold of the drifting consciousness.

Sonetto: I'm right beside you.

Sonetto: We're in the library, just us. No students, no staff, no Manus Vindictae.

Sonetto: You disappeared after we went through that gate, then reappeared behind me just now.

Sonetto: What do you mean you can't see? Has something happened to your eyes?

Vertin: I'm not sure. It's like I've been hit by a flashbang. But I'll manage.

Vertin: You sound different.

Sonetto: That's because we're both children again. We look like we did when we were SPDM students.

Vertin: Then this can't truly be reality. It's like what happened in the Amber Room.

Vertin: The flow of time has been disrupted.

Sonetto: Where did you go after stepping into the gate, Timekeeper?

Vertin: I'm not certain. There was a mist or dust, and I heard a voice.

Vertin: It said I already knew how to gain protection from the "boon." Then it spoke an incantation.

Sonetto: Then, does that mean we succeeded?

Sonetto blinks. Her face is a strange mixture of joy and confusion.

It's difficult to believe things went smoothly. For her part at least, it seems as if she's been walking in circles without end.

Vertin: I repeated the incantation, but I have no idea if it worked. We need to find a way out of this timeline anomaly if we're to know if it had any effect.

Sonetto: Speaking of time, I looked around while you were gone.

Little Sonetto can't help but feel vexed by how odd the situation is and how somehow the least troubling thing is their sudden return to childhood.

Sonetto: There are no clocks, calendars, or even yearbooks in this place. Anything that might indicate a date or time is missing.

Sonetto: And whenever I try to leave, I just end up back where I started. It's like a maze that won't let us go.

Vertin: Wait, Sonetto.

Sonetto: What is it?

Vertin: There's a light, a golden thread. I can feel it, feel her.

Sonetto: Her?

The hand gently touches the golden thread.

An ethereal, pleasant sound trembles through the space.

Vertin: It's Merel.

Sonetto: But I can't see her anywhere. How do you know it's her?

Vertin: I just know. I can't explain how.

Far beyond what Sonetto's eyes can see, the golden thread stretches onward into the darkness until it ends tied into a knot of black nothingness.

Vertin: The thread's tangled. Merel may be in trouble. But her knot isn't anywhere close.

Vertin: Sonetto, where am I facing?

Following the gaze, Sonetto spies the outline of a tower looming down from a distance.

Sonetto: Toward the central watchtower.

Sonetto: I tried to find a way there earlier. But I couldn't even manage to leave the library.

Vertin: Let's try following Merel's thread.

Vertin: Take my hand. I'll guide us. You clear the way.

Sonetto: Of course.

Vertin: Let's get out of here.

Competitive Business

小径

sigh I'm surprised, I must say.

Why would anyone else want to talk to you in riddles the same way I do?

It's kind of a chore being this vague, to be honest. He has to be getting paid for this.

Choices

1. Are you paid to talk to me?

2. Are you actually interested in talking to me?

Branch 1

If only.

All I've received in compensation for our little talks is a dry tongue. I've already poured three pots of tea today.

Branch 2

Do you think you're all that interesting a conversation partner?

I'm not some retiree who has nothing else to do.

The only reason I talk to you is because you won't leave my house.

What else should I do? I'm not strong enough to throw you out.

My only defense is a razor-sharp wit, though it seems to never cut you deep enough to matter. I swear at times I think you've been glued into that chair.

sigh Never mind. Sometimes we just have to accept the little disappointments in life.

That old dust whines about the plaster figures intruding in his room. But that's all he's done so far.

If he wants to take over for me, do let me know. If it means not having to come up with any more riddles, I'll even let him sit in my chair.

Shared continuation

Competitive Business

Snow Blindness · 2/2

13TH-16

Sonetto: ...!

The moment the marble threshold is crossed, the mazelike space begins to collapse behind them. The library is now more than a hundred paces behind.

Sonetto: We made it!

Vertin: Good. Then this thread is leading us to exactly where we need to be.

The golden thread winds toward the second floor, where it ultimately tangles into another knot.

Guided by instinct, each step draws closer to the thread.

Choices

1. story_option_guideslide|0#0#1#9999

The knot unravels with the slightest touch.

As it does, it seems to flow across the back of the hand.

Vertin: There we go.

click

The sound of salvation comes from the door behind them.

Merel: Wait. It's open?

Merel: Emilia, help me open this door.

The Hope in Her Heart

13TH-17

The Hope in Her Heart

The council chamber on the fifth floor is nearly overflowing.

Pedra: I never would have expected so many arcanists to risk their lives for the Foundation, even with their powers taken away from them.

Irinei: You underestimated them, just as you've always underestimated what solidarity can accomplish.

Pedra: Solidarity? I never thought I'd hear that word coming from you.

Constantine: Ladies and gentlemen—

An authoritative voice from the podium puts an end to their bickering.

Constantine: Inside this room are all the surviving members of the Committee and the House of Integratus.

Constantine: The third floor of the Committee Building has fallen, and the enemy is advancing through the fourth as we speak. If this continues, the entire building will fall before help arrives.

Constantine: The president has ordered an immediate evacuation. All of you and any other non-combatant staff are to head to his office on the top floor.

Constantine steps down from the podium. The solemn silence of the room is interrupted by the not-so-distant hammer of gunfire beyond the door.

Irinei: Look at us. A bunch of beaten-down cowards.

Pedra: Hah. And who do you intend to hold accountable this time?

Z: Gentlemen, please, choose your battles.

Z: Yes, we used to fight over policies in this room. But now is the time to set our issues aside and unite around our common goal.

Irinei: Survival. Yes. That is the grim reality.

Pedra: I had hoped we might reconcile under better circumstances.

Z: Don't lose hope yet, Pedra. Perhaps one day we'll be able to return to this room more united than ever before.

Irinei: We can save the debate over that until we get out of here in one piece. Every second we linger is another stress on the people protecting our lives.

Nautika tumbles through the air.

Nautika: Hold on tight.

Eagle: Nautika!

The impact of her landing rumbles the ground like a burst of artillery.

Nautika: I-I took as much of the impact as I could. Are you alright?

Her lower body has faded and crumpled like loose fabric. No matter how Nautika tries, her beast half lies still and unresponsive—an exhausting, fruitless struggle.

Eagle: Yep, everyone's okay.

They all climb down from Nautika's back.

J: Uh, we woulda been toast without you, Nautika. You good?

Nautika: I'm just glad no one's hurt. But I-I need some time to get up.

"Razor": What just happened? Is everyone alright?

J: Huh? Didn't you feel loopy when Arcana did that hush trick?

"Razor": Loopy? I didn't feel a thing.

Eagle: Maybe it only affects arcanists.

Eagle: I can't use any of my arcane skills. It's like the channel of my pneuma is blocked.

"Razor": Like a clogged pipe?

He casts aside his doubts for now and looks around.

"Razor": Whatever it was, the enemy will be hunting for you. Stick with us. We humans don't need powers to fight. Alright team, gather up.

J: Yo, Cap, don't you go treating me like some kinda pushover. My blade still cuts, with or without my arcane skills.

"Razor": Wouldn't think of it, J. Just don't get yourself hurt, alright?

"Razor" rallies those who can still fight.

Just as they're circling around Nautika, a moth appears and lands on Eagle's shoulder.

Eagle: Hmm?

Eagle: A moth? Ms. Stranger, is that you?

Ms. Stranger: I've found clues as to the Manus entry point.

Ms. Stranger: Operation's going smoothly so far. Entrance should be located and closed down in no time.

"Razor": Is she saying she's found the Manus entry point and she's on her way to close it?

Eagle: That's what I heard too. But ...

Another possibility tugs at Eagle's mind.

Eagle: How did this message get through? All arcane skills are muted. Only the Manus can ...

Eagle: Did she ...?!

Ritualist: *cough*

Her mouth is pried open, and the struggling moth flies out.

It returns to Ms. Stranger's ear to whisper memories and information and then disappears.

Ms. Stranger: Looks like the risk paid off. The mask restored my power.

Viscous slime drips from the mask and onto her pale cheeks.

The ritualist slumps against the wall as if utterly drained, though no more worse for wear than "Grace."

Ritualist: You dare to steal power from a Manus mask. Are you brave or merely foolish, Grace?

Ms. Stranger: This isn't the first time I've been tested by it, Prima. I know how to resist its corruption.

Ritualist: Your resistance is meaningless. The mask will destroy the unfaithful. But you've lived on stolen time for long enough. I should've ended you before you ever made it to Antarctica.

Ms. Stranger: Is that so? Funny. I always thought you were more eager for your mother's death than I was. You wanted her position for yourself, didn't you?

Ritualist: You lie!

Ritualist: I have only ever admired her unwavering devotion to the Guiding One.

Ritualist: A devotion that ended in martyrdom—a sacrifice which shall be rewarded. Her-Her flesh may have perished, but her name lives on.

Ritualist: As for you, treacherous pest that you are, you will die inconsequential and unremembered.

Ms. Stranger: Inconsequential ... That sounds familiar. They did tell you what happened during your mother's so-called "martyr's death," didn't they?

Ms. Stranger: It wasn't some sacred act. She wasn't chosen. It was an accident, Prima.

Ms. Stranger: The roof collapsed. A large chunk of it fell, and she was too absorbed in her own preaching to notice, until it squashed her like a bug.

Ms. Stranger: An inconsequential, meaningless death. The only good thing that came of it was the silence.

Ritualist: No. Damn you and your lies!

Ms. Stranger: Do you really think her death meant anything to Arcana? None of you have ever mattered to her.

Ms. Stranger: She sent you here to spread chaos simply because it amuses her. She calls herself a savior, but she doesn't care if any of you die in the process.

Ms. Stranger: Because she isn't a savior, nor a god. Only a purveyor of lies and chaos. All she brings is ruin and death.

Ritualist: I ... I'll tear that blasphemous tongue from your mouth!

Ms. Stranger: Descend into dreams.

Ritualist: ...!

The ritualist succumbs to her exhaustion and falls unconscious. Ms. Stranger, hearing the faint murmurs coming from the mask, turns around.

Ms. Stranger: Both the Manus and the Foundation lie for our loyalty and sacrifice.

Ms. Stranger: But whatever lies they tell, it makes no difference to me. I am loyal only to my own cause now.

Soldier I: My Semi-Automatic Construction Arm has gone offline.

Foundation Security: Leave it. Laplace's equipment runs on arcanum. They'll all be useless now.

Foundation Security: Human soldiers, behind the barricade. Cover the arcanists as they retreat, now!

All that's left along the path of the soldiers' retreat are bizarre tools.

Soldier I: Looks like we're doing this the old-fashioned way.

Their arcane skills may have faltered, but their bullets still fly. Though the tide has turned against them once more, the Foundation continues to resist in every way they can.

A soldier trains his sights on this wholly exposed target.

Soldier I: ...! That's ...

Arcana: ...

She advances without hurry, without fear, through the hail of fire. The soldier's finger finds the trigger.

Creius: Hold your fire.

A hand grips his shoulder.

Soldier I: Huh?

Creius: All units, hold fire. That's Arcana. Firearms don't harm her. Disengage, I repeat, disengage!

Creius has no particular authority to issue orders, but as glimmers of recognition spread through their ranks, they take heed of him all the same.

Meanwhile, Arcana continues toward the Foundation's line of defense, unbothered by the display.

Arcana: Ah, guns. How quaint.

She strolls past their defenses as one might a garden hedge.

Soldiers: ...

Creius: ...

For a moment, every soldier present can feel the heartbeats of their neighbor throbbing in their ears, until the gunfire resumes.

Creius: She warned me about this.

Foundation Security: Why didn't she do anything, sir?

Creius: Because we're irrelevant to her.

Foundation Security: ...

Foundation Security: Then, what do we do?

Creius: All we can do—slow down the rest of the Manus forces. Leave Arcana to those who can handle her.

His eyes betray his confident tone as he stares out at the smoke-filled hall. Eventually, his gaze turns to his hand.

Several minutes ago, a moth sent by Ms. Stranger had landed there.

Creius: Ms. Stranger, you were right about her.

Song of the Black Sheep

13TH-18

Song of the Black Sheep

Countdown to the "Storm"

Countdown to the "Storm"

Lyra: Prima, should the language of music elude you, you may command them with incantations in its stead.

Ritualist: Yes, ma'am.

Lyra: I have matters to attend to whilst you children play your games with the Foundation. I trust the "Windweave" will be safe in your care.

Lyra: You may one day be worthy of your mother's place. But first, prove yourself.

...

...

Ms. Stranger: I said, be quiet!

She holds herself up against the building's coarse outer wall.

Ms. Stranger: ...

Ms. Grace: So many donned this mask because of your lies. Do you remember their faces?

Ms. Grace: 0,110#You lured them in, broke them, and cast them into the abyss,

stood by and watched them surrender their souls to a goddess you never believed in—

never truly knew.

Ms. Stranger: I did.

Ms. Grace: 0,104#Now it's your turn to face the trial. You know what awaits you if you fail.

Why not seek the forgiveness of the Mother of Resurrection?

Ms. Grace: 31,-19#She has spared you. She would embrace you once more, as any loving mother would a wayward child.

Ms. Stranger: I won't. I'll never return to her.

She staggers back to her feet.

Ms. Stranger: This mask can't overpower me. I know how to control it.

Ms. Grace: -259,68#Of course. You are no stranger to this mask.

You've worn it before. But then, you still had the Phototaxis to protect you.

Ms. Grace: 316,-50#How daring of you to think you can master it alone this time.

Ms. Stranger: At least my mind is still my own. That's all I need.

Her attention is drawn to the southernmost building.

Ms. Stranger: That way is Building 5, where the refugees were housed.

Ms. Grace: o,o#And do you see those people?

Arcanist soldiers—our brothers and sisters—they have put on the mask.

From this day forth, they fight only for their own people.

A gray and white tower stands not far off. Soldiers in black exit onto the path leading to the Foundation headquarters.

Ms. Stranger: Those are Krutov's troops. Prima's memory was correct. That must be where the Manus entered the Foundation.

Ms. Stranger: But why here? Why in the refugees' residences?

Ms. Grace: Let's find out, shall we?

Ms. Stranger: ...

Bold strides carry her through throngs of Arcana's followers and toward Building 5.

Manus Officer: ...?

Nobody pays the masked woman any mind.

She slips through the door and enters the building.

Entrance, Building Five

Ms. Stranger: ...

It isn't that she expected to see anything in particular. She hasn't given it enough time to expect anything at all. But the sight that greets her still exceeds her wildest imagination.

Mycelia-like bodies playing bizarre music quiver in the air, their steady yet creeping movements resembling the closing mouths of Venus flytraps.

Ms. Stranger: This is ...

Ms. Grace: A passage that connects us all.

Using limbs mutated into instruments, believers twist and writhe their bodies in resonance with the "Windweave's" deep tones.

Manus Orchestra: ㄨ ... ㄣ ... ㄤ ...

Ms. Stranger: This must be the orchestra Lyra mentioned, and these monsters are communicating through song. This is where they sent those who failed the trial.

Ms. Stranger: When and how did Lyra do all this? I had no idea. I must have overlooked some clue.

She suppresses her guilt and focuses her attention on the strange maw's depths instead.

From the location of its "throat" emerges another troop of shadowy figures.

Ms. Grace: I'm sure you know what must be done.

Ms. Stranger: Yes. I will end it here.

Ms. Stranger: I know how to control these things, and Prima has just shown me the incantation to command them.

Ms. Stranger: I'll order the orchestra to play the song to sever the "Windweave."

Ms. Grace: Hmph!

Ms. Stranger: I'll just—Urgh!

The mask gnaws at her consciousness. The hands covering her face are like delicate instruments of torture, peeling the nonbeliever's disguise away layer by layer.

Ms. Grace: Did it ever occur to you, in all the grandness of your mission,

that using a Manus incantation might invite the mask deeper into your mind?

Ms. Stranger: I ...

Ms. Grace: Your resistance is as pathetic as it is ungrateful in the face of the Guiding One's mercy.

Ms. Grace: Come along home, dear. Lay down that heavy burden. You're no Foundation dog.

You're with your own kind. You'll be safe. You can finally be free.

Ms. Grace: You've been away for far too long.

Too long to remember what it is to belong, to be happy, to be surrounded by family.

Come back. We will all rejoice in your return.

Ms. Grace: You can have the life you want and a new name. Not "Grace," not "Moth," no longer a "Stranger."

Ms. Stranger: Go home, to the primeval glaciers.

An incantation is chanted. The piercing hum bores through her eyeballs and into her brain like a fanged worm, devouring the tender flesh in its path.

Her limbs tremble, as if her own body were joining the sickening orchestra.

Ms. Stranger: ...!

Manus Orchestra: ㄝ ... ㄥ ...

Amid all the chaos, she hears it—the orchestra's melody is changing.

Manus Orchestra: ㄚ—! ㄩ! ㄥ—!

The final note plays, and in that instant, she faintly hears a prolonged wail of agony coming from the abyss.

A force wraps around the sound like a gentle cover before whisking it away into the recesses of a far-off time.

Ms. Stranger: It's done. The portal is closed.

The incantation worked. She knows she's succeeded. Yet her success will come at a price.

Without control over the Phototaxis, she is powerless to resist the mask's trial.

Ms. Stranger: No. Don't do this to me. No!

Ms. Stranger: I don't ... want to ... go ...

Ms. Stranger: No more names ... No more orders ...

Ms. Stranger: I've ... never ... really lived ... ㄛ ...

Ms. Stranger: I ... No ... ㄨ ...

Ms. Stranger: Harrrgh! *cough*

Ms. Stranger: *vomit*

Ms. Stranger: I want to live.

Ms. Stranger: To leave here.

Ms. Stranger: To never, never come back.

Lilya: Fighting on foot? Ugh. You gotta be kidding me.

Lilya gives a disheartened look over to her inert broom. She won't be returning to the sky for now.

But she can't make clear sense of why. It seemed that her Red 38's arcane engine stalled all at once and for no clear reason. The conclusion only comes to her as she realizes she's lost her arcane skills as well.

Lilya: Looks like I need to leave you here, buddy. Better hope the Manus don't snatch you up.

Lilya: Hm?

But she still has a pistol.

Lilya: Who's there?

Ms. Stranger: ...

A figure staggers into view, only noticeable when she's come close enough for Lilya to make out her face.

Ms. Stranger: Help, help.

Lilya: It's you! You—

She catches Ms. Stranger as she sinks to her knees.

Lilya: You're all covered in slime. What the hell happened?

Ms. Stranger: The portal ... The Manus's portal is closed.

Ms. Stranger: Mission complete.

The Killing Board

小径

Queenside Attack

[Opening: French Defense]
...
25. White: Queen d2 | Black: Queen e4 [Black breaks through White's queenside.]
Krutov: "Those Foundation office rats don't know the first thing about combat. Keep the pressure on the front lines! Push forward!"
26. White: Queen xg5+ | Black: Queen g6 [Black's kingside is exposed—White's queen strikes.]
Krutov: "What in the hell are those people in the back doing with their arcane skills? ... Never mind them—more firepower! Tear a hole in this line!"
27. White: Rook xg6+ | Black: fxg6 [White presses the attack against Black.]
Krutov: "Hold the line until reinforcements arrive ... What are the 'orchestra' and those 'gatekeepers' doing?"

[Middlegame: Kingside Storm]
...
31. White: Bishop xg6 | Black: Knight d5 [White clears the queenside—the tide turns.]
Krutov: "Where are the reinforcements? Where the hell are they!"
32. White: Queen xb7 | Black: King xg6 [White's pieces strike back at Black.]
Krutov: "Say that again—what do you mean, 'The traitor has destroyed the main channel of our network'?! Where the hell are Lyra and that pile of scrap metal?"
33. White: Queen xa8 | Black: Knight xc3 [Black's pawns make a desperate last stand.]
Krutov: "Where do you think you're going! There's no retreat! Stick to the plan! Break through their last line of defense!"

[Endgame: Battle for the Post]
...
46. White: Queen b2 | Black: King d1 [Black risks it all on promotion.]
Krutov: "There's nowhere to go but forward—so fight like your lives depend on it! Keep tearing through these Foundation scum!"
47. White: Queen xc3 | Black: c1=Queen [Black pawn promotes to Queen.]
Krutov: "She will come for us! Hold the line!"
...

Protection Amulet

13TH-19

Amulets

A door opens.

Merel: *pant*

Then another, as if by divine intervention.

Fourth Floor, Central Watchtower

Emilia: It's been a little too easy. Don't you think? It's like someone's walking ahead and unlocking all the doors for us.

As if by way of reply, the next door opens to greet them.

Clearly unsettled, Lucas huddles up to Emilia to whisper into her ear.

Lucas: You think it's ghosts?

Emilia: Ah! D-Don't be ridiculous. And even if there were ghosts, they'd obviously be haunting the detention room.

Merel: It couldn't be. The school hires exorcists for a full inspection every vernal equinox. Didn't you know that?

The attempt to calm their fears falls flat. Assurances of safety do little in the face of the crisis around them.

Merel: But if you're still worried, I've got just the thing for you two.

She reaches into her pocket.

Merel: Here. Keep these close.

Cold, hard metal sits in their palms.

Emilia: I thought you were going to give us a talisman or an amulet to keep the ghosts away.

Merel: Well, these are pretty much the same thing.

Merel: Lucas, yours has got an optical incantation that can make you invisible.

Merel: But yours, Emilia, is a real-live grenade. Throw it out, and it'll set off a small explosion, understand? I bet the instructors never let you try these before. Pretty cool, right?

Lucas: Yeah, sure, but why does she get the real thing?

Merel: Because as far as I've seen, Emilia thinks before she acts. I can trust her to use it responsibly.

Merel: You, on the other hand, would probably lob it out the first chance you got.

Lucas: I would not.

Emilia: I'll be careful. I promise.

Her voice is so low it's as if she's speaking to herself.

Merel ruffles the hair of her two young friends and then turns to make for the stairs.

Merel: Alright then. Let's keep moving.

The staircase's spiral rise blurs the trio's perception. It feels as if each turn should be the last, and yet it continues onward until the climb becomes almost excruciating.

Emilia: The top floor is right above us.

Emilia pauses before the window ahead, perhaps too narrow for an intruder to get through, but wide enough to make them visible to enemy eyes.

Emilia: ...!

Merel: Watch out!

She stumbles back, but Merel's outstretched hand grabs hers before she can tumble backward.

Lucas: Emilia? What is it? You're shaking.

Emilia: I ...

Emilia: Look. Over there.

The exterior walls of the SPDM have melted like candlewax. Bloodstains and rust mar the once-pristine, indestructible barriers. Sparks dance along the ground, igniting the grass into growing flames.

The "Storm" is crossing over the now-unprotected campus. Clashing eras warp the outer buildings as the architecture shifts rapidly between different shapes and styles.

Merel: We'll be okay.

Merel: Vertin's doing everything she can. So, we've got to do the same.

Her pounding heart feels as if it is lodged in her throat as she taps on the locked door.

Merel: Vertin, Sonetto, is this you helping us?

Merel: I don't know how you're doing this. But if it really is you, then please, we need your help one last time.

As if answering her plea, the door opens. Behind it lies darkness—an unpredictable black hole.

Lucas: The door's open, again.

Merel grasps the children's hands, trying to mask the trembling in her own.

Merel: The thing we're after should be right behind it.

Vertin: That was the last knot.

Sonetto: If all the knots are undone, will Merel be able to get to the top floor safely?

A jumble of golden thread that's accumulated halfway in pushes through to the darkness beyond the door.

Vertin: I think so.

Sonetto: Then she'll be able to get the Dove to the library. I know she will. Let's head back and meet her there.

Sonetto: But first, we need to find a way out.

Sonetto: Timekeeper?

Before Sonetto, a pair of sightless eyes stare off in another direction.

Vertin: Which way am I facing, Sonetto? What's in this direction?

Sonetto: It's a door. Shall I open it?

Vertin: Yes, please. And tell me what's behind it.

Sonetto: ...!

She comes to a sudden halt.

Vertin: What do you see?

Sonetto: It opens into another space. If I'm not mistaken ...

Sonetto: It's the Committee Building's hallway.

Vertin: Then this maze can lead us to Foundation headquarters.

More golden threads sprawl out, but none glow like Merel's did. These new lines are faint, as if drifting between the destined and the uncertain.

Something in this chaotic darkness is pursuing the strings, causing them to tangle along their original paths. Then the darkness takes shape.

???: ...

Vertin: ...!

The shadow flickers. Each time it appears, it feels as if it siphons the air from the lungs.

Vertin: It's Arcana. She's here.

Sonetto: Arcana?

Sonetto can't see anything in the empty hall around them.

Sonetto: You mean, at the school? Or at headquarters?

Vertin: At headquarters, inside the Committee Building. I think I know why the Foundation never sent more reinforcements to the school.

A Peek into Fate

13TH-20

A Peek into Fate

Sonetto: Then the attack on the SPDM was a diversion. They wanted to pull Foundation forces away from headquarters.

Sonetto: Right now, Arcana has found her way into the Foundation, and the "Storm" is closing in on SPDM.

Sonetto: And here we are stuck in whatever this place is, doing nothing.

Her low muttering makes the corridor feel all the more desolate.

Vertin: ...?

Brushed by a fingertip, the golden threads begin to drift through the air. Their knotted forms tremble in the darkness.

Somewhere within the body, an innate ability, mysterious and distant, is quietly waking.

Vertin: I think I've found a path. Let me try something.

Vertin: Sonetto, this way. This is our way out.

Sonetto: But you're pointing out the window.

Her mind tries in vain to make sense of what her eyes are taking in.

Vertin: Then we need to jump out of it. Just trust me.

Sonetto: Of course.

She opens the window. Below them lies the garden that the Foundation so carefully tends to its trademark austere perfection.

Conviction and trust conquer her innate fear of heights.

She climbs onto the windowsill first and crouches there, then offers her hand.

Sonetto: Please take my hand. Slowly, please. Careful.

Vertin: Let's get out of here.

The labyrinth created by the "boon" is silent and void of any traces of life.

But in free fall, the wind's howl still passes through the ears.

Vertin: Sonetto!

At some point, the tightly clasped hands loosen as the two plunge into darkness.

Vertin: Mmm?

The fall has stopped. The body is upright, feet pointed down, no longer adrift in the void.

Vertin: My sight's restored. I can see again.

Vertin: No. This isn't right.

Vertin: ...

Vertin: These threads, the woven net ... I've seen this before.

The golden threads drift against the fingertips, like the strings of an instrument waiting to be played.

Vertin: What are they? I can touch them, even pluck them.

Vertin: Why are they revealing themselves to me?

"You know the ways of time and fate."

Vertin: ...

The palm presses onto the sand table, which is nearly submerged in the black torrent.

Vertin: ...!

The black tide recedes, and in its wake, it leaves an unstable seed.

Vertin: Is this another game of yours, Arcana?

The tower of threads, gnawed full of holes, sways as if built on shifting sands.

Right before it crumbles, the hand instinctively reaches out and catches this precarious destiny.

Vertin: One day, I will uncover its secret.

Lucas: The door's open again.

Merel: The thing we're after should be right behind it.

Merel presses a hand to the somehow unlocked door and pushes it open a crack to peer inside.

Merel: ...!

Merel pushes the children back before slipping inside.

She pulls the door shut.

Merel: Stay back. Don't come in.

Lucas: What? What's wrong? What's in there?

Merel: It's ... It's better if you don't see.

She turns around and locks the door, locking the children away from the sight that now confronts her.

Merel: ...

At last, an explanation for the missing teachers and guards, dreadful as it may be.

Merel: All the instructors, the guards, even the principal ...

Merel: Ugh!

She forces back the bile rising in her throat at the sight.

Yet despite the carnage, she feels almost calm.

Merel: Alright, Merel. You can't mess this up.

The SPDM's last line of defense against the "Storm" has fallen from its perch. The Dove's body, split into two, lies bloodstained and battered on the floor.

Merel: Shelter Dove's gone. But there should still be spares somewhere.

She kneels and pushes a corpse aside, searching for an intact Shelter Dove.

Merel: Come on, now. They're only dead people. They can't hurt you.

Merel: You've seen worse. With Charon, remember? I wonder what he'd do if he were here.

She blinks. With mechanical movements, she turns over another instructor's lifeless body.

Merel: ...!

Sheltered beneath the body lie several Shelter Doves, mercifully undamaged.

Merel: Ms. Fogel ...

Memories of her flood through Merel's mind, but one thing she refuses to do is think on the anger she once felt at her for sending her to detention all those years ago.

She wipes away the tears welling in her eyes with a shaky hand, then gathers the Shelter Doves in her arms.

Emilia: Merel? Are you okay in there? It's getting dark outside.

Merel: Y-Yes. I found it. Just a minute. Stay right there.

The solemn shutting of the door behind her feels like shoveling the last bit of dirt over a grave.

Lucas: So, inside there ...

Merel: Your teachers and the guards did everything they could to protect you. That's all you need to know.

The students can read the overwhelming sorrow on her face, but they remain silent, unsure of what to say.

The clouds heralding the "Storm's" arrival have blotted out the sun, and the loss of power has plunged the school into darkness. The Doves she holds are their only source of light.

Merel: Take these.

She hands the Shelter Doves to the students, keeping one tucked into her own arms.

Emilia: Glowing doves?

Lucas: You came all this way for some dove sculptures?

Merel: Yep. Now, we need to get these to the library. They're our only chance to survive the "Storm."

She's given up on concealing the "Storm" from them, protocol or not.

Emilia: But what about the monsters? They could still be on the first floor.

Merel: Leave them to me. I'll get you out safely.

Merel leads them back to the second floor. The blast door leading to the first floor is just as they'd left it—locked.

She presses an ear to the door and frowns when she hears footsteps behind it.

Merel: Listen carefully. You two hide in the air vent.

Merel: I'll go first and draw the monsters upstairs. You go down the vent to the ground floor and run as fast as you can to the library.

Lucas: But what about the monsters outside? How-How can Emilia and I get past them?

Lucas's bravado disappears, and the terrified child remains.

Emilia: I know exactly what to do.

Emilia: We use your invisibility grenade before we get out of the vent. Then we just have to get to the library before it wears off.

Emilia details her plan with confidence.

Merel: Brilliant, Emilia. You do exactly that. Take the Dove to the library to save your friends. Assistant Monitor Lavender will be there. I'm sure she'll be impressed.

Emilia & Lucas: ...

Merel: ...!

A powerful burst of arcane energy blasts a hole through the door.

Merel: No. That glow ... I've seen it before.

Merel: So, there's more than one of those things.

Another beam cuts through the hole, this time striking the wall just above the vent.

Rubble falls and blocks the vent's entrance, but the impact also blasts a hole in the watchtower's wall.

Merel: Emilia? Lucas? Are you alright?

Emilia: I'm fine. We're fine.

Lucas: It-It tore a hole through the wall, just like that.

Manus Disciple: ...

A familiar, intact head peeks through the hole in the door.

Merel: Bloody!

Merel: Move, now. Through the opening. I'll help you land with a levitation incantation.

Emilia: What about you?

Merel: I'll be right behind you. Remember, once you land, run straight to the library. Watch out.

The door, unable to withstand further damage, falls to the ground.

Merel: Go! Now!

Merel hoists them up and pushes them through the hole.

Emilia & Lucas: Ah!

Merel: Ŝvebi Stay!

Emilia: Merel!

Merel: I'll see you at the library.

Merel: ...!

She turns and dodges as an energy beam carves through the wall behind her and continues into the "Storm"-wrecked sky.

The disciple lowers its hand and approaches the opening in the wall, intent on breaking through it.

Manus Disciple: ...?!

Merel: Not so fast. You'll have to get through me first.

Manus Disciple: ...

The disciple's head sways as if pondering a choice. Finally, it turns to face its enemy.

Merel loads her last clip and takes a deep breath.

Merel: I've killed your kind before. I know just where to aim.

Merel: Even if I'm on my own this time—

Merel: I'm more than enough to take you down!

Manus Disciple: ...

Soft tissue flows from its cracked skull.

Merel: That's for breaking my Dove. Ugh!

A sharp pain shoots up her leg.

Merel lowers her gun and looks to the Shelter Dove in the corner—damaged mid-combat.

Merel: Could be worse. Just need to remember what Marsha showed me.

She slumps down against the wall, tears off part of her coat, and begins bandaging her wound.

The pain spikes again as she tightens the cloth around it.

Merel: Imagine her face. Urgh, if she could see me now. Tch!

Merel: Not just Marsha, all of them—Charon, the "XII," Vertin ... I'll tell them—urgh! That should do it.

With the wound now dressed, she lifts herself to her feet. She can walk, but each step comes with a wave of pain.

Merel: I'll tell them I didn't run away this time.

She finds herself at the watchtower's base and leans onto its doorframe. The world outside looks as though it's burning.

Rainwater gathers to form a puddle in a nearby crater.

Merel: That must've been Emilia's grenade. I knew you could do it, kid.

The raindrops begin to rise.

Merel: The "Storm" ...

Merel: I've got to get back to the library. I have a promise to keep.

She casts aside her now-useless pistol and everything else weighing her down. All that's left in her arms is the dimming Shelter Dove.

Merel: I really hope there won't be any more battles after this.

Merel: Now, come on. After everything I've been through ...

Merel: I can survive this!

She rushes into the rain.

The White Tower

13TH-21

The White Tower

Hallway, Committee Tower

Creius: Fall back to the Spire.

Creius: If you encounter Arcana, do not engage. I repeat, no hostile action.

Creius: If anyone shows signs of panic or pessimism, restrain them and get them away from Arcana immediately.

Irinei: You ever pictured your own death, Pedra? Ever thought it would feature the two of us, side by side?

Pedra: I'd usually suggest a bit more positivity, but that may be naive given the situation. I might have a few tips on dying with dignity, though.

Irinei: Thanks, but that much I've already figured out. Creius, give me your pistol.

Creius: Take it. Just promise me you aren't saving the last round for yourself.

Irinei: If I go down to my last bullet, I'm gunning for Arcana's head.

Pedra: Well said, Irinei. I don't think we've ever agreed more.

Krutov's army has occupied the entirety of the Committee Building beneath them. The remaining resistance forms a shrinking cordon at the upper levels.

The Spire was not built for shelter, but at this point, they have nowhere else to run.

Druvis III: ...

She yearns to hear the trees' whispers once more, to nurture new saplings, but try as she might, it's all in vain.

Regulus: Druvis! There you are.

Regulus splits away from the crowd.

Druvis III: Regulus? Did you find Mr. APPLe?

Regulus: That I did. He's here in my bag. I thought he'd flown out when we landed.

Regulus: That was a rough fall. How's Nautika holding up?

In her surprise, she senses someone familiar brush up against her.

She turns and sees Marsha carrying someone over.

Regulus: Marsha? Who've you got there? The bard?

Marsha: *sigh* I found her trapped under a filing cabinet.

There's obvious pain in her voice. Without her arcane skill, she's forced to consciously bear each and every wound she's sustained.

Marsha: She's alive. Just in a coma, same as the Awakened.

Recoleta: ...

Operation Team Leader I: We have eyes on Arcana.

The alert incites a wave of fear.

Druvis looks behind her. They're being pushed back as far as they can possibly go.

Druvis III: There isn't much space in the Spire. We'll all end up crowded in a room.

Regulus: Ugh, gods of rock have mercy. Please don't let me die in some stodgy old president's office.

Marsha: The rest of the Manus are cut off. Without reinforcements, our soldiers should be able to keep them out of the Spire. It's only Arcana that has broken through.

Marsha: We are not her goal. Whatever it is, she's decided to leave us be for now.

Druvis III: I see.

She hates this feeling of helplessness, but there's nothing more that she can do.

Druvis III: Let's get Recoleta somewhere safer.

The president's office—the sole room at the top of the Spire—would be considered rather spacious under normal circumstances.

But the crowds of survivors make it feel unbearably cramped.

President: ...

The president stands behind his desk, observing the chaos and waiting.

Foundation Security: She ... She's right behind us.

Before long, the final group of survivors enters the office.

They all look on as Arcana steps inside.

Arcana: A most remarkable spire, I must admit, Mr. President.

Arcana: How many uncounted years of labor were devoted to its construction? To this pretty monument to man's hubris?

Foundation Security: D-Don't let her come any closer.

Foundation Security: ...!

The loyal guard falls to his knees, and as he does, all the other armed personnel in the room seem to lose their will to resist, too.

All courage seems to disappear from them like smoke wisping away into the breeze.

President: ...

President: Enough of this.

Secretary General: Sir?

He waves away the rebuttal and leaves his guards' protection to stand before Arcana.

President: What is it you want, Arcana?

Arcana: Only to speak.

President: You would do all this, bring about so much pain and destruction, just to speak?

Arcana: Destruction?

She seems inexplicably puzzled.

Arcana: To cause such misery hath never been my intent.

Arcana: But alas, my children are unruly at times. Their chaotic natures drive them to violent ends.

President: Violent indeed. I'm sure you'd agree your forces have suffered considerably to get you this far.

President: So, what is this? Just entertainment to you? Like all the wars you've provoked?

Arcana: What wars have I provoked? None that were not first designed in the arrogance and bloodlust of human hearts.

Arcana: Millions lie dead—fallen to thy machines, lost in the bloody hatreds of thine own kind.

President: ...?

An elliptical barrier appears around them. The president and Arcana stand at its two focal points.

Arcana: Fear not. I desire only a little privacy.

President: For what purpose?

Arcana: An audience with the Philosopher King, ruler of the Pax House.

President: I am authorized to speak on his behalf.

Arcana: Yet thou art too young to speak on matters of the Blank Era.

President: The Philosopher King will not leave the Pax House just to answer your questions.

Arcana: Indeed not. For hath anyone e'er seen him stride beyond those walls?

Arcana: How long hath he dwelt therein, isolated from this world? Doth he know his utopia shall never come to pass?

President: His kingdom will come.

Arcana: Thou speakest words of faith, Mr. President, not of fact.

President: I trust in his vision.

Arcana: Pray tell, was his vision unable to foresee this day, or was he simply too feeble to prevent it?

President: In his design, all may be sacrificed, all may be replaced. Whether we live or die today makes no difference. Should we fall, more of us will arise to carry on the mission.

Arcana: "More of us"—thy meaning is clear. Ever obsessed with these inferior beings. Only they might fulfill his ideals; only they may prove worthy of his new world.

Arcana: Alas, that this vision of humanity is mere fabrication—

A noise interrupts their discussion.

Outside, statue-like warriors cleave at the barrier.

Arcana: The Core Guard.

Arcana: Then the Philosopher King foresaw some answer for me after all.

President: You knew about them?

Arcana: And long have I been curious of them. I suspect I am not alone in that.

Arcana: Who would not wish to meet with mankind perfected? The ideal citizens of a brave new world, unshakable against the tides of pneuma.

Arcana: The purest creations of the Pax House.

President: Taunt all you like, Arcana, but there's little you know about humans. You have always underestimated their potential.

President: The master of history is not easily challenged.

The barrier begins to crack under the warriors' blades.

"Breacher": The barrier will be breached shortly.

"Leader": Prepare to engage.

Arcana: ...

Arcana: Welcome back, Vertin.

Arcana: I am heartened to see that thou hast opened my "boon."

Arcana: Thine attempts to turn thy newfound power on me have not gone unnoticed.

Arcana: Very well. I shall leave thee to thine workings. May thou find it worthwhile.

Following the brief diversion, Arcana returns her focus to the president.

Arcana: Thy Foundation's hospitality hath grown cold, Mr. President.

President: Stay awhile. I promise things will get heated shortly.

Arcana: Heh. How enticing.

Arcana: Yet my aims have been met.

She raises a hand.

A seed falls from within her palm.

Arcana: As a token of courtesy, allow me to leave something behind for this young brood of the Pax House.

Arcana: Farewell, mortals.

White light shines from the floating room, making the Spire look like a lighthouse from a bygone era.

The radiance recedes, and the world takes back its contrast.

Marsha: It's gone. Have we won?

Regulus: Seems like that might have been the ticket. The air feels a bit lighter now, don't you think?

Druvis III: I'm concerned that might have something to do with the building collapsing around us. Everyone, onto the branches, please. I'll bring us down safely.

Secretary General: No need to panic. That's just the architect beginning her work.

"Leader": All units, gather at the entrance.

"Leader": The enemy is retreating. Eliminate any remaining Manus Vindictae forces inside the building.

The Pax House's guard soon restores order, and those still capable of fighting leave the office and prepare to retake the Committee Building.

As the room quiets, the Secretary General approaches her superior.

Secretary General: It's over, Mr. President. The creature has been eliminated.

Secretary General: Without Arcana's presence, the Manus army won't hold out for long.

On the floor before him lies a puddle of dark sludge.

President: One would expect more maturity from a god.

President: Did we learn anything regarding Arcana's power?

Secretary General: The Foundation held her back long enough for us to conduct a full assessment. The results align with our speculation.

Secretary General: She has dominion over the "channels" of pneuma in this world. In other words, she can control the very flow of arcanum itself.

President: That explains how she severed us from our powers.

Secretary General: Precisely. Now that communications have resumed, we've been able to reestablish contact with our field operatives. Ms. Stranger reports that she's discovered how Manus Vindictae breached our security.

President: Excellent. Send support to her immediately. Her safety is of extreme importance to our efforts.

Secretary General: I understand that she's already under the protection of a Flying Witch.

President: Good. We should count ourselves lucky. Had Arcana wished it, we would have suffered much greater losses.

Secretary General: A god cannot be killed by mortal hands.

Secretary General: Only slain by the hand of another.

President: ...

President: Do we know Vertin's status?

Secretary General: If I'm not mistaken, she intervened somehow. She challenged Arcana in this very room.

Secretary General: If not for her, the Core Guard might not have been able to breach the barrier.

President: Then we can worry about her later.

He turns toward the window.

President: The SPDM should be secured by now.

Assembly

小径

Excerpt from the New York Times

> Around midnight two days ago, a large fire broke out in the oak forest on the western outskirts. The delay of the warning and the complex terrains full of inflammables in the forest resulted in a fire that lasted a whole night till dawn and 13 deaths.
> The victims entered the forest at dusk. Identities of 6 of them have been confirmed: the Weyerhaeusers, their buyers Tomson Joyce, Shelley Gerald, Kelly Keith, and the project manager Russell James. The others' are still being verified.
>
> The Weyerhaeuser used to be a leader in the wood industry, yet it went bankrupt not long ago due to the wood supply crisis these years. After donating the formula of the Resurrection Potion (basic version) to the Maria Sanatorium in New York, the Sacred Heart Sanatorium in Ohio, and the Presbyterian Church Health Center on certain conditions, the Weyerhaeusers sold all of their forestry lands.
> On the night of the fire, the Weyerhaeusers, their buyers, and the workers went into the forest to start the disafforestation project before they died. The police has found traces of arcanist's activities and a small amount of gasoline at the scene, which shows the case is an arson attack. More investigations are needed to identify the suspect.
>
> Reporter: James Welles/Dorey Johnson

Blame Game

小径

A Disk Delivered by Air

> 153025Z The Guiding One has left. We should withdraw as well.
> 153101Z Do you hear the singing? It's Lyra.
> 153110Z Taira, put your blade away. Don't get drawn into the fight. İlmek, let's go.
> 153122Z Krutov, are you satisfied?
> 153130Z You're grinding your teeth too. You've got no room to talk.
> 153139Z Our objective is met. There's no point in lingering.
> 153141Z Don't let them learn the secret of the network.
> 153148Z Idiot! Moth already pulled intel from that useless Prima's head!
> 153152Z Let's move. Ustrina, don't be angry.
> 153200Z Is she brainless? Can't she just lock the room with her arcane skill?

Wishing for Peace

13TH-22

Wishing for Peace

Countdown to the "Storm"

Countdown to the "Storm"

...

Time and fate ceaselessly intertwine.

Time is a metaphor for fate.

The past is dead and gone. The present is but a fleeting moment trapped within a tiny crevice. And the future ...

Vertin: And the future revealed itself before me.

Vertin: ...

Sonetto: Can you hear me, Timekeeper?

Vertin: I ... Sonetto?

Sonetto: Timekeeper, I'm here.

Golden threads coil all around. All sense of direction is lost.

Reach out a hand and—

Sonetto: I've got you.

Ms. Stranger: The jumbled timeline contracts, and a familiar starting place takes form.

Sonetto: What just happened? What did you see in there?

Vertin: We did it, Sonetto.

Sonetto: Did what?

Vertin: Arcana has retreated.

Sonetto: You confronted her in there?

Vertin: She spoke to me. She said, "Welcome back."

Vertin: I tried to dispel the mist around her, but then she just disappeared.

Vertin: It doesn't feel right. I don't understand what I did.

Sonetto: We'll figure it out some day. Whatever you did, it must have been powerful.

Vertin: Yes, we can figure things out later. Let's just find a way back first.

Vertin: Do you know where we are?

Sonetto: I think we're back in the library. This is the same study room we left before going to the central tower.

Sonetto: Hm?

Images and sounds flood in from all directions, condensing and taking a new shape. And in that space, a gleaming silhouette manifests.

Sonetto: What's that?

She hears a familiar voice.

"It's an item Igor gave me during the Don Operation."

"It's possible that it could generate an immunity zone. But ..."

Sonetto: ...!

Sonetto: It's us, Timekeeper, and Merel, back when we were discussing whether to open the "boon."

Vertin: Then, they're about to ...

Just as expected, the dark gate appears once more.

Sonetto: They're going through the gate, or we are.

Vertin: I know how to get out. Sonetto, lead me to the gate.

Sonetto: Right. Stay close.

But the gate seems to exert a powerful repulsive force.

Vertin: It won't open from this side. Just as I thought.

Vertin: The gate can only be opened from the other side. Someone has to come in first.

Vertin: Come in, Sonetto. Vertin, you have to bring Sonetto with you.

At first, it isn't clear whether the voice can travel through the gate, but then, memories provide an answer.

Sonetto: We're just about to enter through the gate.

Vertin: Which means we need to leave at the same time.

Sonetto: I'm ready.

She waits until the very moment that past and future converge.

"We meet here again before the 'Storm.' And whatever happens, we move forward together."

"Mhm. I promise."

"It's time. Let's go, Sonetto."

Sonetto: Now, Timekeeper!

Past and present selves brush shoulders. The loop is closed.

Dust appears and sweeps everything away once more. Darkness and silence flood all senses.

Vertin: Sonetto?

Sonetto: I'm here. We're back to our real ages. How's your eyesight, Timekeeper?

Vertin: I can see again. It seems we've made it back to reality.

Sonetto: Finally!

The dark gate at the center of the room disappears, and in its place, shrunk down to its original form, appears the floating black box.

Vertin: But there's only three minutes left before the "Storm."

Lavender: Ah, Ms. Vertin, Ms. Sonetto!

Vertin: Lavender?

Lavender: I heard voices. Thank goodness you're back.

Vertin: How's everything in the library? Is everyone alright?

Lavender: For now ...

Lavender walks out toward the main hall.

The students are huddled in the book storage area outside the study room.

Emilia: The Doves aren't glowing so much anymore.

Yet they guard them in silence all the same.

They've brought Matilda here, too. A Shelter Dove casts a faint glow on her still-unconscious form.

Lavender: The immunity zone has shrunk so far that it doesn't cover the library anymore. We'd all have been doomed if these two students hadn't brought us these backup Shelter Doves.

Lavender: They said Ms. Merel was the one who got them.

Lavender: But the Doves may not last long. Without them ...

Vertin: Things will be alright now, Lavender.

Vertin: I've found a shelter strong enough for all of us.

Merel: ...

This isn't the first time she's seen the "Storm" as it arrives.

But there's something different this time. As the world shatters before her eyes, she's without a safe place to hide or an Equilibrium Umbrella.

Merel: The rain ... It's rising.

The wave of adrenaline is receding. Her wounded legs cry out their refusal in her sprint between her and the library.

Merel: Heh heh!

Merel: Who? Who's there?

Merel: Vertin and Sonetto made it.

Merel: We're going to be okay. Come on.

Merel: They made it? But ...

Merel: But what? They can save everyone, us included. Come! Come!

Merel: I can't go any further.

Merel: The reverse has already started. It's too late.

Merel: I'm just hallucinating. You're not real. This must be the Storm Syndrome.

Merel: Don't give up now, Merel.

Merel: You can make it. Just give it everything. If you do, we all live.

Merel: Look.

Merel: ...

She forces her head up. The rain swirls everything into a blur, but she makes out buildings burning and trees, walls—even the sky itself—being ripped apart.

Yet part of the library doesn't yield. She sees light pouring out from the doors and windows.

Merel: It's so far.

Merel: This is where I failed my first PE test. I just couldn't reach the end of the track in time.

Merel: But you've grown up. You're not that little girl anymore.

Merel: Come on, Merel. Move your feet.

Merel: ...!

Lavender: Everyone, stay together. Don't leave the light.

Lavender: Gather around Ms. Vertin.

Vertin: Merel?

Vertin: Where's Merel?

Merel?: Keep going. Just a little more.

Merel: ...

Merel?: It's so close. We can make it.

Merel?: We still have a promise to keep. Remember?

Merel: Vertin ... Sonetto ...

Vertin: Is that Merel?

Merel: Just a little bit closer.

Merel: I don't want to go.

Merel: Don't leave me, Vert—

Vertin: Merel! No!

Pure White Folder

小径

A Hint of Unease

Arcana Invasion Assessment Report

The following is a strategic analysis and operational assessment of the recent Arcana invasion:

I. Assessment of Strategic Intent
Arcana's invasion was not aimed at territorial or resource expansion—it was a strategic probe. Her core intentions are assessed as follows:
1. To draw out the Pax House and force it to expose its operational movements under pressure.
2. To test the Core Guard's combat effectiveness and collect critical data on our core security forces.

II. Current Situation and Response Assessment
The Core Guard has demonstrated loyalty and effectiveness, but its premature entry into direct combat has resulted in the following consequences:
1. Our strategic cards were shown too early—the Core Guard's true capabilities and tactical characteristics may now be known to the enemy.
2. Strategic initiative has been partially ceded. We will face targeted countermeasures going forward, while the enemy still holds options in reserve.

III. Conclusions and Recommendations
This confrontation has allowed Arcana to partially achieve her strategic objectives. We recommend the following:
1. Reassess the threshold for deploying the Core Guard to avoid depleting strategic reserves in response to low-cost probes.
2. Apply tactical deception and upgrades to the Core Guard—projecting a false profile alongside the real one to mislead the enemy.
3. Establish a tiered response framework that clearly defines the escalation order of the Foundation's defense forces, Zeno forces, and the Core Guard.
...

Peace and Loss

13TH-23

Peace and Loss

Matilda: ...

Matilda: ...

The ceiling hangs overhead like the cold sky on a winter's day.

Yet her body, gently cocooned in blankets, feels warm.

Matilda: ...!

Ward, Rehab Center

Matilda: Where-Where am I? Merel?

Just as Mama foretold, she wakes at a time long since set in stone.

Vertin: Matilda, you're awake.

Matilda: Vertin, Sonetto? Wh-What are you doing here?

Vertin: Madame Bouanich predicted you'd wake up sometime today, so we thought we'd drop by. I'm sure you want to hear about the school.

Matilda: Mama is here? No, then the "Storm" has passed? The school—

She grimaces from a piercing pain in her brow.

Sonetto: The students are safe. Most of them made it through.

Matilda: "Most"? And Merel?

Vertin: *sigh* We'll talk more once you're feeling better.

Matilda: I'm perfectly fi—ah.

Vertin: You need to rest. Just lie down for now. Your mother will be here soon.

Matilda: How long has she been back at headquarters?

Sonetto: She came as soon as the "Storm" ended. She barely left your side up until now.

Sonetto: The Foundation needed her for some paperwork. She should be back any moment.

Sonetto: She brought you a new crystal orb to replace the one you lost during the fight.

Matilda: Hngh.

She tries to turn to look at the gift at her bedside, but the neck brace denies her.

Sonetto: Please, don't get up. The doctor said you need to rest for now.

Vertin: We've got a few more "get well" presents for you. Probably easier if we show them to you.

Choices

1. A Shelter Dove
2. Rider-Waite Tarot Cards
3. Super Chips with Zesty Salsa
4. End Conversation

Branch 1

Matilda: A Shelter Dove? Goodness! Th-That is not something you should just be carrying around like a toy.

Vertin: It's only a replica the students made. Plug it into a 230-volt outlet, and it lights up. More of a lamp than a shelter.

Vertin: Lavender brought it over when she came to visit. She said the students are all wishing you a quick recovery.

Matilda: A lamp? It-It looks so much like the real thing.

Choices

1. End Conversation
2. Continue

Return to the topic choices above

Branch 2

Matilda: ...

Vertin: Sonetto and I thought you'd appreciate this.

Matilda: Oh, my heart! You did this on purpose, just to tease me, no? Tell me you didn't forget what I actually use for divination.

Vertin: Of course not, which is precisely why we picked one with silly anecdotes on arcanum on the back.

Vertin: You can read it like a storybook.

Matilda: Hmph. Then I suppose it isn't all that bad.

Return to the topic choices above

Branch 3

Matilda: Super chips with zesty salsa? Don't tell me they're from—

Vertin: J? Yes. He went to great lengths to sneak them in.

Matilda: Chips? He's hopeless. What on earth must go through that big head of his?

Return to the topic choices above

Shared continuation

Matilda: Just leave the rest. I'll look through them myself once I can move a bit more easily. It shouldn't be more than a few days.

Matilda: Until then, I will lie here and think about how to repay their kindness, properly.

Vertin: Of course. We'll leave you to it.

Vertin: Laplace wants to see me as soon as possible. We'll visit again soon.

Letter of Appointment: "With heavy hearts, we announce the passing of Richard, Principal of the SPDM."

Letter of Appointment: "The Joint Committee of St. Pavlov Foundation has elected to appoint Zhāng Zhīzhī as Acting Principal until further arrangements can be made. This decision is effective immediately."

Letter of Appointment: "Her existing responsibilities will remain unchanged."

Z: ...

She takes a sip of her soon-to-be lukewarm tea. A scarlet berry dissolves in her mouth.

Constantine: You look as stunned as the day I named you chief of staff.

Constantine: You had that tea back then, too. Has it always been the same blend? Milkvetch, goji berries, ginseng? Or was it dong quai?

Z: The latter, along with a few other herbs. It was a gift from Black Ibis.

Z: Ma'am, forgive me for repeating what I said back then, but I fear I may not be the right person for the job.

Constantine: The SPDM has been asking for their principal to be put on the Joint Committee for a while now.

Constantine: This makes for a convenient workaround. We put a Committee member as their principal.

Z: With respect, ma'am, I haven't been involved in school affairs for years. Many will doubt the decision.

Constantine: I wouldn't be concerned about that. We've got more than enough justification to back this appointment.

Constantine: Had Vertin and Sonetto not uncovered the secret of the "boon," every student in that library would have been exposed to the "Storm." It's as sound a reason as any for you, their direct supervisor, to assume office.

Constantine: On top of that, Investigator Matilda placed herself in grave danger, and Ms. Merel gave her life protecting the students. The Timekeeper's team paid a heavy price to compensate for the school's failures. I am confident they will accept the matter with grace.

Z: Merel ... Merel Van der Veer.

Z: I only spoke to her once, before she left for Antarctica. She never seemed to want the spotlight.

She walks through her brief memories of their meeting, contemplating what she can say about the girl.

Z: She was happy just being an ordinary girl.

Constantine: Whether she'd have liked it or not, her name will be remembered by those students for the rest of their lives.

Constantine: Without her, the spare Doves would have never gotten to the library. Those kids would have been lost before the Timekeeper returned.

Constantine: The "Storm" Fallen Employees Archive will preserve her medal permanently.

Z: ...

Constantine: When you get to the school, the first priority will be reconstruction. Nearly its entire staff was wiped out. They'll be desperate for new blood.

Z: That sounds very much like the Foundation right now.

Z: We took our share of losses—experienced staff who had survived multiple "Storms," some went all the way back to before the first.

Z: Have you read Ms. Stranger's report, ma'am?

She lifts her cup again. It's cold.

Constantine: Yes. If you're curious how Manus Vindictae slipped its troops in here unnoticed, it was through something they call the "Windweave."

Constantine: Ms. Stranger discovered a portal and, within it, a gigantic beast thought to be the Manus troops' carrier. She believes someone inside the Foundation opened the portal and guided the Manus here.

Constantine: The captive ritualist's testimony supports this theory.

Z: But who was their accomplice inside the Foundation?

Hallway, Laplace

Medicine Pocket: Vekiĝu en la regno de mortemuloj.

Enigma: Slow down. What's the hurry? A dog chasing you or something?

Medicine Pocket: A dog? More like three Critters in a lab coat who keep yapping at me. We might as well throw the *Workplace Noise Regulations* straight in the trash.

Ulrich: In all fairness, Adler, you never specified the speed or cadence of the incantation—a flaw in our experiment protocol, I'd say. I thought you'd have established more stringent guidelines after the ninth "Storm."

Enigma: Ah, yes, how very helpful of you, Ulrich.

Laplace's scientists are on high alert, as usual.

Vertin: Mr. Enigma.

Enigma: Timekeeper, you've arrived at the perfect moment.

Vertin: Am I interrupting? Looks like you're experimenting with that incantation I learned from the "boon."

Enigma: Yes. We hear you haven't suffered any adverse effects from reciting the incantation. Quite the difference from the "first circle" situation.

Enigma: If we can decode the mechanics behind this incantation, we may be able to significantly improve the effectiveness of our anti-"Storm" equipment.

Pointer: Yes, provided the incantation actually works.

Pointer: After our Awakened colleagues confirmed the incantation's harmlessness on them, we gathered subjects of every race we could find at Laplace: human, arcanist, even artificial intelligence.

Medicine Pocket: These dorks even tried to find a "female arcanist of the Timekeeper's age" in an attempt to control the variables. Ha, like that would ever work.

Medicine Pocket: I told you, didn't I? Vertin's one of a kind!

Enigma: As you can see, Timekeeper, we need your assistance. Could you please recite the incantation while connected to our energy monitoring systems?

Vertin: How do I connect to your system? Do I need to wear a monitoring device?

Ulrich: No need. The systems in this hallway have already linked up to you.

Vertin: I see.

Vertin: ...

Vertin: Vekiĝu en la regno de mortemuloj.

The clamor of the Laplace hallway drowns the voice out.

Perhaps it's due to the lack of the "boon" as a medium, or perhaps it's due to the "Storm's" environmental factors, but ...

Vertin: Nothing's happened.

Constantine: This is it.

Z: ...

The Committee members look out over Building 5.

Warning tape blocks access to the once normal building. Only select staff members donning protective gear are permitted entry.

Operation Team Leader I: Keep clear. Building 5 is temporarily closed. Authorized personnel only.

Constantine: This is where the largest breach occurred. Of course, all traces of the portal are gone now. Ms. Stranger sealed it completely.

They look up at the crumbling tower, standing tall at the center of a vacuum sealed off by a cordon.

An arcanist architect has stabilized it, but the loose rubble still falls from time to time.

Constantine: Ms. Cornerstone is overseeing the building's repairs. But the greater concern right now is our looming staff shortage.

Constantine: It seems that we have no choice but to keep expanding admissions. The Resolution must stay in effect.

Z: But, didn't you say it was the cause of this incident?

Constantine: Yes. The Resolution undoubtedly intensified the long-lasting resentment against our refugee policy. Many were upset by our decision, and it seems that agitation escalated into treason.

Constantine: The Foundation has always had to make difficult decisions in regard to who we grant refuge to. Every one of us has been forced to watch family and friends perish in the "Storm."

Constantine: Even among those we do save, many join us unaware of the true ramifications of the "Storm" and the devastation that comes with it.

Z: But in this last era, Manus Vindictae revealed the existence of the "Storm" to a larger population than ever before. Once we passed the Resolution, it was all but certain that we would be flooded with refugees.

Constantine: And yet we couldn't let them all in. It wasn't fair, of course, but fairness isn't a luxury we can afford.

Constantine: No matter how much we expand, we still can't shelter everyone.

Z: Then do you believe this was done in retaliation to the Foundation's strict admission policy?

Constantine: It isn't quite that simple. The staff involved seemed to be acting out of conscience, not resentment. They thought, for whatever reason, that they were doing the right thing.

Constantine: These are wounded, traumatized people, tormented for years by the grief and anxiety of living out of their own time.

Constantine: When they saw the desperate crowd outside the gates, they could only think of their own friends and families.

Constantine: Lyra saw her chance and took advantage of their sympathy.

Constantine: She promised them a way to save more people. If they helped create a passage bypassing Foundation security, all those waiting outside could take refuge from the "Storm."

Z: None of them expected Arcana would be the one coming through that portal.

Constantine: No. They never meant for this to happen. But good intentions can still lead to catastrophe.

The politicians fall silent. Who would be fit to judge them by their intentions?

Z: So, what do we do with them?

Constantine: What would you do if it were your decision?

Z: Given the number of people involved, strict punishment would only further destabilize our already fragile situation.

Z: Perhaps we can give them a chance to make it right: send them into the field to go after Lyra and investigate this "Windweave."

Z: They've already paid dearly for their actions. I doubt anyone will fall for her words again.

Z: Moreover, they've had firsthand experience with the "Windweave." At this moment, there's unlikely anyone more suitable than them to look for it.

Constantine: I'll take it under consideration. It may well be the most practical solution, and I'm sure the court will agree.

Z: I have two direct requests from Vertin: one asking permission to return to her field duties, and the other is about Ms. Stranger.

Z: But, since she belongs to the Secondary Defense Program, it falls outside my authority to make the decision.

Z: The Timekeeper wants Ms. Stranger to be released from all her current duties and put under her team.

Z: Ms. Stranger has explicitly stated that she has no desire to restore her Phototaxis and wishes to keep all her current memories. She hasn't decided on the other aspects of her work yet.

Constantine: Let her keep them. To have rejected the mask and survived—that alone proves her loyalty.

Z: What about her other requests?

Constantine: You're asking me to give up the program's strongest asset.

Z: ...

Constantine doesn't continue her questioning. She pauses, reflecting on her subordinate's reply.

Constantine: ...

Constantine: I thought she'd prefer to forget it all.

Her Reward

13TH-24

Her Reward

The Committee Building's southern garden has, for the most part, been restored to its pre-battle state.

The occasional staff members hurry across it, sending shivers down the branches of the newly planted saplings.

Vertin: They've already finished rebuilding here.

Ms. Stranger: The garden was easy. All it took was transplanting a few plants. I hear the gardeners have been enjoying experimenting with the local flora from the new era.

Ms. Stranger: But that can't be said for everywhere. Building 5 will take some time.

Vertin: I've heard the Foundation is borrowing offices from Laplace just to keep things running.

Ms. Stranger: Yes. A development I doubt Laplace is thrilled with—giving up office space and facing a near-certain budget cut next season.

She smiles genuinely, no longer hindered by double meanings hanging off the corners of her lips.

Vertin: Oh. I remember you mentioned you were looking for ideas for a new name? Any luck so far?

Ms. Stranger: I was flipping through one of those baby name books earlier. I found a few contenders, but I couldn't decide.

Choices

1. Something elegant is best.

2. Something simple is best.

3. Do you have any preference?

Branch 1

Ms. Stranger: Hmm, like Astrid, Seraphine, Eleonora, or Ingrid.

Ms. Stranger: They all sound lovely, if a little over the top.

Branch 2

Ms. Stranger: Like Alva, Ísól, Ella?

Ms. Stranger: But none of them feel like me. I suppose I have a right to be picky this time.

Branch 3

Ms. Stranger: They're all nice, I suppose, with deep meaning and presence. I just don't know which suits me best.

Shared continuation

Ms. Stranger: In a way, the idea of having a new name is kind of strange, exciting, but frightening at the same time.

Ms. Stranger: And I worry there isn't any kind of name that will ever feel right.

Ms. Stranger: Perhaps I'll stay a stranger. A stranger can be anyone, after all.

Vertin: ...

Ms. Stranger: What is it, Vertin?

Vertin: Oh. Nothing. I just sensed something different about you.

Ms. Stranger: Something wrong, you mean?

Vertin: No. Quite the opposite. You seem more alive than ever.

Ms. Stranger: ...

She averts her eyes only to catch Madam Z's approach.

Z: Leaving already?

Vertin: Yes, ma'am. There's no use waiting around here. We should head out and explore the era.

Z: On the topic of exploring, you never said what you were hoping to find.

Vertin: Merel.

Vertin: I've seen so many people vanish in the "Storm," but this time it was different. I saw a golden thread just before she disappeared.

Z: You have my permission to head out. But we must talk more on that when you have time.

Ms. Stranger decides to insert herself into the conversation.

Ms. Stranger: Madam Z, is there any news about my application?

She raises this question with some anxiety.

Z: Yes. The vice president and I have spoken.

Ms. Stranger: ...

Z: Considering the sensitivity of your role in the Foundation, if you leave your post, your record here must be entirely erased.

Z: All your past achievements and contributions will be expunged from our records, including the sacrifice you made in closing the "Windweave" portal.

Ms. Stranger: That all means nothing to me.

She senses some room for negotiation in Madam Z's tone and broaches the topic with a spark of hope.

Ms. Stranger: After everything I've done for the Foundation, this is the only thing I want in return.

Z: You do understand the Timekeeper's team is still part of the Foundation? Vertin reports to me.

Ms. Stranger: Of course. I don't expect to be cut loose entirely. Working with the Timekeeper is more than enough.

Ms. Stranger: I just want to live my own life, as an arcanist under the Timekeeper.

Z: I see.

Z: Then it's settled. From this day on, you're a member of Team Timekeeper.

Ms. Stranger: ...

Vertin: Thank you, Madam Z.

Z: I'm not in a position to speak on behalf of the Foundation, Ms. Stranger.

Z: But if only for myself, I'll never forget what you did for us.

Creius: Gone? All of them?

Irinei: I'm afraid so.

Irinei sinks into his seat, avoiding matching his eyes with Creius's.

Irinei: The First Squad never reached the school and hasn't returned since.

Irinei: There's been no sign of them since their last report before the "Storm." The entire convoy just vanished.

Creius: And my squad?

Irinei: Gone too.

Irinei: Our preliminary reports suggest they encountered an ambush in the mountain pass and that Igor's troops were present. It's possible they were captured. That, or they defected.

Creius: Igor ... I have to go after them.

Irinei turns his head, at last willing to look at him.

Irinei: The Foundation has postponed your trial, Creius, given your prompt response during the attack and, frankly, the Foundation's manpower shortage.

Irinei: The Committee has also decided to sustain your command of the "XII" Squad. Though at present, it only consists of your medic.

Irinei: We leave you to your discretion to plan your next move, which might include, for instance, searching for the rest of your team.

Creius: Don't say it like you're doing me a favor. This was a part of our deal.

Creius: I take the blame. You keep me free.

Irinei: Of course. It's all reciprocity.

Irinei: One more thing: Our tracking devices haven't been able to locate our "subjects" in this era.

Irinei: In other words, the tracking serum has failed. And it appears the vessel ensoulment reagent didn't work on your rookie either.

Irinei: The Timekeeper is setting out soon. She seems confident she can find Merel.

Creius: The Timekeeper has ways to locate her even without the tracking serum?

Irinei: Her abilities are far from ordinary. You should know that by now.

He shakes his head. Creius sees the gesture for what it truly is: nerves.

Irinei: Listen. You're at liberty to search for your soldiers however you like, but you must remain on the tracking serum project.

Creius: I aim to do precisely that. I never leave a soldier behind. In the meantime, I'll try to make contact with the Timekeeper—

Irinei: You may want to reconsider that, Creius. She's unlikely to be an ally in our goals.

The board has been reset. A new game has begun.

Creius: The attack may have thrown us off stride, but we'll regain control within the Foundation before long.

Creius: If the Timekeeper won't work with us, then we proceed in our own way.

Memorial Service

小径

It seems that just about everyone has accepted that death must inevitably follow the rain.

But not you. How many loved ones have you lost? You keep count, don't you?

The same tragedy has played out over and over again ever since your "Acting Principal" first brought you into that stark gray building. Do you really think anything can be done for them?

Choices

1. This will be the last time

2. They're still alive somewhere

Branch 1

It won't—not yet; this isn't the last golden thread you'll follow. More will come. More upon more until you can't see anything else.

Then you'll wind up just as blind as she was …

But I don't say that to scare you. You're lucky. Someone will always be there to show you the way.

Branch 2

I've said it before: anyone who has forgotten their own name is as good as dead.

But that might not always be the case, if that's any comfort.

It's far easier to help someone remember what they've once forgotten than it is to bring the dead back to life.

But that just means the burden on your shoulders is all the heavier.

You'll carry that weight until it breaks you. So, why not just save the world instead?

Dead or alive—drag them all into that magical Suitcase. It'll save you some trouble, and you'll get to be the savior you've always wanted to be.

But if you can't save them all, the least you can do is remember their names for them.

The rain has fallen on some more than others; each time it washes something away. In the end, who they are and who they become will be up to you.

Shared continuation

Memorial Service

Ambush Strategy

小径

Investigation Report from Ms. Stranger

[Top Secret|Authorized by the Pre-Storm Dispatch Center & Ad Hoc Investigation Committee]
[Case ID: ■■■-■■-■■■■]
[Date: ■-■-■]

Case Briefing and Jurisdiction Statement

This report documents the attack carried out by Manus Vindictae (hereafter "the Attacker")

against Foundation headquarters and the SPDM (hereafter "the Targets") prior to the 11th "Storm." The investigation was conducted by the Pre-Storm Dispatch Center and the Ad Hoc Investigation Committee under the relevant clauses of the Emergency Defense Code of St. Pavlov Foundation to analyze and determine the attack's route of entry and the cause of the internal defense's collapse.

...

III. Attack Method and Scene Reconstruction

The Attacker used an unregistered arcane array (technical codename: "Windweave") to bypass all surveillance and defensive measures at the target site, striking directly at the facility's interior.

Phase 1: A small advance unit led by "Lyra" arrived at the target site and began infiltration, lowering the guard of personnel inside through the following means:

1. False Support: A Manus Vindictae member (suspected to be "Lyra") used a false identity to approach multiple Foundation members and their close contacts, earning their trust. During the "Storm" countdown, she successfully manipulated several headquarters staff and individuals with prior refugee experience into following her instructions and opening access to the facility. Manus Vindictae members also used arcane skills to attack the personnel and facilities of the defense surveillance department, rendering the surveillance systems inoperative.

2. Defense Breach: Under arcane control by Manus Vindictae, captured personnel were turned and used as inside operatives, guiding the Attacker past the main defensive network and destroying the base defense systems, weapons stocks, and alarm systems.

3. Temporary Line: The advance unit and inside operatives set up the "Windweave" array within the target interior, completing preparations for the second wave of attack. Once the array was in place, the main force of Manus Vindictae arrived at the target ...

...

IV. Witness Testimony and Evidence Record

Witness #09 Testimony (Engineering Department, Senior Researcher): "I saw Nancy Sur standing in the doorway. It wasn't her shift, so I went over to ask about it. She started saying things like, 'Such beautiful weather, and yet we're still here—history really did get it wrong,' and 'Rewrite the score, sound the anthem, welcome humanity's rebirth' ..."

Witness #47 Testimony (Human Resources Department, Clerk): "These traitors were among the finest when it came to justice and order ... but then again, maybe that's why they'd rather admit they were guilty than admit that surviving was just luck."

...

The Legendary Hermitage

13TH-25

The Legendary Hermitage

Tylwyth Teg Berry Garden

Sonetto: "... They've lived in the orchards for generations, sharing their homes with rare, bird-like Critters and mostly keeping to themselves."

Sonetto: "Each of them grows up with a companion Critter and speaks their language."

Sonetto: "Their elders rule the area, and the young are driven out upon reaching adulthood."

Sonetto: ...

Sonetto raises her eyes up from her files. A breeze brings along the gentle scent of fresh grass.

Sonetto: That's all we gathered from the inn last night. How reliable do you think these accounts are, Timekeeper?

Vertin: Reliable or otherwise, they're the only leads we've got.

Vertin: We've visited every town nearby and come up empty. This bit of folklore could be our last chance.

Sonetto: Even if it is true, their territory is very likely protected by a ritual that prevents outside interference.

Vertin: Not to worry. I think I know a way in.

Vertin: Come, Sonetto. Follow me.

A Youthful Chirp: Hoo!

???: Shh!

???: They'll hear us. We don't even know whether they're friendly. What if they're hunting for you?

A Youthful Chirp: Hoo ...

???: Hm. I admit they're overdressed for hunters—fine fabrics and all. Oh, that one's just caught her coat in the briar patch.

???: But how did these fancy ladies get past the barrier, Bechan? What could they want here?

Sonetto: Please stay still, Timekeeper.

She crouches down and uses her glasfeder again to hold the large flytrap mouth open.

The leaves' razor-sharp teeth gnaw at her tool, completely ignoring the fingers prying the coattail from its clutches.

Vertin: Thank you. I suppose this plant has a penchant for altering clothes.

Vertin: These are no ordinary brambles.

Sonetto: ...

She inspects her glass instrument under the sunlight. Unfortunately, the plant's teeth left visible bite marks on its translucent surface.

Sonetto: It looks like a carnivorous plant, but there are no remains of any prey—only berries wrapped inside the leaves. If I'm not mistaken, these are Tylwyth Teg Berries. I read about them in *Common Arcane Plants of Wales*.

Sonetto: Apparently, eating these berries grants arcanists Tylwyth Teg sight, allowing them to find the Impossible Garden. These plants were declared extinct before the first "Storm."

Sonetto: But, since we're now in 1935, here we are looking right at it.

Vertin: Tylwyth Teg sight? I suppose that's reason enough to give it a try.

Sonetto: Timekeeper, perhaps it's best we don't ...

Vertin: You'd have stopped me by now if the book said they're poisonous. I think we can live a little.

???: ...!

???: She's eating the berries!

A Youthful Chirp: Grr ... Gah!

???: No, wait. I'll handle this. Stay—hey!

A furious shriek pierces her ears. Then, a fierce gale sweeps across the orchard, forcing the shrubs in its path to bow.

???: Bechan! Get back here!

Sonetto: Who's there? Timekeeper, watch out!

???: No! Don't hurt her!

Bechan: Coo!

???: Erhm! Swifto Stoney!

The mispronunciation prevents her arcane skill from taking full effect. The strange bird reveals itself and descends upon the intruders' feet, pecking and biting at their shoes.

Rhiannon: Hey, you! Stop her! That plant bites!

Rhiannon: And watch out for my little friend! She may be small, but she charges like a boar!

Vertin: ...

Sonetto: Stono Swift!

With the gray bird now encased in stone, its caretaker scrambles over. She gently lifts it up and, as she pets it, dispels the petrification incantation.

The bird calms, and the clamor ceases.

???: Sorry, sorry. She's a greedy guts, this one, always protective of her food.

???: You ...

???: Errr. Did I actually hit you with that petrifying incantation? Why are you staring at me like that?

Vertin: We're fine. Sorry. Just a little shaken.

Though the golden thread twisting within her is familiar, it's been woven into something new—a stranger.

Vertin: I'm the Timekeeper of the St. Pavlov Foundation, and this is Sonetto, my assistant.

Vertin: And you are ...?

???: The Foundation? What are your people doing out here?

Rhiannon: Oh, er, right, aha, you can call me Rhiannon.

Vertin: Rhiannon ...

Sonetto: ...

Sonetto tries to break the silence, but she can't, not as she looks over this person at once so familiar and so different.

Vertin: We're very sorry for the intrusion, Ms. Rhiannon. My assistant and I have been searching for a lost friend.

Rhiannon: Ah, well, I'm afraid you aren't likely to find her here. I haven't seen any strangers around in ages, and Mam's never mentioned anyone either. I'm sorry, miss ...

Vertin: Please, call me Vertin.

Rhiannon: Ms. Vertin.

Vertin: Just Vertin is fine.

Rhiannon: Vertin. I see. Then I insist you stop calling me "Ms." as well.

Rhiannon looks the messy pair of intruders over.

Rhiannon: Well, I can't have you leave with those wounds untended. Please, follow me.

Hermitage Hut

They arrive at Rhiannon's less-than-tidy abode.

Potion ingredients, books of incantations, a nest woven with vines, and winter bedding—an attempt at maintaining a balanced life amid all the world's chaos.

Rhiannon: Sorry about the mess. These little rascals are quite a handful.

Rhiannon: It's near impossible to keep them all in line when Mam's gone.

Sonetto: Mam? Your mother lives here as well?

She digs through a mountain of arcane ingredients, trying to find something among the vials of bat wings, toad skins, and rabbit's feet.

Rhiannon: That she does. Mam was the finest witch in all of Perthshire before we came here, a walking encyclopedia of arcane knowledge. If only she were here now. She could heal you with just a breath.

Rhiannon: Aha! There it is.

She pops the cork of a glass bottle containing a root-fiber brew. Its pungent odor wafts out, causing the fledgling on her shoulder to hop down with a caw.

Rhiannon: Shoo! Away, Bechan! That's not for drinking, you little rascal. Off you trot. Play somewhere else.

Bechan grumbles and ruffles her feathers, indignantly burying her beak in her chest.

Sonetto: I've never seen a bird so clever.

Rhiannon: She's an Adar Llwch Gwin. Not many of them around these days.

Sadness crosses her face for a moment, but she remembers her guests and shoos the negativity away.

She dips a piece of cloth into the pungent potion and begins tending to the still-bleeding wounds.

Vertin: Ugh.

Rhiannon: You know, you're not from around here, and you aren't one of Mam's guests, either, so I really shouldn't have let you in. But I feel terrible that Bechan hurt you like that.

Vertin: No need to worry. I've been through worse. Much worse, actually.

Rhiannon: Do you get hurt often?

Vertin: Our work keeps us traveling constantly, like now. If you stay on the road long enough, a bit of wear and tear is inevitable.

Rhiannon: Traveling? Just the two of you?

Vertin: Not just us. But Sonetto and I always travel together.

The scratches have stopped bleeding, leaving only a faint mark behind.

Vertin: What about you? Do you travel much?

Rhiannon: A little. But nothing like what you must do.

Vertin: Have you ever thought about it?

Rhiannon: Huh? Oh, errr.

The sudden question causes the fledgling on her wand to turn its head. Their eyes widen.

Rhiannon: No, I couldn't. I have to stay here at home and help Mam. Plus, the little ones need looking after. And then there's the orchard.

Rhiannon: I'd rather stay here with them, really. Watching these little rascals grow up ... it's a real treasure.

She fiddles with the fledgling's feathers, allowing herself a contented smile.

Vertin: I see.

The Suitcase is picked up.

Vertin: We should probably get going. Once again, we're sorry for disturbing you.

Rhiannon: Oh, don't you worry a thing about it. You aren't our first uninvited guests.

Vertin: It's been a pleasure. But we should probably get back to looking for our friend.

Vertin: Sonetto, let's go.

Sonetto: Timekeeper ...

Sonetto wants to say something, but ultimately, she chooses silence. Rhiannon isn't the classmate she remembers.

That classmate who would bury her face in her collar, the classmate who was always in trouble over her poor grades yet spent most of her free time reading books from the library—

The rain had dissolved that girl. She was gone, and what was left was only memories.

They exit the secluded abode.

Rhiannon: I've got the defense ritual up and running again. Stick to the calcite path, and it'll lead you safely out.

They do as she says, taking care to avoid stepping on the chirping fledglings that hop across their path.

Sonetto: Thank you, Me—Rhiannon.

Vertin: Should you need anything from the Foundation in the future, or if you change your mind about traveling, feel free to reach out.

Vertin: Just stop by the nearest Foundation branch and tell them you're a friend of the Timekeeper, they'll know how to reach me.

Rhiannon stares wide-eyed and blinks, looking both unaccustomed to such kindness and somehow guilty.

Rhiannon: That's awfully kind of you. I'm really, really sorry.

Sonetto: What do you mean?

Rhiannon raises her wand toward her visitors. The bird perched atop it, alarmed, jumps down and seeks cover behind her feet.

Sonetto: What's going on?

Rhiannon: It's just ... This is the Adar Llwch Gwin's last safe nesting ground. They've been nearly hunted to extinction. I-I can't just let you leave.

Vertin: I assure you, we have no intention of revealing this place. Please, tell us what we can do to put your mind at ease.

Rhiannon: It's too great a risk. I'm so sorry.

She looks to the ground and mutters something to herself, but the flapping of an Adar Llwch Gwin's wings drowns out her words.

Rhiannon: After I wipe your memories, I'll take you straight to the railway station, I promise.

Rhiannon: It'll be better for you to forget me and everything here. It's safer for all of us.

Vertin: I won't—

Rhiannon: Dissolve into the—

Rhiannon: ...!

A cry accompanied by a powerful gust of wind interrupts her incantation.

Sonetto: What? What is that?

Glyndŵr: ...!

An enormous bird covered in lustrous feathers draws in the wind with his wings, causing the quivering grass and leaves to still.

He stares at the visitors with alert eyes, then turns his attention to Rhiannon.

Rhiannon: Glyndŵr? You're back!

Glyndŵr preens his feathers a bit, shaking a heavy bag from his back.

Rhiannon approaches him and kneels down. She hesitates, feeling a sudden anxiety about its contents, but she opens it anyway.

Rhiannon: What's that in your bag?

Rhiannon: Clothes, biscuits, chocolate spread, berry preserves, Sharpodonties ... and a letter?

Rhiannon: From Mam?

She looks up in disbelief.

Rhiannon: Hang on! She sent you here to kick me out?

Glyndŵr: ...

Even the newcomers can make out the helpless resignation on the bird's face.

Rhiannon: B-But why? What does she want me to do?

Her companion offers no answer.

Rhiannon: Don't tell me you're siding with her, Glyndŵr. Well, I say we're not going. I'm your bonded witch, aren't I?

Rhiannon: We've talked about this, remember? Forget all those silly things I said about adventures. I want to stay here with you and Mam and the birds!

Rhiannon: Oh, come now. Please don't do this. I wouldn't know what to do with myself journeying out there. Be reasonable!

Glyndŵr: *shriek*

Glyndŵr flaps his wings fiercely.

Rhiannon: Ah! Let me down!

He grips her cloak with his sharp talons and takes flight, bringing her up into the air with him.

Sonetto: Rhiannon!

Rhiannon: No, no, Sonetto! Put down your wand! He won't hurt me. He's family.

Vertin: They're heading north. Come on. We should follow them.

Rhiannon: I think he's taking me to the nearest town. Once you're out, head north. You can't miss it. I'll see you there!

Glyndŵr flies low with Rhiannon still in his grasp. Together, they soar off into the Welsh mountains beyond the Tylwyth Teg Berry garden.

Riposte
小径

The Opportunist and The Sticky Gum

A Loss of Civilization
小径

A Debriefing Meeting Record

Debriefing Record: Missing Items in the Display Room

I. Basic Information

This loss incident occurred in the headquarters display room and was triggered by uncontrollable factors, including the attack on headquarters. The affected items include one Italian portable typewriter from 1969, one set of 1980s disco music cassette tapes, one sword hilt of unknown age recovered from the lake bed of Snowdonia, and 42 era relics in total (see appendix "Lost Era Relics Inventory").

II. Timeline

Incident: During the attack, the display room was temporarily used as part of the defensive structure, serving as an emergency shelter and wartime storage facility. In the process, multiple areas of the display room sustained severe damage, and a section of the wall in the "1960s-1970s" exhibit collapsed.

Discovery: Following the attack, the logistics department carried out post-"Storm" cleanup in accordance with the "Storm" Clearing Protocol. During a subsequent review, the administrator cross-checked the era relics inventory and discovered that items were missing.

Response: That day, the administrator reviewed the arcane surveillance records and confirmed no entries related to lending, requisition, damage, or maintenance. The following day, investigators completed a preliminary value assessment and transferred the case to the internal debriefing process.

III. Cause Analysis

Logistics Department: Due to the lack of arcane value in the missing items, cleaning staff were less vigilant during the post-"Storm" cleanup process.

Arcanum Containment Department: The "Storm" Clearing Protocol lacks clear criteria for distinguishing between "era relics" and "historic debris."

Security Department: Manus Vindictae may have seized the opportunity to steal items during the attack.

Conclusion: The cause remains undetermined.

IV. Improvement Measures

Logistics Department: Strengthen the disposal prevention mechanism—for example, by establishing a "72-hour holding period"—and incorporate this case into the "Storm" Clearing Protocol.

Arcanum Containment Department: Strengthen the classification standards for the collection and put all non-arcane items in the display room under unified management.

Security Department: Strengthen the missing items tracking system and enhance security measures.

V. Recommendations

The tracking level for this batch of historical relics is classified as "Low." Arcane items (including those currently on loan and not yet returned) take priority.

Appendix: Lost Era Relics Inventory